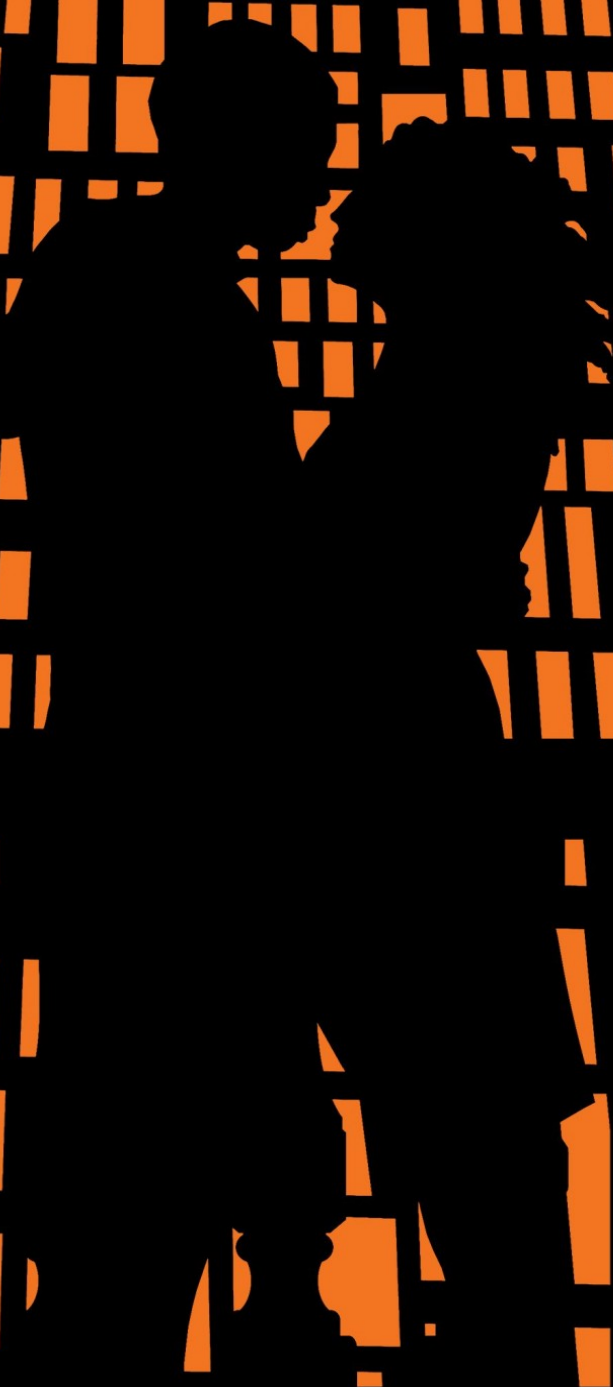


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[Goings On](#)

The Sartorial Riches of the Silent-Film Era

Also: the neo-soul of Erykah Badu, a festival of Indian classical dance, John Wilson's ode to concrete, and more.

By [Rachel Syme](#), [Dan Stahl](#), [Sheldon Pearce](#), [Marina Harss](#), [Brian Seibert](#), [Richard Brody](#), and [Taran Dugal](#)

September 11, 2026

[You're reading the Goings On newsletter, a guide to what we're watching, listening to, and doing this week. **Sign up to receive it in your inbox.**](#)

In today's world of rumbling, thunderous Dolby surround sound, the concept of silent cinema can feel very distant. Sure, you can catch a replay of “Metropolis” or “City Lights” every now and then at Film Forum—and you can listen to Karina Longworth’s excellent podcast about Hollywood history, “You Must Remember This”—but there are notably few other opportunities to dip one’s toes into the era before talkies arrived. As such, **[“Goddesses in the Machine: Fashion in American Silent Film,”](#)** a new exhibition opening on Sept. 18, at the Bard Graduate Center, on the Upper West Side, is a welcome event.



Pearl White, in "The Perils of Pauline."

Photograph from Everett

The show surveys the many fashion designers, including Lady Duff-Gordon, Lilian St. Cyr, Natacha Rambova, Travis Banton, and Salvatore Ferragamo, who brought their sartorial talents to the silent screen. It includes showings of several serial dramas from the nineteen-tens, including "The Perils of Pauline," from 1914; "The Whirl of Life," from 1915; and "The Mysterious Airman," from 1928, all with live accompaniment by the pianist Makia Matsumura. The costume designers for these movies made clothes that spoke loudly when leading ladies could not; there is a sumptuous drama to the pieces they created which echoes through time.—*Rachel Syme*



About Town

Off Broadway

“What they don’t tell you about Nashville, Tennessee / Is heartbreak’s the only thing they hand out for free,” an aspiring country singer-songwriter wails in “[Music City](#),” a toe-tappin’, hand-clappin’, tissue-dabbin’ humdinger of a show. If some of J. T. Harding’s tunes sound familiar, it’s because they were originally sung by the likes of Blake Shelton and Keith Urban. But they’ve been blessed with a book so smooth, by Peter Zinn, that they fit right into this story of three hardscrabble youngsters chasing country-music dreams at almost any cost. Clifton Chadick’s set plops you smack dab in the center of the action, at a table in a bar on open-mike night. With right fine actin’, singin’, playin’, or other carryin’ on by most everyone onstage.—*Dan Stahl (St. Luke’s Theatre; through Sept. 19.)*

Off Broadway

The magician Jamie Allan’s “[Amaze](#)” is a show for kids—and for adults who’d unironically describe themselves as “kids at heart.” As a critic at heart, I tired of Allan’s eager-beaver affect, though it has the advantage of putting audience participants at ease. His artful tricks are organized around a narrative of his development as a magician, from the Fisher-Price magic kit he got as a boy to a hybrid analog-digital sleight of hand that landed him on BBC One. But the razzle-dazzle pairs oddly with his earnestness, as do the video projections with antique furnishings. And what would Freud make of his wife performing alongside him in the “glamorous assistant” role he originally promised his mother?—*D.S. (New World Stages; open run.)*

Soul



Erykah Badu in 2025.

Photograph by Mairo Cinquetti / NurPhoto / AP

Long before “woke” was co-opted and turned into a dog whistle, it operated as a perfect word to describe the music and artistry of **Erykah Badu**. “I stay woke,” she sang on the 2008 song “Master Teacher,” using a term originally meant to characterize not just a greater level of social awareness but a state of being, as she put it, in alignment with nature. Both are core ideals for the neo-soul movement, of which she is a pioneer, whose sound is as earthy and robust as it is conscious. A well-known sage of modern blues and psychedelic R. & B., Badu continues her eternal vision quest on a new album with the prolific beat-making heavyweight the Alchemist, and both are joined in concert by the similarly woke-minded hip-hop group De La Soul.—*Sheldon Pearce* ([Forest Hills Stadium](#); Sept. 18.)

Dance

[Erasing Borders Dance Festival](#) encompasses a wide palette of Indian classical dance—officially, there are eight forms, but in reality there are

many more. Kuchipudi—light, airy, rhythmic—originated in Andhra Pradesh, where it was performed by men, as part of mythological dance dramas. Now it is mainly performed by women. Here, a kuchipudi solo by Sreelakshmy Kallungal Govardhanan, who moves with an almost feral power, displays dramatic abilities—central to kuchipudi—that transcend linguistic barriers. A trio led by Shila Mehta performs kathak, a more abstract dance style from the north; others perform odissi (from Odisha) and the swaying mohiniyattam (Kerala). There will even be a bit of contemporary dance, still based in South Asian technique, performed by Preeti Vasudevan.—*Marina Harss (Kaye Playhouse; Sept. 19-20.)*

Dance



Miami City Ballet performing “Roses from the South (Three Waltzes for Toby),” by Alexei Ratmansky.

Photograph from REN Media

This year’s iteration of City Center’s popular [Fall for Dance Festival](#) offers the standard mix of the promising and the poorly chosen, the not-so-familiar and the all-too. The most intriguing première comes from Robbie Fairchild, a former New York City Ballet star who has found success on Broadway and on the West End. His piece “Lord Chamberlain’s Men” finds an emotional backstory for the forbidden-love theme of “Romeo and Juliet” in the amatory sonnets that Shakespeare wrote to a young man. Other festival highlights include Juan Tomás de la Molía, an on-the-rise flamenco dancer of fresh musicality, and Miami City Ballet, with a new Alexei

Ratmansky piece set to Strauss waltzes.—*Brian Seibert (New York City Center; Sept. 22-Oct. 3.)*

Movies

Following the method of his HBO series “How To with John Wilson,” the Queens-based local explorer offers his first feature film, “**The History of Concrete,**” a warmhearted, wide-rangingly inquisitive documentary about the peculiar implications of the ubiquitous substance. It involves literal cinematic shoegaze—an encounter with a New York contractor who blasts away chewing-gum stains on a sidewalk—and takes Wilson to a primordial concrete road in small-town Ohio, a concrete convention in Las Vegas, and even the concrete-domed Pantheon in Rome. He ponders his own method, because his central theme is the emotional side of the material city, where a tight-knit group of runners pounds the pavement and a do-it-yourself repair job reminds him that even the intimacy of home involves a throng of connections.—*Richard Brody (Opening Sept. 18.)*



Bar Tab

Taran Dugal finds a confessional in a Chinatown paradise.



Illustration by Patricia Bolaños

The climb from Hell to Heaven can be long and arduous. Take Dante's, for instance. The man persevered through nine circles of inferno, sans electrolytes, only to find himself staring up at the mountain of Purgatory. *Merda!* And you thought your walkup was a trek. Luckily for those partygoers with forbidden-fruit predilections, **Gosh**, a new guest-list-only Chinatown club (accessible via e-mail), allows patrons a quicker ascent to Paradise, if they can stomach the snooty vibe. On a recent weekend, a group of friends congregated in the venue's basement, a narrow room with black leather couches and steel tables. Red neon tubes illuminated art works ranging from the disturbing (a black-and-white photograph of a person stuffing sausages in their mouth) to the mundane (a pastoral painting of a snowshoe-wearing rifleman). The friends ranked their drinks. The Sadomaso, a sharp fusion of Amaro Montenegro, mezcal, lemon, and sotol, placed last—far too bitter. Then came the Mirafiori, a golden, overly sweet mix of mezcal, crème de litchi, lime, and nasturtium. The Gin Basil Smash, an addictive blend of gin, lemon, sugar, and basil, topped the list. Simplicity was proportionate to success: the bar had a formidable Guinness on tap. Pints in hand, the group ascended to the ground level—an elegant Japanese-style parlor dotted with toadstool seats—but didn't stay in that purgatory long, instead heading to the top floor, a tentlike lounge enclosed by velvet curtains printed with a psychedelic pattern of dinosaurs, naked gnomes, and Babelian monoliths. Two members of the group stumbled through a

nondescript door nearby, and found a wood-panelled confessional, where an empty beer glass sat beside the divider. In this version of paradise, even angels have secrets, divulged, apparently, over a cold Irish stout.

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [“What Walls Are Good For,” by Dick Westheimer](#)
- [How to use the last of the season’s peaches](#)
- [The perfect combination](#)

[Rachel Syme](#) is a staff writer at The New Yorker. She has covered Hollywood, style, literature, music, and other cultural subjects since 2012.

[Dan Stahl](#) is a member of The New Yorker’s editorial staff.

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[Marina Harss](#) has been contributing dance coverage to The New Yorker since 2004. She is the author of “[The Boy from Kyiv: Alexei Ratmansky’s Life in Ballet](#).”

[Brian Seibert](#) has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2002. He is the author of “[What the Eye Hears: A History of Tap Dancing](#),” which won an Anisfield-Wolf Book Award. His writing appears in the New York Times and the New York Review of Books. A Guggenheim fellow, he teaches at Yale University.

[Richard Brody](#), a film critic, began writing for The New Yorker in 1999. He is the author of “[Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard](#).”

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[Photo Booth](#)

How a Skateboarder Sees Los Angeles

Jerry Hsu captures the city's manic extremes, with photographs of overturned cars, collisions, and a bank building ablaze.

By [Hua Hsu](#)

September 5, 2026



Photographs by Jerry Hsu

Jerry Hsu grew up in San Jose, about an hour south of San Francisco, and, for a time, he assumed he would never leave. He didn't need to. In the late nineties and two-thousands, Hsu and his daredevil friends had proudly put their sleepy Silicon Valley city on the map as an unlikely skateboarding capital. He noticed that young skateboarders from around the country were moving to San Jose, "and it had to do with my group of friends and these videos we were making," he told me. "It's like when a random city becomes very important for some random reason. We were able to have our slice of heaven."

The son of Taiwanese immigrants, Hsu was a precocious talent and became a professional skateboarder in his mid-teens. Magazines sent photographers to San Jose to shoot pictures of him, and he eventually became interested in their craft, what kind of gear they were using, the parallels between their

respective art forms. His mother would drive him to the local Barnes & Noble, where he grew fascinated with how [Nan Goldin](#) and [Larry Clark](#) chronicled the micro-scenes around them. (She also famously procured him a concrete parking block so that he could practice tricks at home.) As skateboard companies sent him around the world in his late teens and twenties, he began obsessively taking photographs of the strange, funny, often macabre things he came across, and publishing them on Tumblr or in *Vice* magazine.

In 2011, Hsu moved to Los Angeles, primarily for a relationship, and to further his career as a skateboarder. But he also felt a private excitement about spending time photographing a city “that was more rich with things I wanted to see.” With a body thrashed by occupational hazards, Hsu, who is forty-four, orients his life nowadays around running Sci-Fi Fantasy, his skate company, and roaming the city to take pictures. His latest book, “[How About Never](#),” is a brutal and wondrous chronicle of the sights he has sought out these past fifteen years.

It’s no surprise that a skateboarder, constantly scanning the landscape for surfaces to recontextualize, might see the world differently. Hsu’s photographs explore the city’s manic extremes. Some of them are quick visual gags: the symmetry of two discarded toilets stacked like yin and yang (or in a sixty-nine position) on the side of the street, a veiny sex toy that’s washed up in a brackish puddle. A triangular slab has fallen neatly out of a wall, as though it was too weary to go on. He notices signs of life where others might just perceive neglect, such as a flower bush sequestered behind a foreboding fence. One picture feels like a short story waiting to be written: a tree hollowed out by rot has been stuffed with roses by a neighbor who felt sorry for it. Hsu maps a Los Angeles of leftovers and castoffs; portraits of friends and strangers in the street are full of dazed, inscrutable expressions.

“My attraction to risk is ever present,” he explains. Hsu is the type of person who runs toward fire, as evidenced by pictures of overturned cars, collisions, a bank building ablaze. They manage to avoid feeling grimly voyeuristic. Instead, there’s a sense of stillness in these images, akin to that flash of calm after you’ve done something ruinous to your body but before

your brain registers pain or begins cycling through consequences. I was drawn to a picture of a smashed car windshield, the glass frozen in a series of circular ripples, until it began to resemble the vertical slit of a reptilian eye. It was still in mind a few pages later, as I studied how a young man's artificial eye seemed to match the orange shade of his hoodie.

My favorite picture in the book finds a sensibly blue Subaru station wagon that has somehow turned on its side in the middle of the night. There's something funny about its vanity license plate ("*4A POEM*") and the way the car's headlights shine brightly on a house in the distance, as if to point attention away from itself.

Hsu says that his ex-wife often remarked that he had a sixth sense for stumbling upon bizarre, uncanny scenes. Many of his images, even the faintly violent ones, possess an absurdist humor: in one, a motorist explains to a police officer why their Toyota has hopped the curb, but, from a distance, it almost looks like the sedan is playfully trying to return to its mates in a used-car lot. Hsu explained that he finds a lot of his subjects by using [Citizen](#), the incident-reporting app, to see if anything intriguing is happening nearby.

For all the book's darkness, there are pictures that feel sublime and vast. There are numerous pictures from the hills surrounding Los Angeles where you can't tell whether the city is on fire or merely aglow with energy. A suburban home like any other sits haloed by clouds, with California's placid skies a screen of infinite possibility. A picture of a cat vaulting from a gate to a fence takes on an outsized feeling of hope. "Maybe this is corny," Hsu explained to me, "but all this chaos and these little beautiful secrets I found here reminded me of myself. It was a mirror and threshold."

I first learned about Hsu in the early two-thousands. My younger cousin wound up skating at his house a few times and excitedly asked if we were related to him. Sadly, the answer was no. Admiring Hsu's twin careers taught me to see my own Silicon Valley suburb differently, even though I was someone who'd felt the urge to leave as soon as I could. I realized that I hadn't tried hard enough to appreciate all the beauty and weirdness that was actually available to me.

Where Hsu's early work was filled with the people in his life, his work over the past decade is marked by a kind of solitude. Some of "How About Never" feels uncomfortably intimate, from its opening image of a cake flower resting on a knife above a dingy sink to pictures of hospital rooms, scabs and bruises, his ex-wife resting her palms on the sink in their bathroom. Hsu says that he spent nearly ten years editing the book, and that he recently realized that it also tracks the dissolution of his marriage. As he put it, there's a private story of "hope, despair, all the feelings that are associated with trying to make a loving relationship happen" in how the images are sequenced.

Hsu spoke to me from his home in Los Angeles, and at one point, he angled his laptop to show me a shelf full of negatives and contact sheets, and hard drives of digital photos. His archives contain nearly every picture he's taken in the past twenty-five years, even random things he texts to his friends. He rarely deletes pictures from his phone, thinking that even the imperfect shots might be meaningful to him someday. It reminded me of the famous series of home movies that Hsu made of himself, as a teen-ager, practicing tricks in his parents' garage. The result of all those hours of practice was a style of effortless cool. Yet he felt compelled to keep a record of all the failures and misses along the way. "Maybe because I have this type of vision, it really takes away from another type that's more practical," he said, laughing. A few minutes after we hung up, he got an alert on his phone: a car had just flipped over in Koreatown. ♦

[Hua Hsu](#) is a staff writer at The New Yorker and the author of the Pulitzer Prize-winning memoir "[Stay True](#)." He teaches at Bard College.

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The Talk of the Town

- [**How to Protect Democracy**](#)

By Joshua Yaffa | The emergence of Germany's far right as a political force represents an old dilemma.

- [**Ric Burns, N.Y.C. Optimist**](#)

By Eric Lach | The director—and brother of Ken Burns—is releasing two new episodes of his long-running “New York: A Documentary Film,” this time covering Superstorm Sandy, COVID, and Eric Adams.

- [**Ke Huy Quan Keeps Smiling**](#)

By Sarah Larson | On a trip to Liberty Island, the actor chats about his new memoir, “Never Say Die,” which chronicles his journey from refugee to child star in “Indiana Jones” to winning an Oscar, for “Everything Everywhere All at Once.”

- [**Paula Cole Doesn't Want to Wait**](#)

By Rachel Syme | At the Conservatory Garden, the singer reflects on her new two-album set, “Sonic Memoir: Demos 1989-1998”; launching Lilith Fair with Sarah McLachlan; and the time Jay Leno made fun of her armpit hair.

- [**The Hearing Aid That Plays It by Ear**](#)

By David Owen | A company called Fortell made an A.I.-powered device that tries to tune out background noise in real time. Does it work? Ask Fortell's test subject, Steve Martin.

[Comment](#)

How to Protect Democracy

The emergence of Germany's far right as a political force represents an old dilemma.

By [Joshua Yaffa](#)

September 13, 2026

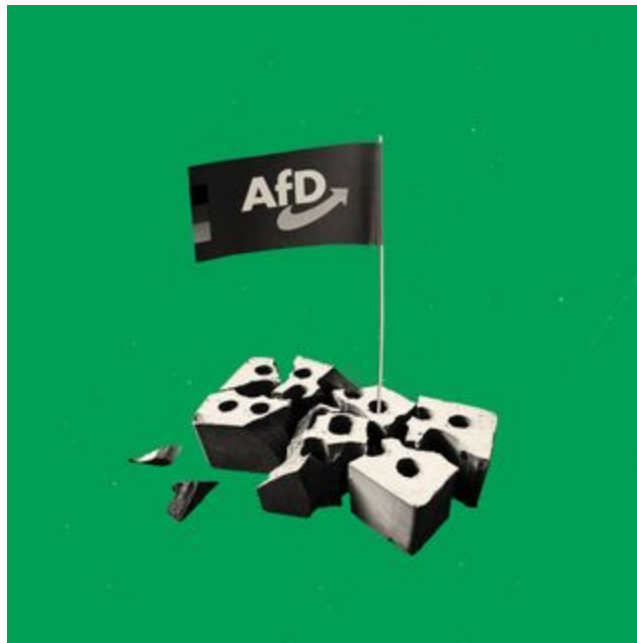


Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photographs from Getty

The Brandmauer, or firewall, was meant to protect German democracy. The principle arose in the mid-twenty-tens, in response to the rise of Alternative für Deutschland, or the AfD, a right-wing populist party known for its ethnonationalism, hard-line anti-immigration platform, and pro-Russian foreign policy. Germany's traditional parties agreed to refrain from any sort of political coöperation: they would neither form coalitions with the AfD nor rely on its votes for governing majorities.

Now the Brandmauer, long under pressure, may be facing collapse. This month, in Saxony-Anhalt, a small German state of slightly more than two million people in the east, the AfD won a plurality of votes: nearly forty-

four per cent. Without an outright majority, the Party can't govern on its own, but that number is more than double the AfD's share of the vote in Saxony-Anhalt just five years ago. And it's the first time in Germany's postwar history that a far-right party has come this close to governing a state.

The emergence of the AfD as a political force represents one of democracy's oldest dilemmas: how to respond to anti-democratic movements that have a democratic base of support. A century ago, conservative politicians in the Weimar Republic made the fateful, and tragic, choice to appoint Adolf Hitler as Chancellor and to name other Nazi figures to ministerial posts, believing that they could control them by absorbing them into the governing apparatus. That turned out, well, as it turned out. In 1949, in order to prevent such a disaster from ever occurring again, Basic Law, the country's modern constitution, enshrined a set of principles known as *wehrhafte Demokratie*, or militant democracy, which call on state institutions to mobilize against those who seek to undermine democracy from within. The Brandmauer is an informal compact, but it's certainly within the spirit of that political culture.

This postwar consensus has found an antagonist worthy of concern in the AfD. The Holocaust, one Party leader said, was a mere "speck of bird shit" on a thousand years of German history; another described Berlin's Holocaust Memorial as a "monument of shame." A Party policy calling for "remigration" is vague yet tinged with menace; in 2023, senior AfD figures attended a secret conference in Potsdam to discuss mass deportations of immigrants, including what one participant deemed "non-assimilated citizens." Whereas other European right-wing populist parties (such as the National Rally, in France) and leaders (like the Italian Prime Minister, Giorgia Meloni) have drifted toward the center in an effort to make their positions more palatable, the AfD has remained resolutely illiberal. Germany's domestic-intelligence service has classified some local branches of the Party as extremist organizations.

The Brandmauer, then, may have been a necessary instrument, but it allowed establishment parties to focus on the mechanics of defense rather than on offense—that is, on articulating a program that will win over voters.

The region of the former East Germany, for example, is facing deindustrialization and demographic decline; voters there, who tend to be poorer than those in the west and feel alienated and excluded, provide the AfD with its highest levels of support.

Jana Hensel, a journalist born in East Germany, published a book this year subtitled “Why the East Is Turning Away from Democracy.” She said, “By spending all this time thinking about how to maintain the firewall, we managed to forget the voters on the other side—how they live, their feelings, their problems.” The Brandmauer allowed the AfD to enjoy the image of the disruptive outsider, the one who really feels your pain, without the responsibility of having to do anything about it.

In Saxony-Anhalt, the AfD’s strong showing came at the expense of the Christian Democratic Union, the center-right party of Angela Merkel and of the current Chancellor, Friedrich Merz. The AfD hopes to persuade a handful of C.D.U. members to break from their firewall pledge and enable a governing majority; AfD leaders are also courting a far-left party that shares their hostility toward immigration and current policy on Russia and Ukraine. Perhaps more likely is a political stasis, in which neither the AfD nor the forces opposed to it take charge outright. That’s hardly a victory for those seen as the protectors of Germany’s normality.

In truth, no mainstream German party has figured out a formula for slowing the AfD’s electoral march. Merz has periodically flirted with adopting part of its agenda, specifically on immigration. Last year, in a controversial vote in the Bundestag, the C.D.U. pushed through a resolution on stricter migration rules which it knew would gain a majority only with AfD support. But one study after another shows that, when established parties take on the policies of the insurgent right, they end up just shedding more votes to it. In recent days, some C.D.U. members have renewed talk of a legal ban of the AfD. None of these stopgap measures deal with the real problem: like much of Europe, Germany is changing—economically, culturally, politically—and, in a sizable part of the population, that is stoking a desire for radical solutions. “Even if the AfD won’t fix the problems of its supporters,” Hensel said, “it will destroy the system under which they think they have suffered.”

Two other German states have elections later this month, and in 2029 the country will hold federal elections that will seat a new Bundestag and, perhaps, a new Chancellor. The AfD is rising in the west, too—for example, in Baden-Württemberg, a wealthy state home to much of the country’s automotive industry. In a sign of Germany’s greater manufacturing decline, the auto sector lost more than forty thousand jobs last year. The VW Group recently announced plans for fifty thousand additional phased layoffs and the end of production at four plants. That sort of malaise may lead to support for the AfD, even as it struggles with a solution. The Party’s co-chair Alice Weidel recently stumbled on television when asked to explain how German car producers could compete with growing demand for Chinese electric vehicles.

For years, the Brandmauer freed the AfD from such expectations. Yet competence at institutional defense is no substitute for an affirmative vision of governance. That’s also a lesson for other European democracies, from Austria to France, where mainstream parties have struggled to keep far-right challengers from power. A firewall can protect a political system, at least for a while, but it cannot explain what that system is for, or why its citizens should care. ♦

Joshua Yaffa is a contributing writer at *The New Yorker* and the author of “[Between Two Fires: Truth, Ambition, and Compromise in Putin’s Russia](#),” which won the Orwell Prize in 2021. He is currently the inaugural writer-in-residence at Bard College Berlin.

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[Closeup Dept.](#)

Ric Burns, N.Y.C. Optimist

The director—and brother of Ken Burns—is releasing two new episodes of his long-running “New York: A Documentary Film,” this time covering Superstorm Sandy, COVID, and Eric Adams.

By [Eric Lach](#)

September 12, 2026

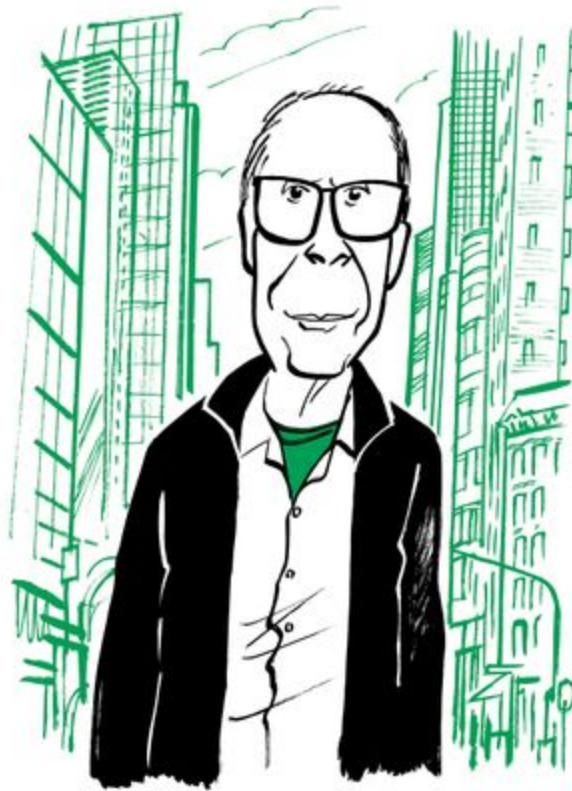


Illustration by João Fazenda

Not long ago, the documentary filmmaker Ric Burns appeared in the doorway of his Upper West Side office with a fresh wound over his forehead. “You may wonder why I have a two-inch gash on my head,” he said, bowing to display the damage. Burns—the director of “New York: A

Documentary Film”—had had a run-in with a metal paper-towel holder, to the tune of seven stitches. “Geysers of blood,” he said, entering a shadowy editing booth. “I got a photo if you want.”

Burns, the younger brother of fellow-filmmaker Ken Burns, was in the midst of making other bloody cuts: editing two long-gestating new episodes of “New York,” set to air later this month on PBS. One of his editors, Parker Dixon, sat at a console, staring at an iMac screen. The two began to work, Burns thinking aloud, Dixon cuing up footage. “Ric puts pen to paper,” Dixon said. “And from there we just feel it forward.”

Burns nodded. “It’s a funny balance,” he said. “Sometimes you want to be seeing what you hear, but a whole lot of times you don’t.”

[Talk of the Town](#)

Fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond



Burns has worked out of the same offices overlooking Broadway and Seventy-third Street since 1989, two years before he and a collaborator, James Sanders, began work on “New York.” The first seven episodes, fourteen hours in all, aired between 1999 and 2001, covering everything from Henry Hudson’s first sail up the harbor to the city’s near-bankruptcy in the nineteen-seventies. An eighth episode, “The Center of the World,” three hours long, appeared in 2003, telling the story of the development and construction of the Twin Towers. The two new episodes, “Shadows of the Past” and “The Future of Cities,” cover the past fifty years. As Dixon browsed through shots of Jack Maple (the police official who pioneered

CompStat), Michael Bloomberg being sworn in as mayor, Superstorm Sandy walloping the Manhattan and Brooklyn Bridges, footage of Times Square during *COVID*, and an interview with Eric Adams, Burns said that these were the trickiest installments he's done. "It's in the present," he said. "It's becoming history."

How is it possible to make sense of a half century of booms and busts, rising and falling crime, skyrocketing inequality, terrorist attacks, waves of new immigrants, revolutionary technologies, divisive new politics, menacing new weather, protests, lockdowns, flowering countercultures, tragic and triumphant Knicks teams, and all the other elements of New York's relentless change? "It's staggering," Burns said. "When it happens all around you in real time, you almost don't realize it's happening."

The new episodes feature a Burnsian mix of carefully chosen images, lyrical voice-over, and cross-spectrum talking heads, including Bloomberg, the history scholar Kenneth T. Jackson, the feminist writer Carmen Boullosa, and the *Times* culture critic Wesley Morris. Check your doom loops at the door; Burns is a New York City optimist. "This is where the people are, it's where the money is, it's where the productivity is, it's where the talent is, it's where the creativity is," he said. "People working hard at every conceivable kind of human enterprise." For years, he has shot footage of pigeons swooping to and fro in the intersection below his office, known as Verdi Square. "I got a major thing for pigeons," he said. "Pigeons are the New York animals, not rats."

Editing is agony for Burns. He grimaced as Dixon skimmed through a segment about the twisty 2001 mayoral race which was being severely truncated. September 11th was a primary day in New York City. Until that morning, Bloomberg had trailed badly in the polls. After the planes hit, officials rescheduled the election. Bloomberg's victory was arguably a bigger surprise than Zohran Mamdani's win last year. One case that Burns makes implicitly in the new episodes is that Bloomberg, for all his administration's faults and blind spots, will go down in history as the signal figure of early-twenty-first-century New York. "The only prior mayor who was a transformer like that was Fiorello LaGuardia," Burns said. "And Bloomberg had the bigger challenge."

Work on the new episodes began in earnest during the lockdown months of 2020, when the future of the city looked bleaker than it had at any time perhaps since the British imposed martial law, in 1776. But New York bounced back from *COVID*, as it had bounced back from Sandy, as it had bounced back from the Great Recession and the fiscal crisis. This resilience provides Burns with his great subject, and tracing its arcs has allowed him to connect the city's past to its present. "Globalization arguably began when Henry Hudson rounded the corner of Coney Island, in 1609," he said. "Fast-forward four hundred years, and here we are." ♦

[Eric Lach](#), a contributing writer, has contributed to the magazine since 2008. He writes frequently about New York City.

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[Coming to America Dept.](#)

Ke Huy Quan Keeps Smiling

On a trip to Liberty Island, the actor chats about his new memoir, “Never Say Die,” which chronicles his journey from refugee to child star in “Indiana Jones” to winning an Oscar, for “Everything Everywhere All at Once.”

By [Sarah Larson](#)

September 14, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

Before becoming a child movie star, in “Indiana Jones and the Temple of Doom” and “The Goonies,” the Oscar-winning actor Ke Huy Quan, born in Vietnam to ethnic-Chinese parents, lived with them and his eight siblings

over his father's plastic-bag factory, in Saigon. He emigrated with his father at age seven, starting with a harrowing boat trip to Hong Kong. He tells the boat story in a new memoir, "Never Say Die"—a "Goonies" reference—and thought of it again on a recent morning in lower Manhattan, as he boarded a ferry called the Miss Liberty. "This brings back memories of the Huey Fong, except that we were way more crowded," Quan said, climbing the stairs. "And, instead of going up, we went down." Tourists speaking several languages, some wearing foam Statue of Liberty crowns, filled the seats; Quan made his way to an upper-deck railing. He has kind eyes and a gently handsome face; his expressions tend toward earnest. As the ferry headed into the harbor, he gazed out at the Statue of Liberty, which he had never visited before. "I get a bit emotional thinking about this, and remembering some movie scenes that I've seen," he said. "Especially 'The Godfather Part II.' " He got quiet. "All the people coming here, hoping for an opportunity. I think if my dad was alive he'd be very proud."

On Liberty Island, the path approaches the statue from behind, affording time to contemplate the folds of its enormous cloak. "I wonder what it was like transporting that across the ocean," Quan said. Reaching the front, he beamed up at its majestic green head—"Ooh, look at that!"—and took a selfie, pointing, in a "Wow!" pose. He wore a black Uniqlo T-shirt of his own design, with yellow script that reads "Keep Smiling." (Proceeds go to the U.N. Refugee Agency and the Displacement Film Fund.) "I'm going to post that to my I.G. later," he said.

[Talk of the Town](#)

Fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond



After arriving in the United States, Quan's family reunited in Los Angeles's Chinatown. One day in 1983, while he and his younger brother, David, were in E.S.L. class, they saw kids heading to an open-call movie audition at their school. David wanted to go, too, and Quan accompanied him, coaching him in Cantonese ("Bigger! Look at me—like this!") and charming casting directors. Soon, Quan himself was at the Warner Bros. lot, auditioning before Harrison Ford, George Lucas, and Steven Spielberg, who cast him as the impishly heroic Short Round in "Temple of Doom." (David was happy for him, Quan said.) "I didn't know who they were," Quan recalled, sitting on a wall. "I hadn't seen 'Star Wars' or 'Raiders of the Lost Ark.' In fact, I'd never been to a movie theatre. The first time I went to a theatre and watched a movie with a live audience, I was in it." In the memoir, he recalls the nurturing and kindness of Spielberg, and of Ford, who taught him how to swim. " 'Temple of Doom' helped me kind of reshape what I went through as a kid in a positive way," he said. "I was having fun and playing a character who was courageous and funny and really enjoying the ride, versus terrified and worried about surviving." Behind him, tourists took photos with the statue; one happy teen posed like Lady Liberty, her arm raised, holding a novelty torch-shaped lemonade cup.



"I'll help you bury your acorns, then you help me with my thing."
Cartoon by Ellis Rosen

Seeing Quan, a young blond guy did a double take. "I literally was, like, Oh, my God, my favorite actor from 'The Goonies'!" he said. Quan posed for some fan pictures, then headed to the lemonade stand. As a kid, he said, he'd loved being recognized, "but when my career went south"—subsequent roles were smaller, and he eventually worked as a creative

consultant for Wong Kar-wai—he didn’t: “I thought I’d peaked at twelve.” (He did, however, meet his wife while working for Wong.) Since the release of “Everything Everywhere All at Once,” in 2022, for which he won the Oscar, “I am no longer uncomfortable,” he said. More good roles followed, including in last year’s “Zootopia 2.” “I play Gary De’Snake, a pit viper,” he said. “He may look intimidating, but he’s actually a kind and funny guy with a big heart.”

After a second ferry ride, Quan, sipping from his own torch-shaped lemonade cup, walked through the Ellis Island museum. “So this is the building where all the immigrants came through!” he said, in the sunny hall. He admired sepia-toned photos of immigrant kids holding American flags (“What an incredible thing America did”) and took in exhibits about restrictions and bigotry. He peered at some cartoons from 1882. “The first group of Chinese immigrants to this country were lied to—they ended up doing hard labor,” he said. “I would love to do a movie about that one day.” ♦

[Sarah Larson](#), a staff writer, has been contributing to *The New Yorker* since 2007.

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[Comeback Dept.](#)

Paula Cole Doesn't Want to Wait

At the Conservatory Garden, the singer reflects on her new two-album set, “Sonic Memoir: Demos 1989-1998”; launching Lilith Fair with Sarah McLachlan; and the time Jay Leno made fun of her armpit hair.

By [Rachel Syme](#)

September 14, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

The 1998 Grammy Awards should have been a triumphant night for the singer-songwriter Paula Cole. She was nominated for seven awards for her second album, “This Fire,” including Producer of the Year, Non-Classical, an honor that has yet to go to a woman (a factoid that she calls “deeply

fucked”). That night, Cole, then twenty-nine, performed “Where Have All the Cowboys Gone?” and won Best New Artist, beating out Hanson, Erykah Badu, Fiona Apple, and Puff Daddy. Yet all anyone could talk about, afterward, was the sight of Cole’s unshaven armpits at the ceremony. On “The Tonight Show,” Jay Leno trotted out a Cole doll and shined his shoes with its copious pit hair. When *Entertainment Weekly* airbrushed out her fuzz, Cole called the magazine “cowardly.” “If I look back,” she said the other day, “I see myself just nose-diving into unhappiness. I felt like prey. There was a deadening behind my eyes.”

Cole, who is now fifty-eight and has an Earth Mother vibe—baggy jeans, chore coat, beaded necklaces, orange HOKAs—was sitting in the Conservatory Garden in Central Park. She had come, as she put it, “to commune with pollinators” before kicking off a national tour marking the thirtieth anniversary of “This Fire.” She views the tour, along with the release of a new two-album set called “Sonic Memoir: Demos 1989-1998,” as a chance to reclaim the idealistic artist she was before the music business chewed her up. “After my third record, I had a complete nervous breakdown on tour in Germany,” she said. Although she stepped away from the industry, she never stopped working, quietly releasing eight more records, including two that she funded through Kickstarter. “I have found solace in being independent and not working with labels anymore,” she said. “I get to keep the music pure.” She survives mostly on royalties from her 1997 single “I Don’t Want to Wait,” which became the theme song to “Dawson’s Creek.” “That song is like Robin Hood,” she said. “I take that money and put it into my lesser-known art.”

She is still astounded by the fascination with her grooming preferences. “I was just this small-town girl,” she said, shaking her silver hair, which she’d braided and pinned across her head, milkmaid style. Going au naturel was an extension of her bohemian upbringing in coastal Massachusetts, where her mother worked as an artist, and where her father was a biology professor and the bass player in a polka band. “Music was a living language in our house,” she said, then tilted her head. “Listen to them!” she said, referring to some chirping crickets. “They are sending out messages to each other, like ‘O.K., it’s the end of the season, the light is changing. We better mate and propagate.’ ” She went on, “My dad studied entomology. I think

we need to befriend insects. They are the largest kingdom existing on Earth, and we are fucking it up. We're dusting our crops with glyphosates. We're destroying soil. We import compost. It's completely illogical, and we're headed for a breakdown."

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Cole splits her time between Manhattan and ten acres in Massachusetts, where she cultivates the land. A few years back, she discovered a book called "The Resilient Farm and Homestead," by the naturalist Ben Falk, and became a convert to his "permaculture" philosophy. Cole dug rainwater swales, installed a woodstove, and planted vegetables. (She hasn't eaten meat since she was fourteen.) This summer, she visited Falk's farm in Vermont, where she worked alongside hippies half her age. "I came screeching in as this old city person," she said. "I had to share a bathroom with nine men, which was really hard-core. Everyone was barefoot, just slipping in and out of their Crocs, and I was, like, ew. But I overcame that, and started putting my feet on the land. You feel your bones spread out. It's fantastic."

Cole strolled along a path lined with daylilies and Japanese anemones. She smiled at a sculpture of a boy and a girl from Frances Hodgson Burnett's "The Secret Garden." "It has never been easy to be a woman in the public eye," she said. Cole was instrumental in launching Lilith Fair, in 1997. "I'd opened for Sarah McLachlan," she said. "Every night I'd go out and I

would thank her for having a female opener, because it just didn't happen. Promoters said women don't sell tickets."

Turning back to the new record, she said, "I cringe when I listen to some of those old recordings. I'm out of tune, and it's messy. But the whole idea of it was for the fans to hear the process of me arriving at myself as a producer and as a human." On tour, she will sing "This Fire" in the original key. "I'm postmenopausal and my voice has changed," she said. "But I refuse to lose an octave." ♦

[Rachel Syme](#) is a staff writer at The New Yorker. She has covered Hollywood, style, literature, music, and other cultural subjects since 2012.

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[Brave New World](#)

The Hearing Aid That Plays It by Ear

A company called Fortell made an A.I.-powered device that tries to tune out background noise in real time. Does it work? Ask Fortell's test subject, Steve Martin.

By [David Owen](#)

September 14, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

In 2023, the comedian, actor, writer, and banjo virtuoso Steve Martin was walking through SoHo, followed closely by two men holding a laptop. The

laptop was connected by an Ethernet cable to a 3-D-printed plastic box, and the box was connected by wires to Martin's head. A passerby recognized him and asked whether the benefits of celebrity included having assistants literally tethered to him. But the men with the laptop weren't working for Martin. They were engineers, and Martin was serving as a beta tester for an invention of theirs, a new kind of hearing aid. The men referred to the laptop as the "diesel-powered" version of their device, which they were hoping to refine, then shrink. Late last year, with continuing help from Martin and others, they succeeded. Their company is called Fortell. Its inaugural hearing-aid-fitting clinic is at Sixty-first and Park. Their waiting room is decorated with paintings that Martin (without assistance) brought from his collection.

"We started crude and got better," Matthew de Jonge, one of Fortell's four co-founders, said not long ago, in the waiting area. "The thing that's novel about our hearing aid is that it filters out sound that, in our estimation, is unimportant and thus distracting, and it does it in real time."

In bars, clubs, and other loud, crowded places, young people almost always hear better than old people. One reason is that the un-degraded auditory circuitry in their heads is able to zero in on the people they're trying to hook up with while blocking out everyone else, a minor superpower known as the cocktail-party effect. "As people lose hearing, they also become less capable of listening selectively," Cole Morris, another Fortell co-founder, said. Modern hearing aids have some ability to compensate, by using directional microphones and conventional noise cancellation. "They're pretty good at dialling down so-called stationary sounds, like the hum of an air-conditioner," de Jonge said. "What they have never been able to do is to separate speech you want to hear from speech you don't, and to do it even if the speech you don't want to hear is louder than the speech you do."

Talk of the Town

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De Jonge and Morris were roommates at Princeton, and later de Jonge was among the creators of Butterfly iQ, an A.I.-enhanced handheld medical-imaging device that is now one of the best-selling sonogram systems in the world. (It was used on the International Space Station to evaluate an astronaut who was later evacuated, and it has appeared in a supporting role in episodes of “The Pitt.”) Early in the Butterfly project, the team received an e-mail from a professor at Harvard, who told de Jonge that he was working with the best physics-Ph.D. student he’d ever had. “He said the guy’s field was quantum optics, whatever that is, but that what he really wanted to do was A.I. for health care,” de Jonge recalled. “He said the guy had no experience in either A.I. or health care but asked if I would hire him. I said yes.”

The physics Ph.D. was Igor Lovchinsky, a Russian émigré. “There are special Russian music schools, and I was admitted to one of them when I was four,” he said. He moved to the United States with his family, won a scholarship to Juilliard, and became a celebrated concert pianist, before switching to physics. He designed Butterfly’s neural networks, then did the same for Fortell, of which he is also a co-founder. The fourth co-founder, Andrew Casper, designed the custom chips used in both projects. Fortell’s hearing aids sell for sixty-eight hundred dollars per pair, about average for the top of the line.

Paul Krawitz is a sixty-seven-year-old retired ophthalmic surgeon in Cold Spring Harbor, on Long Island. He first realized he had a hearing problem ten years ago. “When my bedroom windows were open, I could hear the crickets in my yard if my right ear was on the pillow, but not when I rolled over,” he said. He tried six different hearing aids, but wasn’t happy with any

of them. “I was a pain in the ass as an audiology patient,” he said. “I wanted cognitively transparent improvement in my hearing, not just an increase in volume.”

He made an appointment at Fortell on a whim. “A typical audiologist will sit on the other side of the room and ask, ‘How do I sound?,’ ” he said. “But the Fortell audiologist said she was going to take me on a field trip.” They conversed out on the sidewalk, with Manhattan traffic in the background, then visited an espresso bar. “I heard beautifully,” he said. “You know, the ability to pass naturally in conversation is not a luxury. It’s fundamental to human connection.” Krawitz noticed another difference at home, while listening to Rachmaninoff’s Second Symphony. “People who love music sometimes refer to hearing the ‘air’ between the players, and for the first time in many years I heard it again,” he said. “My wife goes, ‘Why are you crying?’ ” ♦

[David Owen](#) has been a staff writer at The New Yorker since 1991. He is the author of “[Volume Control: Hearing in a Deafening World](#).”

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The Incredible Journey of a Migratory Shorebird

Godwits make the longest non-stop migration in the bird world. That might be the least of their marvels. Can they survive a changing planet?

By [Rivka Galchen](#)

September 14, 2026



One scientist called the Hudsonian godwit's journey from Patagonia to Alaska "technically impossible." Photographs by Ash Adams for The New Yorker

On a sunny June morning, in a bog outside Beluga, Alaska, I met a Hudsonian godwit. She had inky eyes and a long, slightly upturned beak that was pinkish-orange at its base and brownish-black at its tip. The feathers on her back were of mottled sepia tones, and those on her belly were rusty brown and painterly white. Her legs reminded me of the slender inserts of spring-loaded ballpoint pens, and her feet were refined pterodactyl claws. Her name (among humans) was A34, and she was about the size of a city pigeon. She was in the hands of Nathan Senner, a

conservation biologist, who removed and replaced her geotag; measured her head, beak, wing, and leg; weighed her; and took two tail feathers and a sample of her blood. From that small number of data points, he can deduce where she's been, how her feathers have grown, what genetic subgroup she belongs to, and her degree of exposure to mercury.

Senner leads a research laboratory at the University of Massachusetts, Amherst, that is largely focussed on how migratory shorebirds, such as godwits, respond to environmental change. He grew up in Anchorage, where school loudspeakers announced the street corners on which moose had been sighted. In high school, he wrote an occasional "Birding with Nathan" column for the Anchorage *Daily News*. Senner's father, Stanley, has devoted more than five decades to the conservation of migratory shorebirds. Starting in the nineteen-seventies, Stanley and his colleagues have been sounding the alarm on the vulnerability of shorebirds and working to protect key habitats, such as Alaska's Copper River Delta. "Back then, no one was even talking about climate change," he told me recently. Since 1980, roughly half of migratory shorebird species' populations have declined by more than fifty per cent.

Migratory shorebirds are usually not a person's first bird crush. They lack the supernatural aura of the resplendent quetzal, and they don't go in for outlandish mating displays like that of the prairie chicken. As the Princeton University biology professor and shorebird-lover David Wilcove put it, migratory shorebirds can give an impression of being "little brown guys, buzzing around in the mud, not too big and not too small, and, whether one is a stint or a phalarope or a knot or a godwit, they're just kind of there." And yet, Wilcove told me, they are a birder's kind of bird. Once people get to know them, they tend to fall in love.

Relatively few people have laid eyes on Hudsonian godwits. The birds mostly divide their time between remote northern bogs and muddy South American shores. John James Audubon apparently never saw a living one; he based his drawing of them in "Birds of America" on a few specimens he found in markets. Arthur Cleveland Bent, in a 1927 installment of his twenty-one-volume series, "Life Histories of North American Birds," wrote

of Hudsonian godwits, “I can count on the fingers of one hand the red-letter days when I have been privileged to see this rare and handsome wader.”

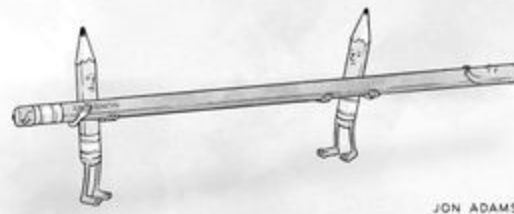
It’s entirely possible that I had encountered A34 two months before seeing her in Alaska. In March, I had travelled from New York to Chiloé Island, in Chilean Patagonia. Flocks of Hudsonian godwits (the smallest of the four godwit species and the least well known) spend from roughly early October to April in and around the tidal mudflats there. The island also has Humboldt penguins, giant rhubarb plants with leaves as large as umbrellas, and the world’s smallest species of deer. Castro, the main town, is famous for its brightly painted wooden seaside houses, which rest on tall stilts to accommodate the tide. *Homo sapiens* is a shore-loving species. About forty per cent of us live within sixty miles of a coast.

Chiloé is where Hudsonian godwits spend their non-breeding season and express their non-breeding personality, which is intensely gregarious and food-oriented. If you walk at low tide on the mudflats of Pullao Bay, you will see godwits bobbing for bivalves and worms, dunking their beaks in and out of the ground as if they were darning. They share their feasting grounds with oystercatchers, ducks, whimbrels, greater yellowlegs and lesser yellowlegs, and other shorebirds that neither I nor my Merlin Bird ID app could identify. The longer I watched the shorebirds on Chiloé Island, the stronger my impression was that they were dressed for a masquerade or a carnival, with some wearing stout beaks, some slim ones, others elegantly curved ones. The pale bellies and darker backs of many of the birds made it look as if they had on fashionable capes over slender, hosiery-clad legs. They called out to one another and occasionally broke into cotillion-like flight. The Hudsonian godwits appeared eternally committed to these revels. There was no sign that they were about to fly nearly ten thousand miles to Alaska, a wondrous and mystifying migration that one scientist called “technically impossible.”

Birds are in trouble. Migratory shorebirds are in especially bad trouble. And *long-distance* migratory shorebirds, like the Hudsonian godwit, may be in the most trouble. “Birds are sentinels,” Stanley Senner told me. “The ecosystems they rely on are ecosystems we rely on as well, though it can take time to convince people of that.” Studies show that, without

shorebirds, coastlines erode more quickly, trap less carbon, and are more likely to become unbalanced. In the Yellow Sea, for example, shorebirds feed on crabs whose population needs to be kept in check, as they graze on native vegetation. In some ways, shorebirds are analogous to the wolves that hunt the deer and elk populations that eat the tree saplings that become the trees that beavers use to build dams that help the fish—and so on. Shorebirds also transport and disperse essential seeds and nutrients. Our interests align, as they say. Also, like all birds, they are lovable, alien, awesome, and alive. Not long ago, I saw a dead magpie on a country highway. Other magpies gathered around it, as if saddened and confused. When a car approached, they scattered. After the car passed, they returned to their fallen friend. So there's also that.

To protect birds effectively, we need to understand them. So much about godwits remains unknown, including where and when they encounter their most mortal threats. Since their epic migration is maybe their most difficult-to-fathom characteristic, we may as well start there.



"We shouldn't have waited so long to have a baby."
Cartoon by Jon Adams

The story of bird migration, as narrated in Western civilization, often begins with Aristotle, who wrote that, in the winter, redstarts turn into robins and garden warblers turn into blackcaps. This sounds silly but, compared with the idea that a caterpillar becomes a butterfly, it seems reasonable. Olaus Magnus, a sixteenth-century Swedish priest, argued that barn swallows disappear in the fall because they hibernate at the bottom of ponds. That also seems absurd until you learn about the common poorwill, which resembles an old piece of bark and spends months of winter nestled almost imperceptibly in the crevices of logs or among piles of rocks. This wasn't

scientifically documented until 1948, although the poorwill has long been known to the Hopi as *hölchoko*, “the sleeping one.”

The Maori tell a story about how a godwit showed their ancestors the way from their ancient homeland of Hawaiki to New Zealand, more than a thousand miles away. But, to most people, avian migrations of that length were long unimaginable. In 1822, a hunter near the German town of Klütz shot down a stork; when he collected the bird, he saw that it had a wooden spear through its neck, later determined to be of African origin. Hunters eventually found more such *Pfeilstorchs* (arrow storks), giving credence to the hypothesis that the white stork not only migrated but did so between Europe and Africa. In some ways, this was a downgrade: the seventeenth-century minister Charles Morton, who wrote a popular physics textbook, claimed that birds migrated to the moon. He supposed that they fuelled a sixty-day flight there with body fat (reasonable) and that the journey was made easier by the minimal atmospheric resistance in space (also reasonable).

Migratory birds in captivity develop *Zugunruhe*, an agitated fitfulness, at certain times of year. Scientists don't know precisely what provoked A34 to set off northward one spring afternoon, with a flock of her fellows, though, if they did, they might better know how her species will be affected by the shifting seasons of our changing climate. Godwits cannot soar like hawks or glide like albatrosses. They migrate by continuously flapping their wings. They must navigate crosswinds and headwinds, storms and maybe an occasional hurricane, continuing on day after day, night after night. As best as we can tell, they do not, while flying, eat or drink or sleep (at least not with more than one hemisphere of their brain at a time). After a journey of hundreds of hours and thousands of miles, they descend on a snow-covered shore at the Cook Inlet of southern Alaska or another favored breeding ground. They land considerably lighter than when they took off. “Many arriving shorebirds seem to be tired,” the ornithologist and conservationist Joseph Archibald Hagar wrote, in his foundational monograph, “Nesting of the Hudsonian Godwit at Churchill, Manitoba,” from 1966. In a field-diary entry, Hagar describes a group of birds that “within a minute or two dropped into some sunny spot out of the wind, tucked heads into scapulars, and went to sleep, not to move again for as long as we watched.”

In 1976, the young ornithologist Robert Gill took a job with the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service in Anchorage. He was dispatched to the Alaska Peninsula to do biological inventories on public land that was up for lease to private companies. During those long-lit Alaskan summer days, walking across salt marshes and through the foothills of the mountains, Gill encountered thousands upon thousands of migratory shorebirds. He told me, “In Alaska, where the seasons are so prominent, it’s very dramatic. It feels like all the birds turn up over the course of one weekend in May.” Along with godwits, the peninsula was a summer home to yellowlegs, dowitchers, sandpipers, Arctic terns, and other species. But almost no one was aware that so many birds relied on this land. How the birds managed their journeys, where they might stop along the way, even how many of them there were—no one knew for sure. “In the vast expanses of wetlands and coastal tundra, you could see why,” Gill said.

The extinction of the once common passenger pigeon, famously described by the naturalist John Muir in his memoir (“I have seen flocks streaming south in the fall so large that they were flowing over from horizon to horizon in an almost continuous stream all day long, at the rate of forty or fifty miles an hour, like a mighty river in the sky”), was part of the impetus behind the Migratory Bird Treaty Act of 1918. Godwits are protected under the act, so killing them or holding them captive, even for scientific purposes, is highly regulated. Also, they’re difficult to capture. Gill’s means of learning more about them was limited, he said, to “the kind of observational work done by old-school naturalists.”

In October of 1987, Gill received a call about nine bar-tailed godwits that had crashed into a radar dome near Cold Bay, Alaska, and died. “They were greaseballs,” he recalled. “They made any Christmas goose look lean.” The carcasses were sent to a lab to be analyzed. Fifty-five per cent of their body mass turned out to be fat. Gill suspected that these chubby godwits were preparing to fly non-stop from Alaska to New Zealand, where this species wintered. However, at that time, the longest known non-stop migration flight was barely half that long. “But, if they were going to stop in French Polynesia, why carry all that baggage?” Gill reasoned.

The lab also measured the birds' internal organs. Gill's collaborator, Theunis Piersma, noticed something peculiar: the guts, gizzard, liver, and kidneys of these birds were very small—it was like cutting open a lion and encountering digestive organs the size of a house cat's. Then, in March of 1992, some forty godwit carcasses were seized from a poacher in New Zealand. These were birds in a very different part of their migratory cycle, and their digestive organs, when analyzed, were of more normal proportions. In 1998, Piersma and Gill published their findings in a paper titled “Guts Don't Fly: Small Digestive Organs in Obese Bar-Tailed Godwits,” concluding that the birds shrank their digestive organs to reduce their weight and their metabolic demands during a non-stop migration. And then, somehow, regrew them.

This conclusion remained debatable. For one thing, Gill and Piersma had no direct evidence that the birds flew without stopping. At the time, there were no tags sufficiently lightweight for tracking birds as small as godwits. But transmitters kept shrinking, and, in 2007, Gill flew to New Zealand, where, after a lot of patient, muddy field work, he succeeded in putting tags on sixteen bar-tailed godwits. The trackers could send signals to satellites to pinpoint the birds' location. By today's norms, the trackers were pretty heavy. Many of them failed within months, but one lasted much longer than expected.

A female godwit, E7, took off on March 17, 2007, from near the Piako River, on New Zealand's North Island. She flew more than six thousand miles non-stop to a nature preserve on the Yalu River, near the China-North Korea border; she stayed there for a little more than a month; she arrived at her nesting area in Alaska on May 15th and spent the summer there. The tracker was still working on August 29th, when E7 started flying southeast, over the Pacific. Gill's team was doing field work in western Alaska and had only spotty internet service; the team would gather around a laptop, waiting for the updates on E7's location to come through. North of Kauai, she took a slight right turn and continued flying. On September 7th, after more than two hundred hours aloft, she landed at the mouth of the Piako River, back on the North Island of New Zealand, where Gill had first met her.

Before E7, the longest documented non-stop migratory-bird flight was that of a Far Eastern curlew who had flown about four thousand miles. E7 flew some seven thousand without a break. The flight defied reason. “I had an engineering professor at M.I.T. call me up and say he gave his students an assignment to compare the size and flight range of E7 to a 747 jet,” Gill said.

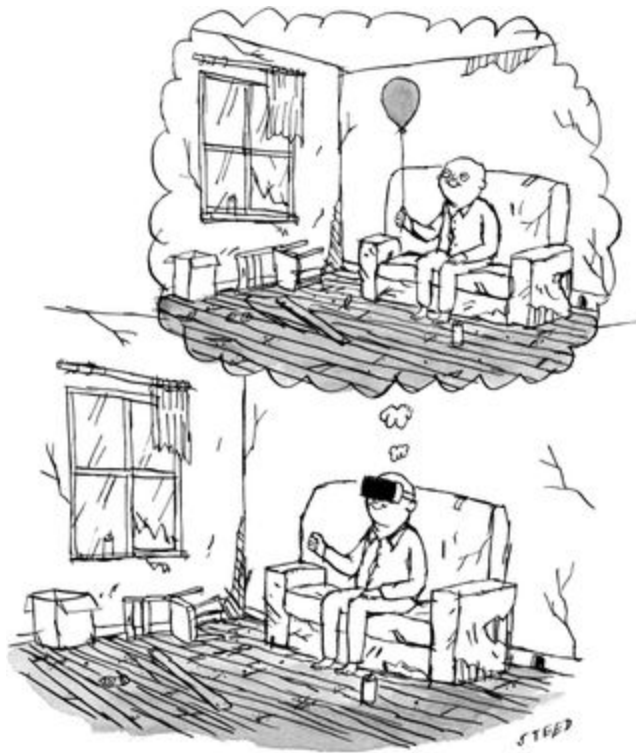
How these birds could put on so much fat and still be healthy remains somewhat mysterious. “The dogma for mammals is that fat is good fuel for low-intensity exercise—but the flapping flight required for migration is thought to be pretty high intensity,” Maria Stager, an evolutionary biologist at UMass, Amherst, who studies the physiology of songbirds, told me. Marathoners consume sugary carbohydrate-rich gels, not bacon bits. Stager is Nathan Senner’s wife; she assists him in his field work, and he assists her in hers. A couple of years ago, to better understand godwit migration, they began a collaboration with Chris Guglielmo, a professor of biology at Ontario’s Western University and the director of its Centre for Animals on the Move, where he often uses wind tunnels to measure birds’ flight dynamics and metabolism. A wind tunnel works much like those “endless” swimming pools, in which you stay in place while swimming against a current. But the wind tunnel wouldn’t work for godwits. “If I tried to get a bird to fly non-stop for eleven days in my wind tunnel—well, first of all, I don’t think my animal-care committee would approve of it, because the bird would probably die of dehydration,” he said.

Guglielmo had done the math. “We knew how fat the birds got,” he said. “We knew the energy content of fat and nonfat tissue.” According to these measurements, even the fattest of the birds would run out of fuel—body fat and a bit of muscle—after about twenty-five hundred miles. “So not even halfway,” he said.

Guglielmo played around a bit with such variables as drag coefficient and presumed altitude. He eventually came up with parameters in which birds might survive flying six thousand miles non-stop—but only if they could complete the journey in four or five days. Tracking data showed that the migrations were never that brief. “They shouldn’t be able to go seven, nine,

eleven days,” Guglielmo said. And yet they did. “They look diminutive, fragile, and delicate. But they’re these high-performance Ferrari machines.”

He had a hypothesis about what was going on. Hummingbirds can save energy by going into torpor at night, lowering their body temperature and their heart rate. Little brown bats can similarly reduce their metabolic demands by going Dracula for months at a time, decreasing their body temperatures by more than fifty degrees Fahrenheit and slowing their respiration to a handful of breaths an hour. Guglielmo wondered whether godwits did something similar, even though hanging motionless in a torpor seems pretty different from flying.



Cartoon by Edward Steed

But there were no data on the heart rate and body temperature of migrating godwits. So, in the summer of 2024, Guglielmo joined Stager and Senner during their field work in Beluga. With him were the veterinarian Beverly Chua, a postdoctoral student named Catherine Ivy, and a graduate student, Kevin Young. When Senner and Stager caught a godwit, they would pass it along to Guglielmo and Young, who would drive the bird to a makeshift operating room they had set up at their lodge. Chua would put it to sleep

with isoflurane, intubate it, cover its eyes to keep them from drying out, make a small incision in its abdomen to insert a device that would log heart rate and body temperature, and then sew the bird up. The surgery took about twenty minutes. From the birds' perspective, Guglielmo said, "it must feel like an alien abduction."

"In total, we placed the trackers in ten birds, five males and five females," Guglielmo told me. Whether they would see those individuals again was uncertain; the birds would have to survive the summer, fly down to Chiloé Island, survive there, fly back to Beluga, and be recaptured. "When I look at them, I have this little moment and think, They're going to go off and do these amazing things," Guglielmo said. The following summer, the team returned, as did at least nine of the ten godwits. The data extracted from the trackers are being analyzed, a slow process.

When I flew into Beluga, on a four-seat Cessna, my bird's-eye view was of blue-and-green water that softly transitioned into brown-and-green land. The pilot pointed out gray harbor seals and some of the village's namesake pink-white whales. The two other passengers were working on a project to keep the local Chinook and coho salmon, which are essential to the area's commercial-fishing industry, from being decimated by the northern pike, an invasive species that preys on the salmon. Beluga, with a permanent human population of thirty-four, is visited by duck hunters, fishermen, oil workers, solar contractors, U.S. Geological Survey scientists, and Senner's team of ornithological researchers, who come each year to monitor the nesting grounds.

"As extraordinary as their migration is, maybe it has led us to overlook other aspects of their life cycle," Senner told me one evening. "We have this idea that migration is dangerous and that a lot of birds are likely dying in migration," he went on. "That's born in part from the fact that we do occasionally see these mass-mortality events." A powerful tornado off the coast of Louisiana in 1993 killed three humans and tens of thousands of birds, most of them neotropical migrants—orioles, warblers, thrushes, vireos—who were nearing the end of their migration across the Gulf of Mexico. In the fall of 2020, following droughts and a cold snap in the

American Southwest, estimates suggest that more than a hundred thousand migrating birds died—many of them falling directly out of the sky.

“But what we’ve been finding with migratory shorebirds suggests the opposite,” Senner went on. “Migration is *not* necessarily the most dangerous time of the year.” José A. Alves, at the University of East Anglia, led a team that compared two groups of Icelandic black-tailed godwits. The godwits that wintered farther away, in Portugal, actually fared better than those that wintered in England. “When we think about conservation, we need to think about where in their life cycle they are most vulnerable,” Senner said.

About a hundred and fifty Hudsonian godwit pairs breed in the bogs near Beluga. After a post-migratory rest, courting begins with aerobatic displays by the males, which involve butterfly-like flapping followed by free-fall nosedives from which they gracefully pull out at the last second. The females lead “pursuit flights,” in which they fly swiftly, with abrupt tilts and turns; a male partner follows just behind and below. Sometimes females stay with last year’s partner, sometimes they choose a new partner. Unchosen males, known (alas!) as “failed males,” spend the season flying around in a group, seemingly to harass paired males and to impress paired females.

A godwit couple will scrape a few shallow, saucer-shaped indentations (sometimes referred to as “nest cups”) into a grassy spot, select one of them, and proceed to nest as imperceptibly as possible. Parents sit atop their clutch of eggs (almost always four) on a predictable schedule: the females from about 6 A.M. to 6 P.M. and the males for the remaining twelve hours, with each bird of the couple feeding at the shore in their off-nest time. These four eggs are usually the birds’ one hope during the whole year of producing offspring; the festive godwits of Chiloé become, in the breeding grounds, measured, quiet, and focussed. Nesting is always perilous, but the moment when the male and female trade places is especially so, as the incubating bird’s movement may catch the attention of a predator.

The bogs in late May are a vast expanse of hummocks of yellowed sedge interspersed with small ponds and copses of black spruce where moose like to hang out. Underfoot, the bog is squishy and resilient, with unseen holes

here and there. It gets softer and sinkier as spring advances. Wearing thigh-high rubber boots, I spent three days in this landscape, tramping behind Stager and Senner as they sought out nest sites, tracked the progress of eggs, and weighed, measured, and tagged expecting parents.

It was here that Senner handed A34 to me for a moment. She was warmer than I expected a bird to be. I could feel her heartbeat. When I was in elementary school, I briefly shared an elevator with the actor Robert Wagner, whom I recognized from the TV show “Hart to Hart.” He caught my eye and said hello. The encounter was otherworldly and wondrous. Holding A34 felt something like that. Then I opened my hands and she took off, back to her clutch of eggs, which, if not eaten by a coyote or a sandhill crane or another hungry creature, would soon hatch. Life is stressful for Hudsonian godwits: Senner told me that, across godwit studies, he has never seen a rate of chicks surviving to fledging higher than about twenty-five per cent.

Senner began collecting data from godwit nesting sites in Beluga in 2009, when Robert Gill helped him to scout out the terrain. Godwit couples maintain large territories, establishing nests far from other godwits. They prefer dense boggy areas that tend to keep humans away. Their nests are built in existing sedge clumps, with minimal modifications, and are therefore ridiculously hard to find—as Gill put it, they’re “very cryptic,” even for expert eyes. Senner is known for having a “nest sense,” but, as he said, “all that ends up meaning is that rather than spending twenty-four walking hours per nest find, I spend maybe twelve.”

One of the more reliable approaches to nest-finding is to follow a male godwit returning to take over nighttime duties. Late one afternoon, Senner and Stager separately staked out two males. They each waited for about three hours. The godwit males remained in spruce treetops, give or take an occasional short flight. Either the birds were on to them, or they were failed males with no nests to fly back to.

That godwits reproduce at all is astounding. They must shuttle great distances between southern and northern latitudes of the globe, figuring out not only the location of their breeding grounds but the optimal moment to arrive so that their eggs can hatch when insects are at their most abundant.

Between 1974 and 2010, godwits were arriving earlier than usual, by as much as nine days. Was this an adaptation to a changing climate? Maybe, but, between 2011 and 2023, the godwits' arrival date shifted again, to as many as six days *later*. "I used to be able to say, 'Come up here on June 1st and you will definitely see chicks hatch,' " Senner told me. "But I can't really say that anymore." This second shift seemed counterintuitive and maladaptive, since peak insect abundance is directly related to snowmelt. "One of the closest correlations to arrival date is when spring came the previous year, which makes it seem like the birds remember that," Senner said. With climate change, the bogs are drying out, so there are fewer insects for young chicks to eat. Yet more nests are hatching, even as a smaller percentage of those chicks are surviving.

Stager recalled a long evening she and Senner once spent looking for nests: "This beautiful thunderstorm was approaching, and we were, like, 'We should not be in this open bog right now, but also we need to be banding these chicks.' " They were searching near where a male godwit was resting in a treetop, indicating a nest nearby, but they were having no luck finding it. Then the male began "making these horrible distressed calls that I've never heard another bird make," Stager said. She and Senner spotted a northern harrier. Their approach startled the predator, who took off with the mother godwit in its claws. When the father flew down to his chicks, Stager and Senner managed to catch and tag all the birds—"He was pretty angry with us," Stager said—then retreated from the stormy bog. The father was left to tend to the chicks himself until they were old enough to survive on their own. At least two of those four chicks survived, Senner told me. He knew because those birds returned to Beluga a couple of years later. "Usually, even with two parents, very few chicks make it," he said. "I thought, Wow, he is a really great dad."

Chicks can walk within a few hours of hatching, but it's several more weeks before they can fly. By the end of this year's breeding season, about twenty per cent of the hatched chicks had fledged. It was a good year. In one nest, three of four chicks survived. In some other nests, no chick lived beyond a week. One of A34's chicks survived. On my last afternoon in Beluga, Stager told me, "I don't consider myself a conservation biologist like Nate—it would make me too sad."

Godwit parents brood their chicks, alert them to danger, lead them to hiding places, and (in a dramatic and short-lived personality shift) aggressively squawk at and harry their potential predators. Then, in July, the adults begin their southward migration, leaving their young behind. Although much remains unknown about godwits in general, even more remains unknown about the juveniles. They have been observed leaving Alaska in August and September, though it's unclear how they find their way. Hudsonian juveniles have now and again been spotted in New Zealand and Australia, rather than in South America, among flocks of bar-tailed godwits. More recently, the scientists Juan G. Navedo and Jorge Ruiz, from the Universidad Austral de Chile, tagged some birds in Chiloé and discovered that, instead of travelling to Alaska in the spring to breed, they spent the boreal summer in the pampas of Argentina.

Sixty years ago, the naturalist and writer Peter Matthiessen observed in this magazine that the Hudsonian godwit was among the most precarious of the North American shorebirds: "It is an exceptionally unassertive bird, readily chivied by marbled godwits, and even sanderlings. Was it always so timid, or is the degeneration brought about by mutation? Has it become specialized in some way not yet understood? . . . The naturalist who could find answers to such questions would explain a good deal that we do not know about ecology and ethology and genetics."

Money and political will being scarce resources, questions of where and when to apply them are the constant companions of conservation science. The long-term survival of Hudsonian godwits—and migratory shorebirds more broadly—depends to a significant degree on scientists figuring out what efforts will be most effective. "I hate to say it, but you might call it an optimization problem," Nathan Senner told me.

"Tidal mudflats have suffered from not being perceived as beautiful sights," Wilcove, of Princeton, said. The dun-colored flats often stretch for miles. "The degradation of a tidal flat is not as apparent as the clear-cutting of a forest or the damming of a river," he went on. "It just looks like a place you don't want to walk, because it's really hot and you could sink down to your waist. It's hard for people to imagine that it's an incredibly vibrant and important habitat for so much wildlife."

The Western Hemisphere Shorebird Reserve Network, founded in 1985, initially focussed on setting up what Stanley Senner described as “a string of pearls” consisting of wetlands along migratory routes, with Alaska’s Copper River Delta becoming one of the first of more than a hundred designated sites. “But now we’re coming to understand that it’s not enough,” Senner said. Smaller-scale interventions also do essential work. In California, for example, rice farmers are paid to flood their fields during key weeks of the year, for the use of migrating birds. W.H.S.R.N. has collaborative conservation projects at sites up and down the Americas, including at ranches in Uruguay, salt ponds in Ecuador, and shrimp farms in Honduras. In Chiloé, Senner’s colleague Natalia Martínez-Curci, of Argentina’s National Scientific and Technical Research Council, has spent years working with the local aquaculture industry, along with members of the Indigenous community, who recently built a bird observatory.

But, of course, migratory shorebirds aren’t limited to the Western Hemisphere. Scientists studying the East Asian-Australasian Flyway (which runs roughly from Alaska and Siberia down to New Zealand and Australia) spent time trying to identify what the various migratory bird species in steepest decline had in common. Was it body size? Breeding range? Migratory distance? The shared variable turned out to be reliance on the coastal wetlands of China’s Yellow Sea. Between 1980 and 2014, about a third of that coastline was lost to land reclamation. Tong Mu, a thirty-five-year-old researcher at Princeton, said that when he began his graduate work on migratory shorebirds of the flyway, in 2014, “everything seemed very gloomy to me, and to many people.” Mu did his Ph.D. under Wilcove, working to identify which parts of the Yellow Sea flats were most used by birds.

In 2018, following much clamoring by scientists, the Chinese government enacted strict restrictions on commercial land reclamation along its coast. In 2019, parts of the Yellow Sea mudflats were named a *UNESCO* World Heritage site. “I would say that the government realized that sustainable development and ecological conservation are a very important part of the story that they want to tell,” Mu said. He recalled doing field work with a much older researcher who said, half joking, half complaining, that science and conservation have nothing to do with each other—that, regardless of

how excellent the science is, policymakers will only hear what they want to hear. “But I think science is still very important,” Mu said.

I asked him for his impression of what migratory shorebirds are like—what his sense was of their personalities, if it was even O.K. to use the word “personality” in relation to birds. He was quiet for a moment. “Sorry, it makes me a little emotional to talk about it,” he said, smiling. Mu spent five Arctic summers in far-eastern Russia, where mating pairs each have their own territory. He grew more attached to them in that setting, witnessing their individual dramas. “There are some success stories,” he said. “But also many failures. The birds’ nests may be depredated. Or they may have terrible weather, and the chicks can’t survive it. And, you know, they have travelled thousands of kilometres, just for that.”

Mu recalled placing a young chick under his hat, to keep the bird warm while he prepared to tag it. “When they are very young, they cannot maintain their body temperature, and have to be covered by the adults every now and then,” he said. The chick called out in distress. An adult bird flew over, landing on Mu’s head. He took off the hat, and the adult dove in after the chick. ♦

*[Rivka Galchen](#), a staff writer at *The New Yorker*, has contributed fiction and nonfiction to the magazine since 2008. Her books include the novel “[Everyone Knows Your Mother Is a Witch](#).”*

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[Popular Chronicles](#)

The American Religion of Self-Storage Facilities

Why are we so obsessed with putting our belongings in metal boxes and then never looking at them again?

By [David Owen](#)

September 14, 2026

Ninety per cent of the world's self-storage capacity is in the United States. Illustration by Lewis Osborne

During the summer of 2019, not long before *COVID* shut the country down, I spent three and a half days driving from Connecticut, where I live, to Kansas City, where I grew up, and three and a half days driving back. My routes in both directions were lazy and circuitous, and they included not even one mile of interstate highway. I ate roast turkey with all the trimmings at a restaurant in upstate New York that offers Thanksgiving dinner every day of the year; stood at the northern end of a puddle representing the Dead Sea in a grassy park created, a century and a half ago, as a walk-over relief map of the Holy Land; saw surprisingly many sex-toy superstores near billboards promoting belief in Jesus Christ; and visited the birthplace of the Western novelist Zane Grey, who, it turns out, was also a minor-league baseball player and a practicing dentist, and whose real first name was Pearl. Mainly, though, I spent long hours alone in my car thinking about our remarkable country. By the time I got home, I had concluded, based on a multitude of examples, that the two great pillars of American culture are church and self-storage.

A self-storage facility is a business that rents lockable space to people who own more stuff than they know what to do with. (A 2022 survey by the Craftsman tool division of Stanley Black & Decker found that more than a third of the country's residential garages were so full of overflow possessions that their owners were unable to park cars in them.) “The

history of self-storage probably goes back a long way, but the seventies is when it really got started, mostly with mom-and-pop-type operations,” Patrick Lemp, an appraiser and broker who focusses on the industry, told me. “Later, it became an accepted institutional-quality asset class.”

The United States is the world leader, with roughly ninety per cent of global capacity. Texas, of the fifty states, has the most facilities, Hawaii the fewest. Among cities, New York ranks third, after Dallas-Fort Worth and Houston, although on a per-capita basis many smaller municipalities are comparably served. Reno, Nevada, is home to a number of operations that pick up, store, and redeliver tents, chairs, bicycles, and other gear for repeat Burning Man attendees, and Wichita, Kansas, was once named the Self-Storage Capital of the U.S. Units range from closet-size to cavernous, including spaces that are large enough to hold entire houses. Most of the facilities I saw on my road trip were single-story structures with lots of closely spaced roll-up metal doors; some, owned or operated by national chains such as Public Storage, Extra Space Storage, and CubeSmart, looked like office buildings. According to the co-founder and C.E.O. of Neighbor, an industry marketplace that works like Airbnb, there are more self-storage facilities in the U.S. than there are Starbucks, McDonald’s, Walmart, Home Depot, Domino’s, Dunkin’, and Costco locations combined. Annual revenues are estimated to be more than forty billion dollars.

People who work in self-storage often say that their market is driven by “the four D’s”: death, displacement, divorce, and downsizing, all life events that entail sudden collisions between stuff accumulation and reality. Years ago, Paul Roossin, an A.I. technologist and former neuroscientist, moved from a house in the suburbs to an apartment in Manhattan, and, because he thought he might want to move back to the suburbs someday, he rented a twenty-by-forty-foot storage space in Queens, for things that he no longer had room for. The facility was accessible by subway, and he visited from time to time. “Literally, though, years would pass,” he told me. Among the items he stored were a synthesizer, a piano, and a Hammond organ. At some point, he donated all three to a nonprofit, and once they were no longer blocking his view of the interior of his unit he was reminded of possessions that he had forgotten he owned. He later downsized from his downsizing, over a period of months, with help from a friend.

There's probably a fifth D: the delusion that your children will want the items you're planning to bequeath to them, especially the kind of furniture that used to be called antiques but that young people for some time have referred to derisively as "brown." My wife and I moved from a large house to a smaller one a few years ago, and, as we were debating what to get rid of, we rented a portable storage unit from a company called *Pods*. Our pod cost about a hundred and fifty dollars a month, plus pickup and drop-off fees, and we kept it for a couple of months. (We also could have paid the company to store it for us, indefinitely, at one of its big warehouses.) Our plan was to fill it with redundant household items, including furniture that we no longer had room for, and send it to our daughter and her family, who live a hundred and fifty miles away. We did eventually send it to her, although she was interested in so few of our things that we had trouble filling it. Two items she did want—an Eames chair that had belonged to my father and a mid-century Danish desk that had belonged to my wife's parents—I wouldn't have minded keeping, but by that point I was so relieved that she wanted anything at all that I happily parted with them.

The most American of America's recent contributions to the global built environment—joining Egyptian pyramids, Greek temples, domed Byzantine churches, and so forth—are the fulfillment centers of major retail corporations. The buildings are easy to spot from the air, because they're immense, low, rectangular, flat-roofed, windowless, and, typically, clustered in industrial parks near airports and other transportation hubs. Self-storage facilities are almost always smaller, and they're less likely to be encircled by eighteen-wheelers, but they're similar in design and construction. Recently, it occurred to me that the ideal place to open a self-storage facility might be in the middle of one of those industrial parks, surrounded by fulfillment centers. That way, when you bought something from Amazon, it could be delivered directly to your storage unit, bypassing your cluttered home and sparing you the embarrassment of not remembering what you'd ordered the day before.

My friend Ray Underwood used to run an excavation company founded by his father. (I once watched him use a backhoe to retrieve a ballpoint pen that a health-department official had accidentally dropped into a deep test hole. He brought it up in one try, along with maybe a teaspoonful of dirt.)

Underwood also owned a good-sized piece of commercial property in our town, on which he built a gas station and convenience store. He was thinking about adding a car wash, but a friend told him that he really ought to build a self-storage facility. This was in the nineties, before real-estate investment trusts and private-equity firms had fully appreciated the cash-cow potential of housing people's stuff, so there weren't many similar facilities around. Winning zoning approval wasn't easy—partly my fault; I was on the commission—but eventually he got permits, in three phases, for six prefabricated metal buildings.

Underwood's facility contains a hundred and forty-five units, varying in size from twenty-five to three hundred square feet. "In the third phase, we added mostly ten-by-thirties, because people kept asking for bigger and bigger," he told me. Most of his customers store what you'd expect: ordinary garage overflow, gently used exercise equipment, out-of-season sporting goods, and furniture made superfluous by moving, renovation, or winter. About a quarter of the customers are local contractors or business owners, who store small machinery, tools, supplies, merchandise, or paperwork that they're legally required to hang on to. The smallest units go for about eighty dollars a month, the largest for about three hundred. The facility has a website, but if you want to learn about rates or reserve a unit you have to call or e-mail Underwood's sole employee, who is married to a former resident state trooper and used to be the town's treasurer. If you don't live or work nearby, she may ask you a few questions. (An occasional issue for self-storage operators is people who rent units with no intention of paying for them, in order to get rid of stuff that would be expensive to dispose of properly.) The buildings require virtually no maintenance. "It's as simple as I could make it," Underwood said.

Newer self-storage facilities are often bigger, fancier, and more technologically advanced. Recently, I visited a four-year-old Extra Space location in Wildwood, Florida, an hour northwest of Orlando. It's one of many facilities on the outskirts of the vast, golf-cart-dependent gerontopolis known as the Villages, which covers nearly sixty square miles in three counties, has some two hundred and fifty pickleball courts, offers live music and walker-friendly dancing every night of the week, and is growing as fast as the universe is expanding. People who retire to the Villages almost

always come from houses where they had more space, and if they don't off-load their surplus possessions before they move they need a place to stash them. Kerry Copeland, who oversees twenty Extra Space locations in that part of Florida, showed me around. "There are about seven hundred and fifty units here, all climate-controlled," he said. The building is three stories tall, and customers can drive right into it by means of a ground-level tunnel. Some of the biggest units open directly onto the tunnel and are large enough to park trucks in. Copeland punched a code into a keypad, and we rode an elevator to the second floor. Motion-activated lights came on as we walked through a maze of air-conditioned aisles. Fire sprinklers were visible overhead. Every surface was pristine. Almost all the units we passed were rented.

Something I didn't encounter during my tour with Copeland was other human beings. (People who have storage units tend to visit them about as often as they visit elderly relatives in nursing homes.) Earlier that day, I'd stopped by a competing facility, a few miles away, where I did see some renters—an older couple who had parked their pickup truck in front of a row of non-climate-controlled units. They had opened the doors of two of them, and the man, who wasn't wearing a shirt, was talking on his phone and using his free hand to move stuff around. The woman was only intermittently visible, behind tall, jumbled piles: Christmas decorations, including an artificial tree and a toddler-size nutcracker-type figure; two big grills, one charcoal and one propane; a compound miter saw and an assortment of other large power tools; several plastic garment bags; hard-to-identify pieces of folding furniture, probably chairs. The bed of their truck contained what looked like a radio-controlled toy car, so it's possible that they were either preparing for or recovering from a visit by grandchildren.

Many of the items that the couple had stored were of the type that people keep in basements, but the high water table in most of Florida makes basements a rarity. A useful tip I got from Copeland is that, if you expect to visit your unit reasonably often, or if you've hired other people to fill it for you, it makes sense to rent one that's larger than the volume of your possessions, so that you have room to maneuver. I can confirm from experience that this is sound advice. A few years ago, my wife and her siblings moved their mother from a large one-bedroom apartment to a

single room, and they rented a storage unit to hold her surplus stuff while they debated what to do next. Everything fit, barely, but removing items from the back was like working a Rubik's Cube.

One of the most significant innovations in the world of finance has been the automatically recurring credit-card charge. Like many people, I never pay bills anymore in the old-fashioned sense of sitting down at the dining-room table with a month's worth of ominous-looking envelopes, a letter opener, a checkbook, and a roll of stamps. Fees for my phone, internet, streaming services, media subscriptions, in-car satellite radio, trash pickup, post-office box, cloud storage, and who knows what else all quietly appear on one or another of my credit-card statements. Other monthly payments, including car loans, electric bills, and Medicare and Medigap fees, disappear automatically from what I still think of as my checking account, even though I hardly ever write checks.

Enabling people to pay for things without consciously paying for them is good for the business of many businesses. Last year, two professors from Stanford and one from Texas A. & M. published a paper in the *American Economic Review* in which they conclude, based on transaction data from a large payment-card network, that "cancellation frictions roughly double seller revenues on average." In large part, this is because credit and debit cards have made it easier for people to become what the professors call "inertial consumers." An increasingly popular remedy for such people, they point out, is using services that "help subscribers find and cancel unwanted subscriptions"—for a subscription fee, of course.

Cancellation frictions are a boon to the self-storage industry. The annoying, time-consuming, and often expensive chore of emptying a junk-filled storage unit is easy to postpone for a month, and then for one more, especially if an unnerving paper bill never arrives. (Some facilities increase retention by offering discounts for automatic payments, or requiring them outright. Credit-card billing also makes it easier for customers to overlook rate increases.) My wife and I have a friend whose mother died in 2006. She and her siblings decided to sell their mother's furniture and donate the proceeds to a charity that she would have approved of. "We put everything in storage temporarily, and it's all still there," our friend told me. She

figures that they've spent at least fifty thousand dollars in rental fees so far—more than they could get from selling the furniture.

Sometimes customers simply stop paying. One of the attractions of self-storage as a business is that evicting stuff is easier than evicting people. A facility owner can overlock a delinquent unit and, after meeting certain statutory requirements, sell the abandoned contents at a public auction. This past spring, at the Inside Self-Storage World Expo, an annual trade show in Las Vegas, I met Chris Rosa, the director of business development at StorageTreasures, one of many companies that conduct such auctions. He told me that he had originally planned to become a high-school history teacher, but after graduating from college he worried that teaching didn't offer enough financial security and decided to become an auctioneer instead. He attended auction school ("mind-numbingly boring") and is now licensed in twenty-five states.

In 2010, while Rosa was learning the art of "bid calling"—the rhythmic patter that auctioneers use to keep bidders bidding—the reality show "Storage Wars" premiered, on A&E. "Behind these doors are some of the world's best-kept treasures," a voice-over on the show says. "But when storage bills go unpaid the contents within are put up for auction." In an early episode, father-and-son bidders named Darrell and Brandon discover that buried deep in an unpromising-looking unit they've just bought for a hundred and forty-five dollars is a pair of handmade boots worn by Shelley Duvall in the movie "Popeye," accompanied by a certificate of authenticity. An acquaintance who buys and sells movie props tells them that the boots are worth at least fifteen hundred dollars—a tenfold return on their investment. Windfalls like that made some viewers believe that buying other people's forsaken stuff could be an easy path to riches. "At my first storage auctions, three, four, or five people would show up," Rosa said. "Two weeks later, it was ten people. By the end of the year, at the height of the show, it was a hundred and fifty."



"His knee bone's connected to some very bad people."

Cartoon by Benjamin Schwartz

The auctions on "Storage Wars," which is now in its eighteenth season, are conducted in person, on the premises, but in recent years almost all non-reality-show auctions have taken place online. Whether the auctions are live or virtual, people bidding on a unit can examine its contents only from the outside, without opening boxes or rummaging around, and if they win they have to clear out everything. Genuine treasures do turn up, but auction winners inevitably discover that someone who has stopped paying the rent on a five-by-ten wasn't using it to store gold bullion and that, for every certified pair of Olive Oyl boots, there are bushels of broken toys, outdated computer cables, spit-up-stained baby clothes, and greasy car parts, all of which they have to haul away. The regular bidders on "Storage Wars," whom the producers tend to portray as scheming rivals, are experienced at judging and unloading junk, since many of them have run secondhand stores, consignment shops, auction companies, or other resale outlets. They also have trucks.

Last year, a retired Episcopal priest I know was asked to perform an exorcism at a storage facility. "A man told me after church one Sunday that for a couple of weeks he had felt an evil physical presence on his chest in bed at night, and that it was trying to kill him," he said. The man also heard noises in the walls, at home and at work, and he had decided that the cause was a demon inhabiting an antique wardrobe he had bought: a large piece of brown. The Episcopal Church's "Book of Occasional Services" has a

section on exorcisms, which priests can perform as a last resort in certain circumstances. The man's situation didn't qualify, but the liturgy for "Celebration for a Home," in the same book, includes the invocation "Let the mighty power of the Holy God be present in this place to banish from it every unclean spirit." The priest and a colleague went from room to room in the man's house, reading prayers from that liturgy and sprinkling holy water, and then did the same in his storage unit, to which he had banished the wardrobe. His wife later told the priest that her husband had felt relief for a few days, but that the real cause of his torment had probably been a brain tumor.

Five years ago, self-storage was one of the most profitable segments of the real-estate industry, with higher annual returns than multifamily housing, office complexes, and retail stores. Growth and revenues got a big boost from *COVID*, partly because people who were trapped at home suddenly realized that they needed to make room for remote working, remote schooling, and staying out of one another's way. (A sixth D might be disease.) So many new facilities were built that some of the most desirable markets are now saturated or close to it, but people still buy stuff that they don't have room for, and rising mortgage rates have forced many people to defer plans to move into larger living spaces.

Speakers at the Inside Self-Storage expo sessions that I sat in on were divided in their assessments of the industry's near-term prospects, but they all agreed that technology and A.I. have become increasingly important. Andrew Capranos, the president (at the time) of a self-storage company based in North Carolina, said, "There is nothing that I can do better than A.I." Facility owners use it to determine what their competitors are charging, and developers use it to streamline their permit applications. Technology is transforming the management side, too. A customer can now often price, rent, and access a unit using just a phone, without interacting directly with another person—a make-or-break feature for many younger renters.

Armaan Premjee, whom I also met at the expo, owns two self-storage facilities, in Texas and Louisiana, and, with the help of A.I., he can run them from Barcelona, where he now lives. "Claude handles our rental-rate

increases,” he told me. He also uses A.I. to answer phone calls and e-mails. New tenants receive an automated text containing their unit’s padlock combination. Premjee pays people to check the properties once a month. (Break-ins are an issue in some areas, especially outside the prime markets. A profitable sideline for a growing number of facility owners is selling personal-property protection.)

Premjee was born in California in 1997, grew up in Mumbai, moved back to the U.S. for college, and earned a graduate business degree in London. He told me that he had become interested in real estate after Googling “how to get rich” and that his father had helped him make his first purchase, a small commercial lot, which he bought for twenty-six hundred dollars and sold three days later for forty-four hundred. More deals followed. “I knew flipping was a good way to make active income,” he told me. “But I needed something that made me money in my sleep.” Self-storage appealed to him, he said, partly because it didn’t involve “toilets and tenants.”

I asked Premjee whether he saw possibilities for growth in Europe, where, compared with Americans, people are less likely to accumulate excessive quantities of stuff. “I think there’s a massive opportunity,” he said. The average home in Europe is half the size of the average home in the U.S., and Amazon delivers there, too. (I asked a Welsh facility manager I met in Las Vegas what his customers keep in their units, and he said, “It’s . . . it’s . . . rubbish.”) “When they look at the U.S., they kind of laugh,” Premjee continued. “Europeans are getting double the rent per square foot.” There are also opportunities in Asia and the Middle East. Premjee recently visited a multistory facility in Dubai. “It had a huge staff on site, and they did valet storage, with pickup and drop-off,” he said. “There were eight or ten people in the office just doing sales and customer-support issues. And, to give you an idea of the rents there, a ten-by-twenty goes for seven hundred dollars a month, and they’re ninety-eight per cent occupied.”

Inside Self-Storage was founded in 1991 by Troy Bix, who had previously worked as a classified-ad salesman. In 2017, convinced that the golden age of self-storage had passed, he sold the company. “I’m not that smart, but I listen to my grandkids,” he told me. “And they don’t give a shit about hanging on to stuff.” At any rate, Bix is still a prominent figure at the expo.

I met him at a booth promoting his current enterprise, Toy Storage Nation, which he founded in 2020 as the “voice of the RV and boat storage industry.” Sales of R.V.s and boats surged during *COVID*, because the pandemic made many other forms of vacationing difficult, but first-time purchasers often discovered that their homeowners’ associations prohibited them from keeping their new toys in their driveways or yards. According to an information sheet that Bix and his wife were handing out, the U.S. now has forty-eight hundred dedicated R.V.-and-boat-storage facilities and more than twenty-eight thousand hybrid facilities. Toy Storage Nation conducts seminars, produces podcasts, and advises owners, operators, and potential investors. Bix said, “They’re building half a million new boats and R.V.s a year now, and seventy per cent of them are beholden to an H.O.A. Ding!”

Among the more recent additions to the storage universe are car condos, which are units capacious enough to fit entire toy collections. They frequently include what are known in the industry as mezzanines, upper levels outfitted like living spaces. When I was young, my father owned a succession of serious R.V.s, the last of which was thirty-five feet long and had features that he had designed, among them cup holders large enough for liquor bottles. He parked it on a thick concrete pad that he’d had added to the end of our driveway. (No H.O.A. in our neighborhood.) He liked travelling in it, but what he really liked was hanging out inside it while drinking cocktails with friends and family, and if he could have done that while parked in an air-conditioned man cave he might never have taken it on the road.

The fanciest car condos sell for well over a million dollars, even though they’re often just big metal boxes. A developer I met in Florida showed me photos of a huge one whose owner used it to store and display his collection of German sports cars, one of which he’d mounted on a wall, like a decoration. The unit had a kitchen, a bathroom, a wet bar, and a carpeted mezzanine that included an office, a pair of Formula 1 racing simulators, a zebra-skin rug, a pool table, a sitting area, and a tripod-mounted rifle that seemed to be aimed at a big-screen TV. Katherine D’Agostino, who lives in Lincoln, Nebraska, and owns a consulting firm called Self-Storage Ninjas, told me, “The first really crazy car condo I ever saw was at a facility called Monte Carlo Garage Suites, in Indian Land, South Carolina. I told the

owner it was amazing, and he said, ‘This is just the one my wife knows about.’ ”

D’Agostino has an M.B.A. from the University of Nebraska, and she used to own a housecleaning business. “I grew the revenue to, like, \$1.3 million a year, but I got tired of employees calling me at 10 *P.M.* to tell me they were sick or their grandma had died,” she said. D’Agostino sold the cleaning business, built storage facilities in Nebraska, Illinois, and Texas, and learned so much about the industry that she began doing feasibility studies for others. She’s now developing “small-bay flex” spaces, which are similar in construction to self-storage buildings but are occupied by small businesses and light manufacturers—coffee roasters, last-mile deliverers, microbrewers, plumbing contractors, the occasional gastropub.

D’Agostino’s business partner is a self-storage designer from Wisconsin, who showed me renderings for an upscale facility that they’re hoping to build. I would describe the structure as a strip mall reconceived by a storage ninja. He and D’Agostino are pursuing sites for two separate projects near the Villages.

One afternoon during the expo, I boarded a bus for a field trip to an R.V.-and-boat facility next to a Love’s Travel Stop, about twenty-five miles from the Strip. It’s directly across Highway 93 from Apex Regional Landfill, which covers roughly two thousand acres and, at the area’s current rate of stuff-dumping, is said to have two hundred and fifty years’ worth of remaining capacity. During the bus ride, I sat across the aisle from a talkative man in his early sixties who was wearing a big hat. I overheard him telling someone next to him that he’d had a liver transplant and was “making up for lost time” by building a storage facility in Virginia for two hundred R.V.s.

The site we visited had been built by a company called Baja Carports. It consisted of ten covered but unenclosed structures of various sizes on a seven-and-a-half-acre asphalt lot adjacent to the truck stop. The facility had its own security fence, gated entrance, and office. A man from California, who was used to dealing with that state’s stringent environmental regulations, asked how the facility handled oil leaks in its drainage system, and the manager said, in effect, “Come on, man! This is Las Vegas!” (The

facility is flanked by desert.) Three of the structures had solar panels on the roof—a Baja specialty—and the manager said that they produced enough electricity to meet most of the needs of the truck stop while also providing a five-amp trickle charge for many of the tenants.

Almost all the toys parked at Love’s were R.V.s, plus an assortment of boats, trucks, and cars. The shade provided by the canopies made the spaces noticeably cooler than the uncovered pavement, which felt hot enough to melt truck tires. The man with the hat and the new liver told me that, if it had been up to him, he would have installed vertical shading along the western end of the lot, too, to block the setting sun. I walked around with identical twin sisters from Alabama, one a lawyer and the other a real-estate broker. They told me that they were getting ready to take over three storage facilities owned by their father, a developer, who had been occupied for some time with buildings of his that were severely damaged by thunderstorms and a tornado in 2025. The sisters had come to Las Vegas to listen to experts and gather ideas. Self-storage isn’t necessarily the bonanza that it has been at certain times in the past, but they were by no means the only attendees I met who believe that there are still fortunes to be made.

“We’re a stuff society,” the lawyer twin said. ♦

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[A Reporter at Large](#)

She Made Me Do It

A prominent dressage trainer shot a belligerent student—and now maintains that he’s the real victim.

By [Ian Parker](#)

September 14, 2026



Michael Barisone, at his horse-training center in Florida. In 2019, he shot his student Lauren Kanarek twice in the chest. His lawyers convinced a jury that she had driven him insane. Photograph by Stefan Ruiz for The New Yorker

Until 2019, when he attempted to kill one of his students, Michael Barisone was a leading rider and trainer in the horse-handling sport of dressage. Today, he still owns a dressage farm in Loxahatchee, Florida, twenty miles inland from Palm Beach. This part of the state, drained by a grid of canals and centered on the village of Wellington, is the winter capital of America’s equestrian world. Barisone’s operation is relatively modest: there’s no high hedge, no entrance arch. On five acres, he has a stucco house that’s connected to a barn; white-fenced paddocks shaded by palms; and an outdoor riding ring. Along one end of the ring is a common neighborhood fixture: an eighty-foot-long mirror. Barisone, who’s in his early sixties, with a big Will Ferrell chin and a muscular build, can hold a conversation about his own good judgment, and the iniquity of his enemies, while riding a horse and monitoring his own reflection.

In dressage competitions, horses follow a short sequence of bouncing walks and trots, pirouettes and figures-of-eight. It's an exhibition of control. A horse should do as it's asked, in a way that projects noble interspecies harmony. Although dressage people have sometimes hoped to broaden their sport's appeal by calling it "horse dancing," that may create false expectations. In dressage's usual form, one discrete movement follows another in a compulsory sequence. There may be a kind of flow, but there's no sustained rhythm. Competitive dressage less resembles dancing than it does a D.M.V. road test—or floor exercises, if every gymnast had to do the same thing.

Barisone learned dressage during a middle-class childhood in far-upstate New York, and soon excelled at it. In the first of several meetings that I had with him last winter, in Loxahatchee and in New Jersey, he said that, given his ability, he "should have" competed in ten Olympic Games, going back to the eighties. It's easy to sympathize with an athlete's disappointments, but Barisone's narrative of near-misses spans decades. He did represent the United States at the Beijing Olympics, in 2008, as the designated backup for a three-person team. He didn't ride.



Barisone competed in many international dressage competitions and represented the United States as a designated backup in the 2008 Summer Olympics, in Beijing. He is pictured here in 2009, in Florida. Photograph by Amy Katherine Dragoo / Reuters

But when Barisone proposed to me that for twenty years he was the dressage equivalent of a major-league-baseball player, that seemed fair—with the caveats that there's no league and no real audience. He competed at a high level; his income derived from selling horses he'd trained, and from coaching amateur dressage enthusiasts—his “ladies,” as he tends to call them—and their horses, along with a handful of Olympic-level professionals. Barisone and his former wife Vera Kessels followed the migration patterns of their people. They spent winters in Loxahatchee and summers at their other farm—since vacated—in western New Jersey. Barisone sat on dressage-world committees; he was, he told me, a “revered” member of the dressage community. In a 2012 episode of “The Colbert Report,” Stephen Colbert was shown riding in breeches and tails while Barisone, holding a whip, walked alongside him. Colbert's horse was persuaded to piaffe—to trot in place, knees up, in a way that's required in advanced dressage competitions. Barisone recently proposed that he was, at that moment, “the most famous horseman in the country.”

In Barisone's Loxahatchee kitchen there is a dark-green safe the size of a vending machine. It used to stand in his office on the New Jersey farm. He has never seriously contested the idea that, on August 7, 2019, he took a handgun from the safe and drove a few hundred yards, to a house on his property where Lauren Kanarek, a thirty-eight-year-old student of his, was boarding with her boyfriend. He shot her twice.

“I did *everything right*,” Barisone told me, a number of times, during long conversations held, over several days, at his kitchen table in Florida. His dominant tone was one of astonished resentment. He has the manner—and the abundance of files in Bankers Boxes—of someone struggling to correct a great miscarriage of justice. One could mistake him for an inmate preparing an appeal in a prison library. As we talked, I sometimes found it disorienting to remember that Barisone is a free man. His fiancée, Lara Osborne, usually joined us at the table; there were dogs and cats underfoot, in a sunny house with no mortgage and several pickup trucks out front. Now and then, a neigh carried through the kitchen's French doors.

In 2022, Barisone was tried in New Jersey for attempted murder. He was found not guilty by reason of insanity. This was a remarkable verdict. Fewer than one per cent of Americans charged with felonies plead insanity, and the great majority of those who do have previously been hospitalized with a serious psychiatric condition. Barisone had no history of serious mental illness, and by the end of 2023 he had no such illness, according both to his own account and to the State of New Jersey.

This rare court-sanctioned narrative—sanity, criminal insanity, quick reversion to sanity—might seem like tremendous luck, given that he faced a decade or two in prison. But this isn't how Barisone has experienced his freedom. It wasn't surprising to hear him mourn what he'd lost since shooting someone in the chest twice. But it was striking to hear how fiercely he resented having lost anything at all. (He has lost time and money, and he can no longer compete in dressage.) "I want my dignity back," he told me. "I want my reputation back."



Cartoon by Sarah Kempa

The first time I called him, he said, of the case, "You're going to find it is a John Grisham novel combined with 'Fatal Attraction' combined with 'Yellowstone.'" Barisone's story has its evident hero, and its villain is Kanarek, his victim. In this presentation of events—a "scum of the earth" client, in his words, and a terrific guy who snapped, as anyone would have

—Barisone has enjoyed near-universal support from the dressage community, and beyond. In much of the online discussion about the case, including in the forums of *The Chronicle of the Horse*, a long-established magazine, commenters have identified two victims, not one, and have almost always found Barisone’s victimhood the more compelling. A woman was shot, but a man was driven to shoot her, because she was annoying, and at times belligerent, in person and on social media. Kanarek has been widely scorned as a dressage interloper and as an embodiment of contemporary ills: a bullshitter, an entitled troll.

Barisone read me a note that he’d received after his acquittal, from a woman he didn’t know, who called Kanarek a “giant of wickedness.” The letter started, “Thank you for showing the rest of the world that good people can survive this kind of horrible torment and come out the winner.”

For Barisone, such regard isn’t enough. It doesn’t reset everything to how it was before he met Kanarek. “I will get to Trump,” he told me. “And I will get this undone. Watch me.” Since the shooting, Barisone has filed six lawsuits, and at least one more is being prepared. Last summer, about two years after a psychiatrist submitted to a court that Barisone bore “no ill will” toward Kanarek, Barisone filed a claim against the United States Equestrian Federation (*USEF*), for failing to punish her; it called her behavior “disgusting,” “abusive,” and “vulgar.” It also disparaged her riding ability and noted her acknowledged history of drug use. Barisone, meanwhile, was described as a man of substance; the document included his former financial assets and his dressage-competition results.

In Florida, Barisone imagined his vindication. He told me, “If this goes right—if I can make another team, a World Cup, a World Championship—I will be the biggest comeback story in the history of sports.”

On the day of the shooting, Kanarek was sitting alone on the porch outside the farmhouse where she was then living with Robert Goodwin, her boyfriend. The house was the first building that would be seen by a visitor to Barisone’s Hawthorne Hill Farm, in Morris County, New Jersey. A minute or so farther up a gravel road, just over a hill, stood a cluster of other buildings, where there was a clubroom, some bedrooms, horse stalls, and an indoor riding ring.

Kanarek, the eldest of three sisters, grew up in Livingston, a wealthy commuter town an hour's drive east. In her late teens and twenties, she'd gone through what she described to me as "a bad patch of crazy things." She didn't finish college; her sisters began corporate careers in New York City. It's clear that relations between Kanarek and her family had sometimes been strained, but her father, Jonathan Kanarek, a retired Wall Street equities trader, said in a recent call that there was never a rift. In a tone of disappointed acceptance, he brought up both her former drug-taking and a period, sometimes mentioned by Barisone and his allies, when she worked at a strip club. By 2016, Kanarek, who was then living in Greensboro, North Carolina, with Goodwin, a contractor, had revived a childhood enthusiasm for riding and taken up dressage. Jonathan called the sport "a great thing that led her out" of drugs. He and his wife, Kirby, helped out, both financially and by providing quotidian oversight, including of medical appointments.



Lauren Kanarek. In online forums, she has been widely scorned as a dressage interloper and as an embodiment of contemporary ills: a bullshitter, an entitled troll. Photograph by John Snyder / High Time Photography

In the spring of 2018, Lauren Kanarek paid for a month's training at Barisone's farm in Florida; she then began shuttling her two horses, seasonally, between his farms, as part of an arrangement that included lodging in New Jersey. In August, 2019, she and Goodwin were staying in the farmhouse's second-floor apartment. It had its own ground-level entrance, which opened onto the porch; from there, steps led down to a concrete patio.

At about 2 *P.M.*, Barisone's silver Ram truck appeared over the brow of the hill and pulled up by the patio. A few weeks earlier, relations between Barisone and Kanarek, which until then had been largely accommodating, and sometimes even playful, had suddenly turned fractious. They'd fallen out, in part over the care of her horses, but the dispute had skipped any intermediate stage of adult discord—say, pissily polite e-mails or form-letter threats of eviction. Each had begun working to destroy the other's reputation. But this had been playing out largely at arm's length, in the form of Facebook posts and duelling 911 calls. So Barisone's appearance at the farmhouse unnerved Kanarek. In a recent conversation, she recalled feeling a rush of adrenaline. She went back indoors.

Goodwin was on the phone with a lawyer whom Kanarek had retained the previous day. He handed her his phone and went outside. Barisone, who Goodwin later said looked "sorrowful," asked him, "How do we fix this? I don't want a war."

Goodwin said that they should let their lawyers handle things, and turned away. But Kanarek wanted to add that any resolution of their dispute had to include paying Goodwin for construction work he'd done on the farm, originally in a barter agreement. While she was still on the line with the lawyer, she approached Barisone.

In her memory, she and Barisone were standing just feet apart on the patio. Barisone is six feet three. Kanarek, who weighs about a hundred pounds, is five feet four. She had often taken a combative tone—in messages addressed to family members, or to old enemies, or to new ones she'd found among Trump supporters on Facebook. On this patio, a few weeks earlier, she'd had a pivotal confrontation with Barisone, arising out of a disagreement about horse feed. He'd loudly complained, and she'd also

complained. In such situations, she told me, “I’m going to stand tall and yell back at you and take you by surprise.” (After the confrontation, she wrote to Goodwin and her father, “I said some pretty TRUE and fucked up things that literally silenced him for a full minute.”)

According to Kanarek and to the testimony of Edward David, the lawyer on the phone, there was no verbal combat this time. Kanarek told me that she hadn’t even begun to speak when Barisone drew a gun from somewhere.

“I didn’t even know it was a real gun,” Kanarek recalled to me. “I’m seeing that it’s pink—camouflage pink and black.” Perhaps it just shoots BBs, she thought. She remembered saying, “Oh, my God.” Barisone fired. “It was immediate—*boom, boom*,” she told me. “It didn’t sound as loud as you would think.”

She dropped the phone. “I could see two complete holes in my shirt,” she told me. The holes were about two inches apart, above her left breast, near where a crocodile might be on a polo shirt. According to her account, Barisone then shot “at Rob’s head.” The bullet missed, and Goodwin retreated inside. Kanarek, laughing at her own description, recalled the “Superman moment” that followed: Goodwin seemed to fly back outside, horizontally. Goodwin is shorter than Barisone by about seven inches, but he also has a muscular build. He careened into Barisone and put him in a choke hold. During all this, one of the couple’s dogs yapped and bit at Barisone.

Kanarek told me that her bloody hands made it a struggle to call 911. When she got connected, she said, “I’ve been shot in the heart.”

On the recording of the 911 call, there’s a lot of barking, and some grunting from Goodwin, who says into the phone, “A man came here with a fucking gun. I’ve got him detained right now.” He also shouts, “Get that fucking dog inside now!” Goodwin has to be talking to Kanarek, which suggests that he hadn’t processed what had just happened. Kanarek hadn’t collapsed, and she could be hyperbolic when talking about ailments and injuries. (She’d recently written in a text that a spider bite had left her “150% incapacitated.”) But, as Kanarek tried to help debilitate Barisone by beating

his head with a phone, Goodwin saw two exit holes in the back of her sweatshirt.

Kanarek recalled feeling dizziness, and pressure in her chest: “I’m, like, ‘How do I put a tourniquet on this wound *that’s on my chest?*’ I was literally thinking, Do I have tampons?” She couldn’t breathe properly. It felt like “being in a pool and stuck under a raft that someone was on.”

The line to the 911 dispatcher was still open when, after about five minutes, a police officer, Derek Heymer, arrived at the farmhouse. Kanarek, who remained conscious, told him, “I’m shot—please help me.”

Other officers arrived, and Kanarek was treated with chest seals. Barisone, handcuffed, began to say, “I had a good life,” to no one in particular. The judge at his first hearing detected in this statement a fatalism that made him a possible continuing threat to himself and others—although the refrain could also have been interpreted as an expression of affront. Later that afternoon, Barisone, while being treated for a broken arm and other injuries at a local hospital, complained, “They destroyed my life.”

In an emergency operation in the same hospital, doctors opened up Kanarek’s chest. They clamped her aorta, to keep her alive—she’d lost about half the blood in her body—before repairing her lungs. Today, Barisone claims to have no memory of the time between being in his office up the hill and waking, the next day, with one arm shackled to a hospital bed.

Barisone recently described the equestrian world, whose respect he craves, as “an incestuous cesspool of filth.” Judges and administrators are venal and corrupt; horse dealers are “shysters.” He told me, “I didn’t go into dressage for the love of the game.”

Barisone said that his riding prowess had its roots in grievance. He and his sister grew up in what he called a “ramshackle shithole” of a house, outside Rochester. His father was a technician at Xerox. His mother—whom he described with loathing, and with frequent reference to her obesity—had ridden horses during a childhood that was more prosperous than her married life. She opened a commercial horse barn on their land. According to

Barisone, this drained the family's resources and forced him into riding. By his early teens, he said, she was bullying him into teaching others to ride, and into breaking "junk" horses that she brought home. He recalled asking, "Can't I do Little League?" Barisone was scornful of his father's meekness: "He didn't say to her, 'Are you fucking *kidding* me? Get your fat ass out of here. You're not treating this kid this way.'



Barisone laments that he has been banned from a sport where he was once a "revered" member of the community. Photograph by Stefan Ruiz for The New Yorker

Barisone came to take competition seriously, he claimed, as a form of rebellion: "I finally said, 'You know what? You're going make me fucking ride? I'm going to *ride*.' " He also became skilled at training horses of all temperaments. "Some are narcissistic, some are difficult, some are tractable," Barisone told me. "They can be manipulative. They can be condescending." Gil Merrick, a former dressage trainer who was once the *USEF* official in charge of the sport, and who cemented a friendship with Barisone when they travelled together to the Beijing Olympics, recently said that he "didn't know a single person who didn't respect Michael." He admiringly contrasted Barisone's training instincts with more "froufrou" approaches. "It's not that he doesn't love the horses—he does—but he's

realistic about it,” Merrick said. “These are animals. . . . They’re going to submit to us.” A dressage horse has to trust its rider, but, “basically, your horse doesn’t *like* anything but being in the pasture eating grass,” Merrick explained. “He’s in the ring because you put straps on his face, a saddle on his back, and you’ve got spurs on your legs, and when you touch the spur on his side he thinks mountain lions are about to break through his rib cage.”

Barisone didn’t attend college and has only ever worked with horses. (As a hobby, he restores trucks and muscle cars.) By the second half of the nineties, he was competing in major overseas dressage competitions. A brief first marriage dissolved. In 2000, when he was in his mid-thirties, he married Kessels, a Dutch dressage rider. They built a house and a barn on a plot in Loxahatchee that he bought; they also set up the New Jersey operation, on fifty-four acres bought by a retired lawyer. The company was called Barisone Dressage; he shared training duties with Kessels—and, later, with Justin Hardin, a longtime employee. Some clients paid a monthly fee for the farm to board and train their horses. Barisone also taught lucrative multiday dressage workshops, or “clinics,” around the country. “Absolutely love his style,” a clinic student wrote online in 2013. “You do have to be willing to put up with a certain amount of ‘when I was at the Olympics’ stories.”

Barisone told me that by 2018 he was billing more than seven hundred thousand dollars a year. But by then he was also negotiating a divorce from Kessels. When we spoke, Barisone projected breeziness about the breakup, and he always described Kessels, who died last year, as “a great lady.” But it was clearly difficult for the couple to divide their assets without dismantling the business. Barisone likes to be recognized as unusually skilled at fixing things—drywall, fencing, a 1969 Chevelle, a weird horse—but he couldn’t control a drawn-out legal process. Privately, he complained that Kessels was being “defiant.” During the breakup, he was given prescriptions for Xanax, to treat anxiety, and an antidepressant. (He has acknowledged combining Xanax with alcohol, which is firmly discouraged.) He had some sessions with a therapist whom he’d seen around the time his first marriage ended. After his divorce from Kessels was

finalized, he texted Mary Haskins Gray, a dressage rider who had become his girlfriend. “I got clipped 965k,” he wrote. “Hard to feel good.”

When Kanarek became a client of Barisone’s, in March, 2018, she began paying him about five thousand dollars a month, which helped. Today, she and Goodwin live in Florida, just a few miles from Barisone. In one of my recent phone calls with her, which had similarities to my conversations with Barisone—myth-building, conspiracy claims, overconfidence in dubious legal “proofs”—she included herself in the category of people who “ride for a living.” This was surprising language. The sport has never brought her income. At the time that she was paying Barisone, she also added to her collection of horses, at a cost of tens of thousands of dollars. In addition, she was supporting Goodwin and paying for vets, farriers, horse transportation, show fees, and saddles. (Jonathan Kanarek described himself to me as the effective guarantor of these costs, if not always the ultimate payer: his daughter, he said, has had other financial sources, including a bequest from an uncle.)

Dressage doesn’t demand youth or a particular body type. One competitor at the Beijing Olympics was sixteen; another was sixty-seven. A rider can buy accelerated progress in the form of a “push button” horse that’s been highly trained by someone like Barisone. And, in part because dressage is expensive, the competitive circle is small. You meet your heroes. Any hobby can start to feel like a vocation, but if an adult student of financial means had daydreams, during her first dressage lesson, about competing internationally, this would be less absurd than someone having the same fantasy while learning to ski. And if this dressage student posted a video of her ride—in horse attire, with some French in the hashtags—it might seem more like an *accomplishment*, to untutored friends, than the beginner’s ski lesson.

According to Merrick, the former dressage official, a peculiarly high percentage of relatively advanced amateur riders believe, firmly and falsely, that Olympic competition is a real possibility. He referred to the dressage trainer’s challenge of working with clients whose wealth brings a “high sense of entitlement.” He said, “They lash out—‘I spent the money. I’m showing up. *Why isn’t this working?*’ ”

Barisone recalled the first time he saw Kanarek: “My head is spinning. This has got to be a joke. This woman, she’s hopeless.” Her horses were “garbage.” Barisone’s scorn sounded forced. He regularly worked with middling riders, and Kanarek seems to have been about as competent as one would expect after a few years of training. Privately, she blustered about how fast she expected to ascend dressage’s levels—the sport’s equivalent of martial-arts belts—and in 2019 her Facebook profile picture showed her with the sport’s biggest star, Isabell Werth, a German who has won medals at seven Olympics. But Kanarek wasn’t delusional about making the Olympics. Barisone may have registered a disconnect between her investment of time and money in the sport and her skill, but, as he put it to me, “in this business, we’d all be broke if we weeded out bullshitters.”

After Kanarek’s first month in Florida, Barisone invited her to New Jersey for the summer. He then invited her back to Florida, and then, in 2019, back to New Jersey. He didn’t draw up a lease for the apartment. He didn’t run a background check or ask for references. Later, when Kanarek added two horses to the two she already kept with Barisone, he accepted Goodwin’s construction work on the farm as payment for their keep. Barisone is now committed to a “Misery”-like narrative of being preyed on by Kanarek from the start. More believable is that a trainer certain of his ability to control things took on a client who didn’t care to be controlled.



*“Maybe not the best use of the defense budget.”
Cartoon by Dan Misdea*

These arrangements were brokered by Jonathan Kanarek. He and Barisone clearly got along, and they seem to have concurred on the question of how once dashing men of a certain age should do business together. In a text that Jonathan sent to Kanarek and Barisone a few weeks before the shooting, he proposed, in a spirit of peacemaking, that “Michael and I just wanna conduct business professionally and have happy lives. Aggravation from daughters, girlfriends or wives will not be tolerated.” (Soon afterward, Jonathan—at a meeting to introduce Kanarek and Goodwin to his old acquaintance Edward David, the lawyer—joked about his wife’s irresistibly “slutty” Texan accent. A recorder in Goodwin’s pocket taped the meeting; Goodwin says that the recording was accidental.)

A year after Barisone shot Kanarek, Jonathan introduced himself by e-mail to a prominent dressage rider. “Michael and I made agreements with only a handshake,” he wrote appreciatively. “He always tried to be true to his word.”

One day, Barisone and I went out for lunch in Wellington. On a looping drive, we passed new gated developments and older horse-oriented estates built on a country-club scale. Gesturing across a large tract of land, he said, “My old friends the McPhails bought the whole thing.” Then: “That’s for sale—fifty acres. That was owned by Mary Alice Dorrance Malone, the heiress to the Campbell’s Soup fortune. She just passed away. . . . Her son-in-law is a friend.”

As Barisone drove, he also recalled his agitated state of mind on the day of the shooting. Because of Kanarek, he said, he had become tearful and distracted. That morning, in a Home Depot, he’d had a moment of big-box ennui: he’d wandered blankly, half searching for smoke alarms, then left with nothing.

He and Mary Haskins Gray had returned to New Jersey that April and moved into the farmhouse’s ground-floor apartment. Gray’s children, not yet teen-agers, sometimes came to stay. Kanarek and Goodwin moved into the apartment above.

Kanarek had come to feel, with a little justice, that she couldn’t always rely on Barisone’s handshakes. She’d had to press him about living

arrangements for that second summer; she'd shown frustration about the amount of training time Barisone was giving her, and about her access to a horse of Barisone's that she liked. (She eventually bought it.)

Put another way—and this is evidently how Gray saw it—Kanarek was always complaining. She'd fallen out with Hardin, Barisone's lieutenant. She could be self-dramatizing and accusatory; she was often late to scheduled rides.

Gray, who did not respond to interview requests for this article, clearly wanted Kanarek to leave the farm. By the spring of 2019, there had been at least hints of something that became clearer in the days before the shooting, and very clear when the legal process gave lawyers access to mounds of private electronic communications: Kanarek and Goodwin were a mess. Many people would have hesitated before taking them on as tenants, housemates, or clients. Barisone had allowed them to become all three. Goodwin had a history of drug use, and has acknowledged a relapse during this period; Kanarek, who at the time repeatedly messaged Goodwin about his abuse of crack, became frantic when he once disappeared overnight from Hawthorne Hill. Kanarek, a former heroin user, now took Suboxone to ease cravings. She was once charged with assault, following a bar fight, although she had no convictions. She was sustaining a vicious long-term feud with a woman in New Jersey whose child had drowned; Kanarek had called the woman a murderer. She talked to her own mother with contempt.

Her social-media output could look unrestrained in its tone and quantity. A post from that spring was signed, in a self-celebrating flourish, “#BiPolarNarcissist.” (Kanarek told me that for decades she has taken Seroquel, a medication most frequently prescribed to treat bipolar disorder and schizophrenia, but she said that she has used it only to treat insomnia.) One day not long before the shooting, her father texted her about something she'd posted on Facebook the previous night. She insisted that she'd posted nothing, but eventually acknowledged that, although she hadn't *posted*, she'd maybe “replied to 160 people.” (Ambien and other medications were to blame, she said.) Her forgotten replies included a pugnacious nine-hundred-word message about the Barisone situation: “Names will be named, threats to me will be revealed.” According to Merrick, the former

USEF official, dressage typically attracts riders who like “order and discipline.” Kanarek and her family seemed to be running an experiment in whether immersion in dressage can deliver a person from disarray.

In conversation, Barisone often implies something his online supporters assume to be true: that, long before he shot Kanarek, he had told her, clearly and often, to vacate his facility, and she had refused. In fact, as Barisone acknowledged to me, he had protected Kanarek’s right to stay when Gray had urged her to go during a meeting at the farm that spring. He recalled saying, “Let’s not get into things that cause us all kinds of problems.” According to Kanarek, Barisone told Gray, “Please shut the fuck up.” (Barisone denies using those words.)

Barisone told me that his pliancy toward Kanarek and Goodwin sprang from fear. He was being forced to harbor “terrorists”; he was a beaten spouse. Barisone was surely being more candid when, in another conversation, he framed his approach very differently: “Why ruffle feathers?” He worried that Jonathan Kanarek might sue him for something or other, and he didn’t want new legal fees. He could *make this work*.

Kanarek told me that Gray’s antagonism, at the meeting and at other times, positions her as the ultimate instigator of the shooting. “Part of me feels badly for Michael,” she said. “Which is insane for me to even think, because he has no remorse whatsoever.” Her father has spoken similarly. Shortly before the shooting, he texted Barisone that “everyone in the business knows your girlfriend has emasculated you.” Later, in his e-mail to the prominent dressage rider, he wrote, “There is no way Michael shoots anyone without being cajoled, tormented and tortured by his ‘girlfriend.’ ” This commentary is a mirror of how Barisone’s fans talk on the *Chronicle of the Horse* forums: responsibility for his violence must lie with a disobedient woman.

A couple of months before the shooting, Barisone and Kanarek were still living in the same building and still in friendly communication. In mid-June, Kanarek texted Barisone that her mother was about to visit, and added a face-palm emoji. Barisone texted, “Lucky you,” and Kanarek replied, “Please shoot me.” Barisone went on to describe his own mother: “Peg was evil. Fat-ass 300lb, asexual, angry, lesbian pig.” He recalled learning of her

death, in 2015. “They called me about 5 minutes after Peg croaked,” he wrote. “I felt nothing, had a beer, and went on my first date with Mary.”

During this period, Kanarek was still praising Barisone. “He’s good at finding the human in the horse,” she wrote to relatives. She quoted him comparing one of her horses, approvingly, to a gay bodybuilder “who hands out flowers to pedestrians as a good deed on his free time.”

In the second week of July, things changed. Kanarek and Gray had an argument about the feed being given to Kanarek’s horses. Kanarek reported this to her father, who sent Gray an e-mail suggesting that to intentionally misfeed Kanarek’s horses might be a crime. Three days later, on July 12th, Barisone and Kanarek argued about this on the patio. He told me that he instructed her to “cease and desist,” and that, instead, she got in his face. Barisone was astonished and affronted. The following day, he texted Gray, “I will just make it so miserable to be here that they will beg to go elsewhere. . . . Watch me.”

From then on, he was focussed on Kanarek: he and Gray scanned her Facebook history; he asked a private detective to do background checks on his guests; he contacted the woman whose son had drowned, and told her that Kanarek should “rot in hell.” He complained about Kanarek to *USEF* officials, and told Gray that he hoped to get Kanarek banned for life from competitive dressage.



“Well, you’ll have to come again sometime when you can’t stay as long.”

Cartoon by Teresa Burns Parkhurst

Kanarek, for her part, posted about Barisone and Gray on Facebook, first in the barely veiled form of a parable about a king and an “imposter” queen. The queen’s “open attacks on ME will not result in execution,” she wrote. “Instead, it will result in the same ending Humpty Dumpty endured . . . ‘All the king’s HORSES & all the king’s men—couldn’t put Humpty together again!’ ” Soon afterward, she posted that “EVEN a one time Olympian can be cut down to size. Even by someone like me. Maybe, especially by someone like me. Deep pockets & nothing to lose.” (This was part of the forgotten post that Kanarek’s father asked about.) These posts were surely unpleasant for Barisone to read, but it’s hard to see them as “manifestos” underlying a master plan, which became Barisone’s contention. They’re a preening, Ambien-inflected extension of an ongoing argument in which both sides engaged in displays of dominance. As Jonathan Kanarek put it to Edward David, the lawyer, Lauren “can out-crazy anybody. You’re better off pissing off a Colombian drug-lord.” Kanarek’s late-night posts also hid the fact, evident in quieter communications, that she knew she’d have to leave the farm before long.

Barisone and Gray moved out of the farmhouse and into the building with the clubroom, up the hill. They had to sleep on the floor, because Hardin and a few stable hands had the bedrooms. On July 31st, Barisone called 911, saying that Kanarek had been loudly threatening him. He said, of her and Goodwin, “They’re scumbags and I want them warned.” He called 911 again the next day and falsely described Kanarek and Goodwin as squatters. He hired a neighbor as a security guard. Ruth Cox, a horse-world friend, drove up from North Carolina. In her truck, she had a pink-and-black handgun.

During the first week of August, Kanarek started keeping a digital recorder in her locker, close to the horse stalls, on a voice-activated setting. In public and private messages, she tauntingly referred to things she’d overheard. “Now that your girlfriend has promised not to leave you, you should have your permission slip to conduct business as promised,” she wrote to Barisone, adding a blushing “whoops” emoji. (Barisone hired a debugging company but did not ask it to inspect the locker area.)

On August 2nd, Kanarek called in a formal complaint about Barisone and Gray to the U.S. Center for SafeSport. That body, established in 2017 in response to the crimes of Larry Nassar, the Michigan physician who serially abused young gymnasts, can investigate misconduct, including nonsexual misconduct, in any Olympic sport. Kanarek complained of racist and sexist jokes, harassment, and intimidation. She wrote on Facebook, “I’m being bullied by a 6’ 3 man. Bullied to the point I’m afraid. It’s very complicated—I’m not sure of what I can say here—but it seems as if Safe Sport was created exactly for this reason.”

On August 3rd, Barisone made a third 911 call, this time about a Facebook post. Kanarek also called 911, to report a suspicious vehicle and a possibly threatening conversation recorded by the device in her locker. The same day, Gray pointed out to Barisone, via text, that he had still not told Kanarek, “We’re evicting you.” This was true. After learning that an eviction might take weeks, he’d turned instead to the local police and the equestrian bureaucracy; he was clearly astonished that these bodies didn’t act immediately on his command. (In an e-mail to Sonja Keating, *USEF*’s general counsel, Barisone warned, “If this turns out in a disaster, which is imminent, someone will be responsible.”)

In the week before the shooting, Barisone did allow his sometime lawyer Steven Tarshis—also a friend and a dressage client—to speak with Jonathan about a negotiated exit for Kanarek, and they had exchanges that both men described to me as cordial. But, within days, Barisone had ended these negotiations. He described his thinking to me as “There’s no deal to be made! Get out!”

On August 4th, Barisone called 911 again. The next day, SafeSport announced that George Morris, one of America’s biggest equestrian stars, then in his early eighties, had been banned from his sport. Morris, a former show-jumping Olympic medallist who’d become a well-known trainer, is gay, and in a memoir published in 2016 he’d estimated that his sexual partners numbered ten thousand “and counting!” The equestrian world had long recognized his preference for younger men. The ban, which shut down Morris’s training business, followed a SafeSport investigation of sexual misconduct, years earlier, involving teen-agers. (Morris has denied

wrongdoing.) Barisone, in his kitchen, has a George Morris action figure that used to voice the blunt riding advice for which Morris was known. These days, Barisone and Morris have dinner in Florida regularly, and the conversation tends to turn to injustice. As Barisone put it to me, “It is a war on white men, both straight and gay.”

On the day of the ban, Morris and Barisone spoke by phone; Barisone commiserated with Morris but primarily shared his own distress, about Kanarek. That afternoon, Barisone drove to a police station and asked to speak to the chief. The chief wasn’t available to him; nor was his cell number. As Barisone later put it in a lawsuit, officers paid him no deference: they were “stone-faced” and “pushing out their chests.” Barisone’s rhetoric today moves seamlessly between anger over not being taken seriously as a victim of abuse and reluctance to recognize abuse in the actions of powerful men. Talking about a former Olympic show jumper who was convicted of sexually abusing a minor, Barisone described the crime as an “apparently consensual, albeit illegal, affair.”

On August 5th, Tarshis privately apologized to Jonathan Kanarek for Barisone’s handling of the conflict, then e-mailed Lauren to say that she and her horses had to be off the property in two days. Tarshis threatened eviction proceedings, although no eviction complaint was ever filed. (As Tarshis explained at trial, Barisone “did not want to start eviction—he wanted to scare her into leaving.”) After Kanarek received this letter, she and Goodwin wrote to town authorities, describing “VERY DANGEROUS & illegal” conditions at the farm. The day before the shooting, officials representing the local health, construction, and fire-prevention departments all came to Hawthorne Hill Farm, unannounced, to inspect the property. Because there were code violations, such as missing fire extinguishers, everyone who had been sleeping in the clubhouse building could no longer do so. They laid out mattresses on the front porch. That night, Barisone paced around the building, patrolling.

Early in the afternoon on August 7th, Barisone saw a minivan pull up outside the clubhouse. Vanessa Medrano-Cortez, a caseworker for New Jersey child-protective services, introduced herself. “The lady said, ‘I’m

here about a report of child abuse,’ or something like that,” Barisone told me. “And, of course, I knew right away. *She turned us in!*”

Medrano-Cortez asked to talk to Gray alone. They went into Barisone’s office. Within minutes, Barisone had interrupted them twice. On a third interruption, he asked them to use another room. He kissed Gray as she left. Barisone recalls telling himself, “I can’t breathe, and I’m thinking, *Call somebody, call somebody. I need help, I need help.* There is no one going to step in to save us from these monsters.” It was like “somebody had a tourniquet around my neck.”



“I didn’t even know it was a real gun,” Kanarek told me, of the shooting. “I’m seeing that it’s pink—camouflage pink and black.” Perhaps it just shot BBs, she thought. “It was immediate—boom, boom. It didn’t sound as loud as you would think.” Photograph by Saúl Martínez

Barisone told me that he had no memory of taking Ruth Cox’s gun from the safe, and proposed that he’d surely gone to the farmhouse “peacefully.” Barisone seems to have spoken a little differently in his meetings with Steven Simring, a forensic psychiatrist retained by his defense. Simring has reported that Medrano-Cortez’s arrival set Barisone on a path of remonstrance; it “precipitated his arming himself to defend himself, driving down, and having a confrontation.”

Barisone is writing a memoir. In his kitchen, he read from its opening, in which his self-portraiture fuses victimhood and pomp. The shooting, he writes, would “make headlines across the nation, as well as around the world.” It goes on, “The man who I had been died shortly after 2 *p.m.* that afternoon, a casualty of mortal wounds suffered in the age-old conflict between right and wrong. . . . Had an autopsy been performed, it would

have revealed the cause of my death to be a shattered dream and a broken heart.” The book’s working title is “Pure Evil.”

Barisone’s trial, delayed by the pandemic, began in March, 2022, in a courthouse in Morristown, New Jersey. He faced weapons charges and two counts of attempted murder; he’d previously turned down a plea agreement for a ten-year prison sentence. Cameras from Law&Crime, a streaming service, were set up in the courtroom.

Denied pretrial release, Barisone had been held in a local jail for two and a half years. He told me that Gray had broken off contact with him shortly after his arrest. Lara Osborne, a dressage rider whose teen-age daughter had been working at Hawthorne Hill in 2019, became a regular visitor and helped organize a GoFundMe for him; before long, they’d come to see themselves as a couple.

In jail, Barisone read through tens of thousands of pages of discovery documents, much of which comprised Kanarek’s postings and electronic communications. He became a reference service for his attorneys, and when Simring, the psychiatrist, asked for a digest of what he’d found, he cut out passages and glued them together. Deprived of scissors, he’d grown a long thumbnail. In Barisone’s telling, staff and fellow-inmates were awed by his diligence. He quoted a corrections officer saying, “We’ve never seen anything like this!”

On the day Kanarek nearly died, Susan Wachowich, the writer of DressageHub, a widely read and widely disparaged blog, posted an image featuring a celebratory cake and the words “Michael Barisone is my hero!” Posters at *The Chronicle of the Horse* began, with only a little more decorum, to pick over Kanarek’s online posturing and history of disputes. Kanarek, who was intubated for more than a week, was discharged from the hospital at the end of August; she almost immediately joined the *Chronicle* conversation.

She stuck to her preferred social-media register of snark and thrown elbows. This sometimes read oddly, given her circumstances, even if her central riposte—“Imagine being shot in the chest twice”—had unanswerable force. In one of her first posts after the shooting, she

wondered if her detractors were envious of her good horses. She also said, of Barisone's farm, "If my goal were to cause trouble I could do that for a much cheaper price than what I was paying." Later, her parents began posting; her father used the handle Inigo Montoya, for the Spanish swashbuckler in "The Princess Bride."

When I talked to Kanarek, she was sheepish about some of this material. After e-mailing me a note of thanks that she'd sent to police officers that September, she wondered if she should have waited to write it until she was no longer taking pain medication. ("I'm regretting the 'police officer' emoji!" she wrote to me.) But she never stopped commenting about the case online, on multiple forums. Today, a Reddit persona frequently writes about the shooting in Kanarek's voice, with intimate knowledge of her life and with access to discovery material. This persona has repeatedly claimed not to be Kanarek, but Kanarek acknowledged to me that this was her handle; she added, unconvincingly, that she shared authorship with someone.

Given Barisone's tales of his lawyerly industry in prison—and an account he gave me of using the barber services offered by an inmate who was later convicted of beating a three-year-old boy to death—his appearance in the courtroom was surprisingly chaotic. He was unshaven. His uncombed, graying hair nearly reached his shoulders. The knot of a yellow tie dangled below the collar of a baggy shirt. He rarely seemed to wear his glasses when the jury was in the room. He maintained a gargoyled expression of horror—eyebrows up, mouth pulled way down—and frequently pressed balled-up tissues against his eyes.

His lead trial attorney, Edward Bilinkas, a dapper New Jersey man then nearing seventy, had the courtroom delivery of a schoolteacher trying to hush nonsense at the back of the class by raising his own voice. Lauren Kanarek, he proposed, might well be "responsible for this tragedy." She'd plotted against Barisone and terrorized him with endless social-media provocations, including "incessant" posts about guns and "going to war." She'd accused him of "sexual abuse of his girlfriend's small child." Long before the shooting, people at Barisone Dressage had urged her to leave. Barisone's subsequent pleas to the police and to dressage authorities had

been ignored. He'd been forced to flee his own home, his "castle." According to Bilinkas, "Every man, woman, has a breaking point."

As for what happened on the patio that day, Bilinkas told the jury that Barisone had been subjected to a "horrific beating" and bitten repeatedly by a dog. And—Bilinkas was now at full volume—the jury would hear a recording of Goodwin yelling, "Don't move, I'm going to fucking kill you!" (In fact, Derek Heymer, the police officer who first arrived on the scene, had shouted this at Barisone.)



"Wait! Do you also take recycling?"
Cartoon by Akeem Roberts

This all sounds like the start of a self-defense argument—imminent threat, castle under siege—but a self-defense acquittal would be possible only if the judge eventually included that option in his jury instructions. And that was unlikely. After all, Barisone had driven to the crime scene with a loaded gun that he didn't usually carry.

Bilinkas had another strategy. When the shooting occurred, he said, his client had been suffering from a mental disease so severe that he hadn't known what he was doing was wrong. Largely through the medium of Facebook, Kanarek had driven Barisone mad.

I recently discussed Barisone's case with Michael Perlin, an authority on mental disability and the law, and a former professor at the New York Law School. The case, he said, was "the outlier of outliers," to the point that it resembled the insanity case of popular myth: a well-funded client, psychiatric experts in furious courtroom disagreement, and a swift escape from justice. Perlin has spent decades trying to dismantle this myth. In truth, he said, an insanity defendant, if successful, typically spends far more time in a psychiatric facility than someone convicted of the same crime would have spent in prison. Insanity defendants are disproportionately low-income, their cases rarely reach a jury, and there's usually no dispute about the diagnosis, which is almost invariably schizophrenia. As Perlin put it, the typical case involves a defendant who, after assaulting a victim unknown to him, says, "God told me that I should hit the third woman I see crossing Lower Ferry Road wearing a purple sweater."

Two defense witnesses for Barisone—Simring, the forensic psychiatrist, and Charles Hasson, a psychologist—testified that, at the time of the shooting, Barisone was suffering from delusional disorder; he had experienced a sustained psychotic fantasy about Kanarek's dangerousness. (He was also depressed, they noted.) In the kind of delusion case that typically reaches the courts, someone arrives at an unfounded belief—about being poisoned by a co-worker, say, or deceived by a spouse—and sticks with it to the point of violence, even as everyone around them begs them to see that they're wrong.

But delusional disorder is defined as something experienced for at least a month—not as a breaking-point response to indignities, to use Bilinkas's language. Neither Simring nor Hasson could say when the delusion had started. In fact, in late June, 2019, Barisone was still exchanging jokey texts with Kanarek—unseen by the jury—in which he proposed that she think of Goodwin's "manhood" to estimate the dimensions of an air-conditioner filter she needed to buy. ("Hahahahahahaha!" she responded.) There was also no sign of anyone trying to talk Barisone out of his distress about Kanarek, when it came. Everyone shared it.

And, if Barisone was psychotically deluded, how was the jury meant to understand the defense's central framing, which was that Kanarek had

cruelly tried to harm Barisone? He hadn't imagined being bugged; he *had been* bugged. Bilinkas had urged Kanarek, on the witness stand, to agree that she'd hatched a plan to "destroy" Barisone. Perhaps unwisely, she replied, "At some point, yes." It was surprising, then, to hear Simring claim that Barisone had developed a "core false belief" that Kanarek had "an elaborate plan to destroy him and kill him." This fear, he said, was "outlandish."

The jury was being asked, in effect, to endorse the old saw about even paranoiacs having real enemies. But there didn't appear to be evidence that Barisone, despite having come to despise Kanarek and to fear her recklessness, actually believed that she was deadly. The defense's argument seemed to depend—with circular convenience—on the act of violence itself, and also on evaluations of Barisone done months or years after the shooting, by which time he was living in a cell, stewing in discovery documents. When I recently asked Hasson, the psychologist, for evidence of Barisone's delusional thinking, he referred both to his client's seeming fearfulness on the day before the shooting and to the fact that, at the end of 2021, Barisone compared Kanarek to Nikolas Cruz, the mass murderer who committed the Parkland, Florida, school shooting.

A witness giving psychiatric evidence about a defendant's state of mind is largely unconstrained by the rules of hearsay. Barisone didn't take the stand, and Simring, who at a later hearing called Barisone a "gentleman," almost became his proxy. (Simring declined to be interviewed for this article.) Before the jury, Simring endorsed Barisone's claim that he had done "everything in his power" to resolve the conflict, and wrongly proposed that a private message Kanarek had sent to a friend a week before the shooting—"They know a war is coming"—was a public post that could have worsened Barisone's state of mind. Simring also suggested that Kanarek's allegedly scary posting had gone on for more than a year, although her online aggression toward Barisone lasted for about three weeks. And while Simring acknowledged that he'd barely read beyond the few dozen pages of material thumb-clipped for him by Barisone, he claimed to know that, in the thousands of pages of discovery documents, a "vast number" of Kanarek's electronic communications were similarly threatening. They weren't. Barisone's edit of this material was bound to mislead. For example,

Kanarek had repeatedly posted about guns she kept in North Carolina. But these posts primarily look like an effort to establish a liberal-badass persona with standing to take on Trump-supporting gun nuts. And she repeatedly posted about any number of things, including avocados and “Game of Thrones.”

Simring’s written report, like Bilinkas’s opening statement, suggested that “someone had reported allegations of sexual abuse” against Barisone. This wasn’t true. In court, Medrano-Cortez, the caseworker, explained that after her office was contacted by SafeSport she visited the farm to check if Gray’s children were neglected—not sexually abused. (The investigation quickly found no neglect.) The visit was surely prompted by SafeSport’s call with Kanarek, but there’s no evidence that Kanarek made any claim about the children besides noting that they were often on a property she had described as run by irresponsible people.

In a cross-examination of Simring, Christopher Schellhorn, from the Morris County prosecutor’s office, highlighted some of these errors. And a psychologist testifying for the prosecution challenged the delusion diagnosis. But the defense had given the jury permission to show sympathy for an apparently hounded man, and to embrace ideas about the inevitability of “snapping” that, however dubious, shaped the trial as well as thousands of comments about it. In truth, most people never reach violent breaking points. To take Kanarek as an example: this wasn’t her first feud, but no other adversary had shot her.



In the courtroom, Barisone, normally well put-together, was dramatically dishevelled. He was unshaven. His uncombed, graying hair nearly reached his shoulders. Photograph by Amy Newman / USA Today / Reuters

Barisone looked like a wreck, and it was easy to find Kanarek off-putting. In court, she seemed distracted and unserious. Her victimhood was all wrong: on the stand, she seemed to be scoring points in a continuing quarrel, not describing shocking violence. On the *Chronicle of the Horse* forums, there was talk of her false eyelashes. Her several long scars from her hospitalization were not visible. One wonders how Barisone's defense would have been different if he'd used a gun that wasn't pink, or used a tire iron instead of a gun, or had left Kanarek severely disabled, or dead.

On April 14th, the jury rendered a verdict. Barisone's knees buckled under him on hearing that he was not guilty of trying to kill Goodwin—and that, in the shooting of Kanarek, he was not guilty by reason of insanity. Barisone would be held by New Jersey, but only until a judge ruled that it was safe to release him.

Jonathan Kanarek was at home, twenty minutes away, with Lauren, when the verdict came. "It was devastating," he said. Christopher Schellhorn, the prosecutor, recalls returning to his office and sitting alone for maybe half an hour, "just trying to digest what had happened."

The jury members, drawn from a relatively conservative county, haven't spoken publicly about the trial. But remarks made by David, the attorney and Kanarek family acquaintance, perhaps point to some of the thinking in the jury room. The day before the shooting, Kanarek and her father met with David in his office. She talked in a scattered way about her dispute with Barisone, then left the room for a few minutes.

David turned to Jonathan. "We did not do the right thing for our children," he said. "We gave them everything they ever needed, ever wanted—"

"Certainly that," Jonathan said.

"—to create this high-strung, intolerant, demanding person who loses the ability to reason and rationalize. They're people who have to win all the time! We created type-A personalities." He then added, with apologies to what he called the "MeToo age," that it was weird to see this in young women. "We're guys," he said. "*They're* not supposed to be like that."

One day in Loxahatchee, Lara Osborne and I drove to a nearby dressage show. Barisone didn't join us; his suspension from the sport, which began soon after the shooting, denied him access to *USEF*-sanctioned events—even a quiet Saturday-morning show that, without us, would have had no spectators. A show of this kind is like the non-élite part of a marathon; riders were competing largely against their own expectations, not one another. “That was a *very bad piaffe*,” Osborne said at one point.

It was a relief to take a break from Barisone and his files. Osborne, who's in her mid-fifties, and who sells horse tack and clothing, is fully committed to Barisone's cause, but she doesn't share his intensity, and she occasionally allows herself an ironic eyebrow raise when his rhetoric overheats. She has set her phone to play the “Law & Order” theme when Christopher Deininger, Barisone's lead civil attorney, calls about one lawsuit or another.

I asked her if she ever encouraged Barisone to make peace with his current fate, and to stop calling for, say, the imprisonment of one of the detectives who investigated the shooting. Barisone had told me, “I don't want to be the fucking guy who has an asterisk next to his name forever. I don't want the asterisk!”

Osborne and I were standing beside the ring. “This is all that Michael knows,” she said. “How do you just walk away? This was his life. It wasn't just that he was a competitor. He was a coach, a mentor. He was a pillar of the community.”

At the time of Barisone's trial, much of the dressage community clearly supported him. His subsequent litigation is surely eroding that support. Merrick, the former dressage official, said that, though he understood Barisone's desire to rebuild his former life, “if he thinks it'll happen by smearing Lauren, it's not going to go well.” He added, “People really will walk away from him. He'll be kind of forgotten, and then I don't know what a guy like Michael does.”

Osborne told me, “If he just turns tail and walks away, she's destroyed him and she wins. Why would you give in to that?” But, she conceded, this was “not his best life.”

Barisone is the kind of man who, when asked, in passing, if he knows how to fly a plane, answers, “I *could*. But I don’t. I mean, I understand aeronautics.” In one of our conversations, he referred to himself as a “he-man.” Whole days passed without Barisone allowing Osborne to finish a sentence. His recollections often take the form of dialogues in which interlocutors meekly acknowledge his overwhelming rhetorical advantage.

One might hesitate to call this narcissistic, if that term hadn’t been used repeatedly in mental-health assessments of Barisone in recent years—though not in those presented to the jury in 2022. Ann Picardo, Barisone’s former therapist, told Hasson, the psychologist, that she’d found her client to be “grandiose” and inclined to make “pompous speeches.” Barisone, she said, “wanted to be around people who sucked up to him.” Soon after the verdict, Barisone was sent to the Ann Klein Forensic Center, in Trenton, where he was seen by Joanna Bajgier, a psychiatrist. She identified no delusional disorder but saw possible signs of narcissistic personality disorder (N.P.D.) That fall, Barisone was transferred to the Greystone Park Psychiatric Hospital, in Morris County. Anthony Gotay, a psychiatrist, also saw no delusions, and gave him diagnoses of N.P.D. and obsessive-compulsive personality disorder.

Barisone was entitled to regular hearings at which a judge would weigh the risk of releasing him. At the second of these, in May, 2023, Gotay described people with N.P.D. as requiring “excessive admiration.” They have, he said, an “arrogant demeanor that basically they are better than other people.” According to Gotay, Barisone liked to say that he should be *running* group meetings at Greystone, not merely participating in them. Gotay also said that when Barisone talked of the shooting he claimed to have “handled the situation perfectly.”

At the hearing, Hasson—who hadn’t mentioned narcissism at the trial—didn’t disown his earlier diagnosis but seemed to be describing the crime in a new way. “He had a narcissistic personality disorder,” he told the judge, and was “placed in a very toxic circumstance.”

By definition, people with N.P.D. are prone to distorted thinking—about their virtues, their specialness. And there’s a strong correlation between N.P.D. and violence. Barisone might be said to have experienced a

narcissistic injury—an intolerable challenge to his inflated sense of self—when Kanarek pushed back, starting in mid-July, and said “pretty TRUE and fucked up things” about him. But, in the eyes of most courts, the characteristics that combine to indicate N.P.D. don’t amount to a mental illness. That is, N.P.D. is a description of who you are; it’s probably a problem, but it’s not a disease, and not a criminal defense. Prisons are filled with people who have antisocial, borderline, narcissistic, and histrionic personality disorders—so-called cluster-B disorders.

Barisone has never fully embraced the delusional-disorder diagnosis that kept him out of prison. In our conversations, his usual framing was about good and evil, not catastrophically warped thinking. He didn’t quite disown the verdict—“I agree with the jury that it was impossible for me to rationally know what was going on. I agree with *that*”—but he complained that the judge, Stephen J. Taylor, had denied him the chance for a straightforward not-guilty verdict. Had Barisone been allowed to bring up every unbecoming fact about Kanarek, he told me, “I would have walked out of the courtroom a free man.” He seemed most wedded to the idea of a former mental illness when he described a planned lawsuit that, he predicts, will undo his dressage ban and, in the process, overthrow the SafeSport system. Among other restrictions, Barisone is barred from teaching *USEF* members. He made the case to me that, given his past psychiatric condition, revealed in his attempt to kill a student, restricting his access to students is a clear violation of the Americans with Disabilities Act.

Barisone’s suspension became a permanent ban last December. A SafeSport investigation had found evidence of sexual harassment and “emotional misconduct.” The report detailing this is confidential, but Barisone and Jonathan Kanarek both told me that the sexual-harassment finding is not connected to Lauren. (In Barisone’s dismissive description, it’s about “off-color jokes” that he made before 2019.) The misconduct charge, however, addresses Barisone’s treatment of Kanarek and Goodwin.



“And remember, there are no bad ideas, just ones I call ‘interesting’ and dismiss.”

Cartoon by Joseph Dottino and Alex Pearson

At the Greystone facility, in 2022 and 2023, Barisone was no longer the dramatically dishevelled figure he’d been in the courtroom; he now carried himself as a clear-eyed man of principle who was absurdly out of place, like a dissident in a Soviet *psikhushka*, or Jack Nicholson’s character in “One Flew Over the Cuckoo’s Nest.” (In our conversations, he gestured at both.) Barisone had a point. He might or might not be dangerous, but he was almost certainly not mad. A 2026 study of a state psychiatric hospital whose admissions are largely involuntary found that the average patient was taking three psychotropic medications. Barisone was taking nothing. He began a legal action against the hospital and its doctors while still there, alleging that his N.P.D. and O.C.P.D. diagnoses were “fabricated.”

Speaking in Loxahatchee, Barisone recounted one of Gotay’s colleagues bringing up the N.P.D. “You’re telling me that, because I’m incredibly driven and success-oriented, that makes me mentally ill?” he recalled asking her. “Ma’am, I’m an Olympic athlete! Have you ever had an Olympic athlete in here?” To represent the doctor, Barisone adopted a small, stupid voice: “No, no.”

He was released in November, 2023, nineteen months after his trial. He now must keep regular appointments with a court-sanctioned psychologist, and must return to New Jersey for further hearings about his state of mind.

To spend time with Barisone is to have the occasional old-fashioned thought about the redemptive potential of prison. I never heard him express compassion toward Kanarek. His acceptance of responsibility for her injuries is severely truncated: “The overwhelming likelihood is, yes, I held this thing”—Ruth Cox’s gun—“and, yes, I pulled the trigger.” He aligns himself with other men tarnished by “weaponized” accusations, in particular those whose innocence is at best uncertain, and in whom narcissism may be evident: Donald Trump; George Morris, the show jumper; Brett Kavanaugh; Lance Armstrong.

Tarshis, Barisone’s lawyer, who has an image of a horse on his business card, has decided to let his *USEF* membership lapse, so that he can keep training with Barisone. He rides at the Loxahatchee farm most days. He was at the kitchen table one morning when Barisone was describing to me the simple life he claims to want. This would involve working on his old cars, but also—as if a throwaway thought—winning a prestigious dressage show and then giving media interviews afterward. “Get my blue ribbon, go to the press conference—‘Thank you, everybody’—and come home with this lady,” he said. He was looking at Osborne. “I don’t care about being famous anymore.”

Tarshis, clearly unpersuaded, said, “Wait, stop.”

We had dinner that evening at a local country club with an equestrian clientele. At a table in the middle of the room, Barisone recounted that, nearly a year before the shooting, Goodwin, during a discussion about a dressage show, had “smashed” him against a wall and warned him that if he didn’t do whatever Goodwin wanted, or if he dared go to the police, Goodwin would kill him. This was hard to believe (and Goodwin later called it a lie). Barisone’s proposition was that everything that followed—months of living and working together, silly texts—was done in the shadow of that threat.

At trial, Barisone presented himself as the victim of scheming. That account failed to convince everyone, but it must also have frustrated him; he was claiming to be a dupe undone by a chaotic female client. As he has worked on his memoir, he seems to have found a new approach, involving a kind of B-movie gangsterism.

Tarshis, though not a part of Barisone's trial team, has been involved in the case from the start, and he filed the 2025 suit that accused Kanarek of vulgarity. But he was clearly hearing about this scene of allegedly pivotal violence for the first time. He seemed confounded, and tried to reset the conversation.

Tarshis, with Barisone looking on, said, "Michael's a contradiction. He's a big, powerful, strong guy. Appears to exude confidence. You see how he takes over a room. Nobody can even talk!" But, he went on, "he is incredibly insecure."

Tarshis described Barisone as he had been in the summer of 2019: "Given the status that he enjoyed in the sport, I think there was a part of him that did not want to admit defeat" by evicting Kanarek.

"You're a hundred per cent wrong," Barisone said.

"Let me finish."

"Couldn't be more wrong."

Tarshis went on, "I think he—without realizing it—may have been concerned that if he kicks them out, especially *these* people, they're going to be bad-mouthing him all over the place."

"Not even remotely," Barisone said. Only "the victim of a terrorist," he said, could understand what he went through. He returned to the wall-slamming.

"Why didn't you call me?" Tarshis asked.

"Steven, you don't do that as an abuse victim!"

Tarshis was still puzzled—he was having to rewrite a story he thought he knew well. "Why didn't you go to the police?"

"I'm a chickenshit. Conflict terrifies me."

Tarshis asked him when he first contacted the police.

“Thirty-first of July, 2019,” Barisone said.

“That was *the first time*?” Tarshis asked.

Tarshis had a few more questions, but Barisone was done.

“Steven, zip your mouth,” he said, sharply. “Zip your mouth.” ♦

[Ian Parker](#) has been a staff writer at *The New Yorker* since 2000. He received the National Magazine Award for Profile Writing in 2005.

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Jared Kushner's Dollar Diplomacy

Donald Trump's son-in-law represents the kind of Washington figure for whom public office serves as a means to extraordinary wealth.

By [Dexter Filkins](#)

September 14, 2026



“Kushner is plagued with conflicts of interest,” Virginia Canter, a former White House counsel, said. “He is supposed to be working for the American people, but in fact he has tremendous financial incentives to further the interests of his investors.” Illustration by Nigel Buchanan; Source photograph by Chip Somodevilla / Getty

In the waning hours before the U.S. went to war with Iran, this February, Jared Kushner held a meeting with Iranian negotiators in Geneva—one last chance to avoid a conflict that would plunge the region into chaos and shock the world economy. Afterward, Kushner dismissed his counterparts as unworthy of his time. “Lots of tricks,” he told reporters. “They’re basically playing games with us all over the place, and it’s very, very slippery.”

Kushner, the boyish-looking son-in-law of Donald Trump, has been given an extraordinary brief in recent years. Along with Steve Witkoff, the President's special envoy, he has been charged with ending wars in Gaza, Ukraine, and just about anywhere else they might break out. Kushner, who is forty-five, has little regard for the craft of diplomacy. In his view, it is less important to know a region's history or the details of the partisans' negotiating positions than to simply hear the sides out and split the difference. Peace deals are like real-estate deals, he has said. Both involve hard bargaining and, at times, bluffing. The fact that so many diplomats before him have struggled is a testament not to the intransigence of international problems but to the mediocrity of his predecessors. "I've been getting criticized for the last couple of years, by all the people who have tried and failed, for not doing this the same way that they have," he said in 2020, after Trump unveiled his first Middle East peace plan. "If somebody was successful, I wouldn't be dealing with this."

When Kushner and Witkoff began meeting with the Iranian negotiators, in February, the two countries were on the brink of war. In 2025, American and Israeli forces had bombed Iran's nuclear-enrichment facilities, which Western leaders said were engaged in a decades-long drive to develop a nuclear weapon. Afterward, Trump declared that Iran's capability to enrich uranium had been "obliterated." (When the head of America's top military-intelligence agency disputed the President's assessment, he was fired.)

Yet Trump and other Western officials wanted further concessions. The Iranians maintained a large stockpile of lower-grade uranium. It was buried under rubble from the bombing in 2025, but Trump and Benjamin Netanyahu, the Israeli Prime Minister, insisted that the Iranians give it up and forswear any intention of enriching uranium in the future. Trump sent Kushner and Witkoff to present the Iranians with what amounted to a binary choice: turn over their entire stockpile or expect an attack. To emphasize his threats, he had dispatched an armada to the Middle East. "We have to have a meaningful deal, otherwise bad things happen," he said.

Discussions about limiting Iran's nuclear program are formidably complex, with challenges that are both technical (determining the speeds of centrifuges that can be used) and diplomatic (verifying the Iranians' often

dubious claims of disarmament). But neither Kushner nor Witkoff brought a technical adviser to the talks; though an expert from the Department of Energy had been assigned to Witkoff, he wasn't in the room. (The White House denied this.) As if to demonstrate their confidence, he and Witkoff were simultaneously negotiating with Russian representatives about the war in Ukraine. The Iran discussions took place in the morning, the Ukraine talks in the afternoon.

A former diplomat briefed on the talks with Iran told me that, when the Iranian foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, began offering concessions, the two Americans failed to grasp precisely what was on the table. They sought advice from Rafael Grossi, the head of the International Atomic Energy Agency, but Grossi was attending the talks as a neutral party. A former White House official who worked on the Iranian nuclear issue was aghast at the lack of preparation: "The Iranians come to you with a proposal. What does it actually mean? How much does it actually set them back—two months or two years? What are the work-arounds? For them not to have technical advisers there is just total malpractice."

At a press conference afterward, Kushner argued that the Iranians were merely stalling. "They were just trying to buy time in order to preserve whatever they could, to get past the term of President Trump," he said. Another former White House official I spoke to largely shared that assessment. "It was the same old game," he said. "The Iranian position is: We get a shit ton of sanctions relief, and we do nothing to dismantle our nuclear infrastructure." But some experts who followed the talks thought that Araghchi's proposals were made in earnest. Among other things, the Iranians were offering to suspend nuclear enrichment entirely, which they had not done before, and to dilute the enriched uranium that they still retained.

At the press conference, the American negotiators made baffling statements. Witkoff accused the Iranians of using the Tehran Research Reactor, a facility that produces medical isotopes, to illegally enrich and stockpile uranium—even though repeated I.A.E.A. inspections had found no evidence of military use. "You can tell by what Kushner and Witkoff are saying that they don't understand a lot of the technical issues," Kelsey

Davenport, a nonproliferation expert at the Arms Control Association, in Washington, D.C., told me. A friend of Kushner's was blunter: "He's a lovely guy, but he is way the fuck out of his depth."

The host of the negotiations in Geneva—Oman's foreign minister, Badr Albusaidi—was so alarmed by the proceedings that he flew to Washington to try to fend off a war. Unable to secure an audience with Trump, he met with Vice-President J. D. Vance, who opposed the conflict. Then, in a highly unusual move for a career diplomat, he appeared on CBS and issued a plea for patience, saying, "The peace deal is within our reach."

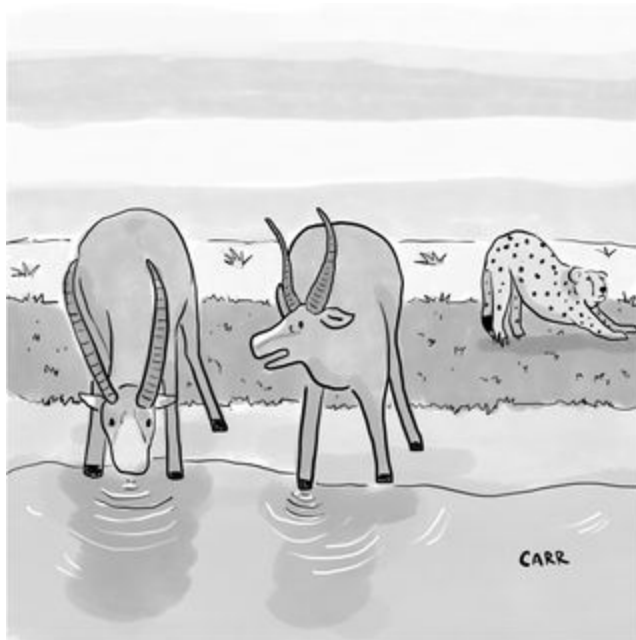
In Washington, Kushner and Witkoff told Trump that the Iranians had refused to capitulate. Hours later, the U.S. and Israel launched a series of devastating strikes that killed Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and many of Iran's other senior leaders. The former White House official told me that the Administration had rushed into an unnecessary conflict. "I don't blame them for a failed negotiation," he said. "But why so soon do you then start a war and take out the entire leadership? It just wasn't that urgent."

With the war under way, Kushner gave a surprising rationale for attacking the Iranians: "They basically could have been, you know, days or weeks away from a weapon, if they would have put the effort into it." This was implausible. Since the strikes on Iran's nuclear facilities in 2025, the I.A.E.A. had seen no signs of a revived weapons program.

In fact, Trump appears to have been pushed into the conflict by Netanyahu, who believed that a coordinated campaign could quickly topple Iran's regime. When American intelligence officials pinpointed the location of senior leaders, Israel chose to strike. At that point, Trump decided that the U.S. couldn't avoid a war, according to Secretary of State Marco Rubio: "There was going to be an Israeli action. We knew that that would precipitate an attack against American forces."

In the seven months since then, the Trump Administration has become mired in a costly war that seems to offer no easy exit. The U.S. has bombed civilian water supplies and accidentally struck a school for girls, killing more than a hundred children; it has squandered a huge proportion of its stockpiles of advanced missiles, weakening its ability to deter such

adversaries as China and Russia. As Iran's hard-line regime has given way to an even harder-line one, the Administration has effectively ceded control of the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's most significant waterways.



"Remind me again—are you supposed to stretch before or after a run?"
Cartoon by Chelsea Carr

For any other Presidential envoy, the result of the Iran talks would have been a catastrophe. For Kushner, it was not even the most important thing in his portfolio. As he negotiated with Iran, he was also managing billions of dollars in investments that other governments in the region had made in his private-equity fund.

Throughout the Trump era, Kushner has made a career of combining business and politics. He argues that being a businessman aids his diplomatic efforts, by allowing him to find inventive solutions to problems ordinarily handled by unimaginative bureaucrats. But, as he has traversed the globe for Trump, he has grown more entangled in the commercial affairs of countries where he works. He represents a new kind of Washington figure, for whom public office serves as a means to extraordinary wealth. In the past two years, an array of people linked to the White House—including Witkoff's sons, the cryptocurrency adviser David Sacks, and other members of the Trump family—have used their official positions to bring in billions of dollars for themselves. "I know all these

guys,” a former American official who served in the Middle East told me. “They go into these meetings, and they are doing business right alongside their diplomacy. ‘O.K., enough about the ceasefire. We have this hotel we want to build.’ That’s the kind of foreign policy America has now.”

When Kushner left Washington after Trump’s first term, he was exhausted by four years of internecine conflict and embarrassed by the disaster of the January 6th riot. A friend of his told me, “Jared and Ivanka made a deliberate choice to withdraw from being seen as Trump proxies.” The Kushners moved to Indian Creek, Florida, where they bought a twenty-four-million-dollar mansion on a private island—an enclave known as “the billionaire bunker.” Kushner started his private-equity fund and called on his connections to create a lucrative portfolio of investments. “My desire at this phase of my life is to focus on my firm,” he said in 2024.

After Trump returned to office, though, he asked his son-in-law to come back. Kushner protested, once joking, “There’s a chance that when I get home my wife changes the locks.” But Trump insisted, and Kushner eventually acquiesced.

Trump’s second term has been marked by a radical diminishment of America’s role in the world—scaling back overseas commitments, insulting the country’s oldest allies, and gutting the diplomatic corps. In place of seasoned ambassadors, Kushner and Witkoff are dispatched to troubled places, rarely staying more than a night or two.

The men bring very different styles to the negotiating table. Witkoff, who made a fortune by buying distressed properties in New York—sometimes scouting seedy neighborhoods by night in a beat-up car—is known as a hands-on bargainer, less interested in the details of a proposal than in the person sitting across from him. “He’s literally a slumlord from the Bronx,” a longtime acquaintance of his told me. “He’s got this pleasant combination of street smarts and charm, a sort of Mediterranean warmth.”

Kushner, by contrast, is precise, detached, bloodless. Even his voice—high-pitched and crisp—can sound aloof. A former senior American official who worked with him on Middle East issues told me that Kushner sometimes seemed uneasy in the Arab world, where many senior leaders are

demonstrative and physical. “Jared is not warm and fuzzy in that way, and of course the Arabs like a bit of that,” the former official said. “He didn’t come to hang out. He came to get business done.”

Witkoff told me recently that he and Kushner have a kind of productive sibling rivalry. “We both want to get to the finish line and bring positive results home for the President,” he said. “We’re a little bit obsessed. Winning means something.” Kushner’s family ties to Trump make him less likely than other officials to lose his job. They also bind him to a boss who is erratic and often shockingly ill-informed.

Late last year, Kushner was called on to help with the faltering talks to end the war in Ukraine. Since Trump returned to office, his policy toward the conflict had careered inexplicably. “Every day was a roller coaster,” a former U.S. official in the region told me. “Will the President wake up today posting about great deals with the Russians and how close he is to Putin? Or will it be the day he wakes up and respects Zelensky?”

Witkoff told me that he and Kushner don’t mind navigating tense and uncertain circumstances. “Jared and I both know what we don’t know,” he said. “We’re going to be O.K. not knowing something and then getting curious and getting smart on the issue.” When the two began work on Ukraine, they had very little understanding of the war, a former senior Trump foreign-policy official told me. Both believed that Vladimir Putin was “a good guy,” and that “the Russian Army is invincible,” the former official said, adding, “They think this is a real-estate deal. They don’t seem to understand this is a war.”

After meeting with delegates from the two sides in South Florida, Kushner and Witkoff emerged with a peace plan that would have required Ukraine to accept nearly all of Russia’s demands: ceding territory, promising never to join *NATO*, and drastically shrinking its army. Karoline Leavitt, Trump’s press secretary, hailed the proposal as “a good plan for both Russia and Ukraine.” But, when the plan became public, it collapsed under a wave of outrage. Even Rubio reportedly derided it as “Russia’s wish list.”

Some observers suspect that Russia has effectively offered the Americans business deals in exchange for a favorable peace agreement. “This is the

generally held view,” the former U.S. official in the region told me. A classified report produced by a European intelligence agency states that Trump and people around him have discussed several potential contracts in Russia. The report is not dated, but the European official who gave it to me said that the details were first discussed sometime after Trump invited Putin to Anchorage, in August, 2025. Twice that year, Kirill Dmitriev, the head of Russia’s sovereign wealth fund, was allowed to enter the U.S., where he talked about investment opportunities. “The privatization of American foreign policy is quite far along,” the official who gave me the report said. (A spokesman for Kushner denied that U.S. officials would profit from the deals under discussion.)

The document lists ten potential ventures, which it says appear to “have been originally designed by the Kremlin’s political and business elites.” They include reopening the Nord Stream 2 pipeline under American control, resuming ExxonMobil’s operations in Sakhalin, and drilling for oil in the Sea of Okhotsk. According to the report, there was discussion of unfreezing Russian assets that are held under American sanctions. The document mentions people who might participate, including Trump, Witkoff, and Kushner. It also names Richard Grenell, the former Presidential envoy, and Gentry Beach, a friend of Donald Trump, Jr.’s who has secured advantageous contracts in places the Administration is negotiating. (Grenell denied any wrongdoing.) “The deals would be executed the moment Trump delivers a peace deal,” the European official told me.

Since Kushner got involved in the Ukraine negotiations, he has displayed unusual flexibility. His presence in negotiations “changed the dynamic,” an official who sat in on the talks told me. “He told everybody, ‘I want to hear where this is going. I want to understand.’ ” The official added, “Maybe this is actually how he is effective in his business role.”

Yet open-mindedness can be hard to distinguish from naïveté. This month, Kushner and Witkoff visited Russia and Ukraine, hoping to re-start stalled talks. In Moscow, they greeted Putin like an old friend and allowed their hosts to transport them in a Russian limousine, rather than in a U.S. Embassy vehicle—a security risk that few of their predecessors would have

allowed. In Kyiv, Kushner spoke about the war in tidily transactional language, acknowledging little of the bloodshed and destruction that Putin's invasion has wrought. "In the business world, you think about things in the context of 'win-win,' " he said. He and Witkoff envisioned a "peace package," by which Russia and Ukraine could "focus on fulfilling their huge potential and they can find ways to benefit from each other." Hours after their departure from Kyiv, Putin resumed bombing.

In 2024, Kushner gave a talk at Harvard and offered scathing assessments of some notable diplomatic accomplishments from previous Administrations. Barack Obama's deal to limit Iran's nuclear program was "one of the dumbest agreements" of all time. The Oslo Accords, which in 1993 set forth a process for establishing a Palestinian state, were "a total failure." He was more generous about his own work: "My track record of success in the Middle East I do think is second to none over the last many years." Kushner's self-assurance grated on veteran diplomats. "He's incredibly confident in himself and quite arrogant," a former American official who worked with him told me.

Kushner's sense of exceptionalism started early. He grew up in Livingston, a wealthy town in northern New Jersey, in a Modern Orthodox Jewish family; his father, Charles, had built a fortune in the home-construction business. Though Charles donated lavishly to local charities, he struggled to cast off doubts about his character. "Kushner had a very bad reputation in the Jewish community as being an asshole—the Kushners were known for their rapacity and their greed," an acquaintance of the family told me. Jared attended the Frisch School, a Jewish day school in Paramus, where he was a middling student. "He's a parody of someone to whom everything has been given," the family acquaintance said.

Despite slim academic credentials, Kushner was admitted to Harvard, after his father pledged to donate \$2.5 million—with donations beginning once his son started classes. While in college, Jared began investing in apartment buildings, many of them in Somerville, a short walk from campus. "I would notice every detail of any building I entered," he wrote in his memoir, "Breaking History." "I graduated Harvard with honors, while making millions of dollars from my real-estate investments."

While Kushner was starting out in business, his father was under criminal investigation. Chris Christie, then the U.S. district attorney for New Jersey, suspected that Charles had disguised extensive political contributions by attributing them to family members. Prosecutors showed his sister Esther records of donations made in her name, and she expressed shock. Enraged, Charles hired a prostitute to lure Esther's husband to a motel for sex, and arranged for the encounter to be filmed. He then had the video delivered to an engagement party that Esther was giving for her son. Prosecutors in Christie's office charged Charles with tax evasion, witness tampering, and wire fraud; he pleaded guilty and was sentenced to two years in a minimum-security facility in Alabama.

Kushner, then a law and business student at New York University, took over the family real-estate company. In 2007, at the age of twenty-five, he met Ivanka Trump at a networking lunch, and two years later they were married. A friend described him as a devoted husband: "I think he married her out of genuine love—it's a genuine relationship." Others noted a natural affinity between the two families. "The historic union of the House of Kushner and the House of Trump was not a stretch—it's a royal marriage," the family acquaintance said. "They're both creatures of power and of the power that money confers."

As Trump began his political career, Kushner saw an opportunity to avenge his father. In 2016, after Trump became the presumptive Republican candidate for President, Trump selected Christie to run his transition. That May, the two men were sitting together when Kushner walked in unannounced and asked his father-in-law to keep Christie off the team. Kushner said, "He's a bad guy—he's not trustworthy," Christie recalled recently. Trump demurred for a time, but after the election he let Christie go. By then, Christie told me, "Jared had been taking a meat-axe to my head with Trump for weeks." (Kushner has said that Trump fired Christie for other reasons. Charles is now Trump's Ambassador to France.)

Kushner was a novice to politics; he'd been happily running the Kushner Companies and the *Observer*, a struggling weekly paper that gave him some cachet among New York élites. He wasn't even in Trump's political

party. “I only had one friend who was a Republican,” he said in his talk at Harvard. “I was just in a massive echo chamber.”

But Trump trusted him. “Jared is family, and he’s bright, and he can give good advice on some things,” a former senior official during Trump’s first term told me. “I mean, this is not like Donnie, Jr., or Eric or Ivanka. I think there is a difference there.” Trump apparently valued Kushner’s loyalty, and also his willingness to absorb a joke at his own expense. Once, during a meeting in the Oval Office, Trump got a laugh by musing about having a different rich son-in-law. “Ivanka could have married Tom Brady!” he said. “But instead she married Jared.”

When Trump took office, Kushner became a kind of minister without portfolio, working on issues as diverse as reforming sentencing laws and renegotiating trade agreements. Like his father-in-law, he was inclined to rely less on government employees than on wealthy friends. A former senior Republican official offered to find staffers with experience in fiscal affairs and monetary policy. Kushner turned him down, saying, “You don’t understand. We’re bringing in billionaires—billionaires.”

Kushner soon began to concentrate on the Middle East, where he helped administer a policy of unstinting support for Israel. He had grown up steeped in hawkish views on the region. His father had often contributed to Israeli causes, including some, like the American Friends of Bet el Yeshiva, that supported settlements in the West Bank. Netanyahu was an old family friend, who had once spent the night in Jared’s bedroom.

Trump and his advisers felt that Iran, America’s primary adversary in the Middle East, had been allowed to operate unopposed. To contain it, they wanted to bolster Saudi Arabia, which the Obama Administration had kept at a chilly remove for its dismal human-rights record. Trump charged Kushner with rebuilding the relationship. American intelligence agencies had restricted Kushner’s access to top-secret materials, out of concern that his business interests made him susceptible to exploitation by foreign adversaries. But some diplomats thought that his background made him a natural fit for the Middle East; like the Gulf monarchies, the Trump and Kushner clans functioned essentially as dynastic family businesses.

THINGS YOUR EX IS DOING RIGHT NOW



Cartoon by Michael Maslin

Kushner quickly identified a focus for America's efforts: Mohammed bin Salman, the seventh son of the Saudi king. At the time, Salman—known by his initials, M.B.S.—was being touted in the Gulf as a dynamic future leader. But he was only second in line to be king; the first was his cousin Mohammed bin Nayef, a longtime ally of the C.I.A. in the fight against terrorism. Trump harbored deep animosity toward the C.I.A., which had suspected his campaign of accepting Russian help in 2016. “The main motive that Trump had for tilting toward M.B.S. was to stick it to the agency,” a former C.I.A. official in the Middle East told me. “Plus, bin Nayef was completely honest.”

Kushner arranged for M.B.S. to have lunch with Trump at the White House, and helped persuade the President to travel to Saudi Arabia for his first overseas trip. In Riyadh, Trump was treated like a potentate, hailed with trumpet fanfares and saluted with golden swords. During his visit, he approved an agreement to sell the Saudis a hundred and ten billion dollars in arms, including precision-guided missiles whose transfer had been held up by the Obama Administration. Kushner helped secure the deal with a phone call to the C.E.O. of Lockheed Martin.

Kushner and M.B.S. quickly became friends. Both were in their thirties, and saw themselves as innovative leaders cutting through hidebound bureaucracies. They spoke often on the phone, and Kushner was invited to

cruise the Red Sea with M.B.S. on his half-billion-dollar yacht, the Serene. One former American official who knows the two men marvelled at the contrast that they presented as they frolicked in the sun. “The Saudis are totally unconscious about how enormous they are—they take off their shirts, and they go into the water, and they’re so huge, they’re spilling out everywhere,” the official said. “Then there’s Jared, this wispy white boy.”

According to U.S. officials, the Trump Administration’s support encouraged M.B.S. to undertake a series of reckless initiatives. Two weeks after the Riyadh summit, he and the U.A.E. began a blockade of Qatar. Saudi officials harbored a long list of grievances with Qatar, including its support for the Muslim Brotherhood, a global Islamist movement. But many observers feared that M.B.S.’s real intention was to displace Qatar’s monarchy and seize its vast deposits of natural gas. According to the former American official, Kushner did not intervene to halt the blockade, which brought the region to the brink of armed conflict. “Jared knew about it, and he acquiesced,” the official said. (Kushner’s spokesman denied this.)

Kushner’s family had some history with Qatari leadership. In April, 2017, a few months before the blockade began, officials from Qatar’s sovereign wealth fund gathered at the St. Regis hotel, in New York, to consider prospective investments. Charles Kushner visited and offered a pitch. Nearly a decade before, his family had bought an office building, 666 Fifth Avenue, for more than a billion dollars. Since then, it had lost much of its value, and the mortgage was at risk of default—but, Charles argued, the Qataris could benefit by investing in the property. A financial analyst close to the fund told me that the Qataris dismissed the proposal. “They just didn’t think it would ever pay off,” he said. He suggested that they had missed a chance to build good will: “If they had given Kushner the money, would there have been a blockade? I don’t think so.”

Secretary of State Rex Tillerson and Secretary of Defense Jim Mattis worked with Kushner to defuse the blockade. But, a few months later, M.B.S. launched another spectacular gambit, detaining hundreds of Saudi royals and other prominent figures in the Riyadh Ritz-Carlton and demanding financial tributes and vows of fealty. M.B.S. also summoned Lebanon’s Prime Minister, Saad Hariri, to Riyadh, where he was slapped

repeatedly and forced to read a resignation letter on live television. (Both parties have denied this.)

The crisis reached a peak in late 2018, when Jamal Khashoggi, a Saudi American columnist for the *Washington Post*, was killed and dismembered by a hit squad inside the Saudi consulate in Istanbul. U.S. intelligence officials concluded that the assassination had almost certainly been carried out on M.B.S.'s orders, and an international uproar broke out. "It was one of the most serious threats to the American-Saudi relationship," the former C.I.A. official said. But Kushner defended M.B.S. inside the White House, former officials told me. Trump announced publicly that he was satisfied M.B.S. "knew nothing" about the incident, adding, "Things happen."

For Kushner, all that mattered was America's objectives in the region. "Saudi Arabia has, I think, been a very strong ally in terms of pushing back against Iran's aggression," he said at the time. In any case, a tendency toward disruption was seen as a valuable trait in an ally. "People like Jared were convinced that everybody who had preceded him had failed, and the last thing he needed was expertise," an American official serving in the region told me. "It's hard to emphasize how much the White House didn't understand the way the Middle East worked."

After the murder, the Administration was obliged to distance itself from M.B.S., but it maintained communications. In early 2017, M.B.S. was preparing to depose his rival Mohammed bin Nayef. Both men had armed loyalists, and American intelligence officials feared an outbreak of violence. M.B.S. called Kushner to discuss his plans, in a conversation that was secretly recorded. "Kushner told M.B.S. that everyone in the U.S. government except the intelligence agencies was behind him," a former regional intelligence official told me, explaining that he had seen a transcript of the call. "It was the green light." (Kushner's spokesman denied this.) A few months later, M.B.S. had bin Nayef detained, then forced him to sign a statement in which he agreed to relinquish power. Bin Nayef has been in detention or under house arrest since 2020.

M.B.S. soon embarked on an ambitious reform project, of a kind that Kushner had championed. He lifted a ban on women's driving, neutered the religious police, and partially privatized the state-owned oil company. At

the same time, he moved to crush internal dissent, suppressing the country's already beleaguered press. In 2023, after a retired teacher named Mohammed al-Ghamdi expressed sympathy for political prisoners in Saudi jails, he was sentenced to death for "supporting terrorist ideology."

Kushner's warm relations in the Gulf also helped facilitate his most substantial diplomatic achievement: the Abraham Accords, which normalized relations between Israel and several Muslim countries in the Middle East. The deal began with a crisis. In 2020, Netanyahu, emboldened by support from the Trump Administration, indicated that he intended to annex Israeli settlements in the occupied West Bank—a move that was certain to spark a conflagration in the Arab world. Yousef Al Otaiba, the Emirati Ambassador to the U.S., published an article in an Israeli newspaper soon afterward, saying that, if Netanyahu called off the annexation, the U.A.E. would work toward normalizing relations with Israel.

Kushner was well positioned to secure a deal: he was a confidant of Otaiba's, and Netanyahu was a family friend. Perhaps most important, "he had his father-in-law's backing, and everyone he dealt with knew that," a senior official in Trump's first term told me. Israel, the U.A.E., and Bahrain signed the accord, followed by Sudan and Morocco. Kushner's deal ignored a central concern, however: there was no provision for Israel's Palestinian population. Saudi Arabia, a long-standing advocate of Palestinian statehood, declined to join. But Kushner emerged with his relationship to M.B.S. intact, and with new ties to the Gulf monarchies—connections that would prove hugely profitable in the coming years.

In June, 2021, six months after Trump's first term ended, a group of investment managers who oversee Saudi Arabia's sovereign wealth fund gathered in the Public Investment Fund Tower, an eighty-story skyscraper in Riyadh. The subject of the meeting was Kushner's request for a two-billion-dollar investment in Affinity Partners, a private-equity fund that he was starting.

According to the minutes of the meeting, Kushner's representatives were exclusively seeking foreign clients, because they "would like to avoid media attention." The three countries that Kushner was visiting—Saudi

Arabia, Qatar, and the U.A.E.—maintained enormous public-investment funds. They were also autocracies, with little accountability for leaders' decisions.

Kushner had no experience running an investment fund. But he had good relationships with Gulf potentates, and his team included at least two officials who had worked with him during Trump's first term: Miguel Correa, a former military attaché at the U.S. Embassy in the U.A.E., and Avi Berkowitz, a White House adviser on international relations.

The Saudis have few scruples about investing with former officials; they gave a billion dollars to a fund run by Steven Mnuchin after his time as Trump's Secretary of the Treasury. But the committee opposed Kushner's request. The minutes list numerous objections: the firm had failed "to provide any quantifiable investment track record," Saudi Arabia would be assuming "the bulk of the investment and risk," and the proposed management fees seemed "excessive." A due-diligence investigation found the firm's operations "unsatisfactory in all aspects." As a friend of Kushner's put it, "Jared had never invested in more than a 401(k)."

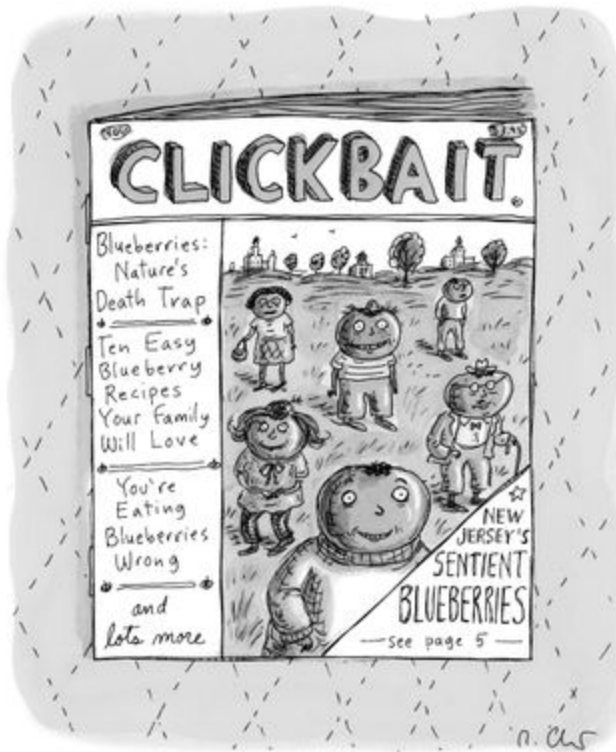
But M.B.S. was the chairman of the Public Investment Fund; the committee was overruled, and the deal went through. The Saudi contributions promised huge incomes for Kushner and his team, no matter how well the fund performed. With a management fee of 1.25 per cent, the fund would receive more than twenty-five million dollars a year, plus twenty per cent of any profits. The U.A.E. invested an additional two hundred million dollars. The government of Qatar, perhaps chastened by the blockade, supplied two hundred million more.

The investments spurred outrage in the United States. "Why did Jared Kushner receive two billion dollars, with a 'B,' from the Saudi government just two months after leaving the White House?" Representative Robert Garcia asked on the House floor. Kushner never answered the question, but, in 2024, he defended his work in the Trump Administration at an investment conference in Miami. "For my critics, what I say is, Point to a single decision we made that wasn't in the interest of America," he told the crowd. When asked about M.B.S.'s role in the murder of Khashoggi, he grew impatient: "Are we really still doing this?"

There's no direct evidence that the Saudis intended to reward Kushner or Trump for their actions in office. But the former American intelligence official who worked in the Middle East told me that Kushner's help in salvaging U.S.-Saudi relations after Khashoggi's murder would have created a debt for M.B.S. Exactly how such a debt was to be repaid could have been determined after Trump's term. "The details of how it was arranged and who was going to get what—who was going to give the money and all of that—were obviously not going to be done by Donald Trump," the official said. "It's the sort of thing that Jared would do. His family background made him an expert."

Trump benefitted from the relationship, too. After he left office, in 2021, his country clubs were named as major venues for the *LIV* Golf tour, which is backed by the Saudi Public Investment Fund. His businesses also signed licensing agreements for a series of new properties in the region, including a Trump Tower in Jeddah.

In 2024, Affinity's chief legal officer, Chad Mizelle, was called to speak with investigators from the Senate Finance Committee. Mizelle told them that Affinity was funded entirely by a few foreign clients; apart from the three Gulf states, the only other investors were Terry Gou, a Taiwanese billionaire who employs roughly a million people in China, and a fifth party, whom Mizelle refused to name. Investigators asked what returns Affinity had earned for its investors, and Mizelle's answer surprised them: there hadn't been any yet. Private-equity funds often tell investors not to expect immediate results, but investigators noted other concerns. Nearly three years into a five-year investment term, Affinity was managing three billion dollars of its clients' capital but had invested barely a third of it. In the same period, the Finance Committee estimated, it had collected a hundred and fifty-seven million dollars in fees.



Cartoon by Roz Chast

Senator Ron Wyden, among others, suspected that Affinity was just a vehicle for Gulf leaders to enrich Kushner. (Kushner’s spokesman denied this.) Wyden noted in a letter to Mizelle that, if Trump was elected to a second term, the investments would give the Gulf states enormous leverage. The Administration “will have financial motives to make foreign policy decisions that may be counter to the national interest in order to ensure Kushner and Ivanka Trump continue to collect millions of dollars in fees,” he wrote.

Kushner insisted that he had no intention of rejoining the government, but his investors believed that he would remain influential. “The Emiratis saw Jared as a fixture, someone who is going to be around a long time,” a former senior U.S. official told me. “They were investing in the relationship.” As it seemed increasingly likely that Trump would win another term, Qatar and the U.A.E. made new contributions totalling \$1.5 billion to Kushner’s fund. Those contributions were made just before the November, 2024, election, but Kushner waited until afterward to speak publicly about them. “It’s not complicated,” the Kushner acquaintance told

me. “All the Middle Eastern countries invest in Jared’s fund, and they suck his dick, so they can get political favors from the Trump Administration.”

When Kushner returned to diplomatic work, he declined to take a salary, and White House lawyers argued that this made it impossible for his government and business interests to conflict. Most ethics specialists, however, see the issue of his salary as irrelevant; federal law prohibits government agents from participating in matters in which they have a financial stake. Virginia Canter, a former White House counsel and an ethics lawyer at the Securities and Exchange Commission, told me, “Kushner is plagued with conflicts of interest. He is supposed to be working for the American people, but in fact he has tremendous financial incentives to further the interests of his investors.” Kushner and Witkoff rebuffed concerns about their conflicts, and they didn’t take any reporters along on diplomatic trips. (Witkoff argues that he has divested from his business interests by giving control of them to his sons.) Karoline Leavitt, the White House press secretary, brushed off skeptics: “Jared is donating his energy and his time to our government, to the President of the United States, to secure world peace, and that is a very noble thing.”

The deals Kushner has assembled in Trump’s second term have made little distinction between personal friends, government associates, and family connections. In September, 2025, he initiated a first round of funding for a startup called Brain Co., which aims to sell A.I. services to businesses and governments. His partner in the venture is Luis Videgaray, the former foreign minister of Mexico, who was his counterpart in negotiating trade agreements during Trump’s first term. Among the funders are the Silicon Valley C.E.O.s Patrick Collison, who gave hundreds of thousands of dollars to Republicans during the 2024 election season, and Brian Armstrong, whose company contributed a million dollars to Trump’s Inauguration fund. In December, Trump signed an executive order limiting states’ ability to regulate A.I.

By the standards of this Administration, these conflicts are not extraordinary. David Sacks, one of Trump’s top technology officials, has overseen scores of regulations on A.I. while owning stakes in some five hundred companies tied to the industry. Commerce Secretary Howard

Lutnick led a deal to mine tungsten in Kazakhstan, backed by as much as \$1.6 billion in federal funding; Lutnick's old firm, Cantor Fitzgerald, which is now controlled by his sons, helped secure investments in the project and stands to collect millions of dollars in fees.

Trump himself recently disclosed that he has made more than two billion dollars since his Inauguration, much of it from his cryptocurrency businesses, which have attracted investments from foreign governments and individuals seeking influence. In 2025, Emirati funds bought a half-billion-dollar stake in World Liberty Financial—a company founded by members of the Witkoff and Trump families, including Eric and Donald Trump, Jr.—then used its cryptocurrency to execute a two-billion-dollar deal. Two weeks later, Trump granted the U.A.E. access to a supply of the world's most advanced computer chips, despite concerns from national-security officials that the Emiratis would share the chips with China.

Last January, at the annual gathering of international business and government leaders in Davos, Switzerland, Kushner gave a presentation outlining his ideas for rebuilding Gaza. The Strip had been largely obliterated in the war between Hamas and Israel, and most of its two million inhabitants were living in tents or in the ruins; images of human misery had flooded screens around the world. But, where others saw desolation, Kushner saw a development opportunity. He called his plan Project Sunrise.

In a series of PowerPoint slides, he laid out a vision of the Gaza seacoast ten years in the future. It looked like Miami Beach: shiny new condominiums, office towers, a high-speed rail network, and “one hundred per cent full employment.” The price, Kushner said, would be a hundred and twelve billion dollars, financed by international donors and neighboring states. He promised “amazing investment opportunities” for the private sector, and told the crowd to plan for “catastrophic success.” To some in the audience, the presentation seemed detached from reality. “People were rolling their eyes,” Philip Gordon, a former White House national-security adviser, told me. “It struck everybody as a complete fantasy.” But it echoed Trump's pitch for rebuilding Gaza into “the Riviera of the Middle East.”

Kushner's involvement in Gaza began before Trump's second Inauguration, when he and Witkoff worked with Biden officials trying to secure a ceasefire and the release of the last of Hamas's hostages. "Jared was very straight and nonpartisan," a former senior member of the Biden White House told me.

Kushner's role in the Gaza talks called for impartiality, but Hamas negotiators might have had reason to be skeptical. A friend of Kushner's told me that he had returned to the White House in part because "he thinks he can help Israel." And, though he has sometimes spoken of bettering the lives of Palestinians, he showed little compunction about setting aside their interests to secure the Abraham Accords. At Harvard in 2024, he had said that the best place for residents of Gaza would probably be in Israel's Negev Desert. He didn't explain how they would be compelled to move, or whether they would be permitted to return. In his description, Gaza is a dystopian place, "built by N.G.O.s and terrorists."

Kushner and Witkoff shuttled between Israel and Qatar, where Hamas leaders were being housed at America's request. They met with Turkish and Saudi leaders, along with a few Palestinians. A turning point came in September, when Israeli jets bombed Qatar and killed the son of Hamas's lead negotiator, Khalil al-Hayya. Trump was furious, believing that Israel was trying to sabotage the talks. He forced Netanyahu to apologize to Qatar's Prime Minister on camera—while Trump held the phone. Afterward, he sent Kushner and Witkoff to meet with Hamas leaders in Egypt, where they secured a ceasefire and the release of the last of the hostages. They also won an assurance from the Israelis to forgo large-scale offensive operations in Gaza. But Trump's role was decisive. "Jared and Witkoff didn't really do the ceasefire," the former senior official in the Biden White House told me. "Trump called Bibi and said, 'Stop the goddam bombing,' and that was the end of it."

In October, a twenty-point Gaza peace agreement was signed, calling for the disarmament of Hamas, the withdrawal of Israeli forces, and the rebuilding of the territory. To oversee its implementation, Trump had formed a U.S.-backed body called the Board of Peace. He envisioned the board, which included Kushner, as a kind of privatized United Nations: any

country could participate, if it agreed to contribute a billion dollars. He appointed a separate board of Palestinians to supervise the reconstruction of Gaza.

Trump convened the Board of Peace in February, and barely a week later he began strikes on Iran. As the Iranian war consumed the White House's attention, the situation in Gaza all but collapsed. Hamas refused to turn over its weapons, and the Israel Defense Forces pushed deeper into Gaza, taking over more than half of the territory and strictly controlling access. Some leaders in Netanyahu's Cabinet began calling for Gaza to be reopened to settlers. In the coming months, I.D.F. attacks killed nearly a thousand Palestinians, many of them civilians.

Nickolay Mladenov, the Board of Peace's representative for Gaza, recently announced that Hamas had agreed to a new plan, under which the group would begin to surrender its weapons if Israel began to withdraw. But Israel would not budge until Hamas fully disarmed. Although the board's member states have pledged seventeen billion dollars, no money has yet been deposited in its official account. About five thousand recruits for a new police force have been vetted, but training has yet to begin.

The former senior official in Biden's White House credited Kushner, Witkoff, and Trump with at least bringing the worst of the fighting to an end. "Would we be doing any better?" he said. "I don't think so. It's just an awful situation." For Palestinians, though, life has grown increasingly desperate. Aid workers told me that, on average, Israeli forces allow in only about a third of the food and other humanitarian aid that the government has agreed to let pass. About two-thirds of Gaza's people are thought to be malnourished; as many as seven in ten babies are born underweight. There is virtually no running water, and two million people are bathing in the ocean. Many Gazans say that the Israeli government is trying to push them out. "It's one hundred per cent engineered suffering," Hani Almadhoun, who runs a network of kitchens in Gaza, told me. "I don't think Kushner is a horrible person. I think he's trying to help. But he has no impact in Gaza."

In the summer of 2021, Edi Rama, the Prime Minister of Albania, was invited onto a superyacht moored off the ancient city of Durrës, on the Adriatic coast. The yacht, the Planet Nine, was owned by the financier Nat

Rothschild, a scion of the European banking family. Among his other guests were Kushner and Ivanka Trump.

Rama was in his eighth year as the leader of Albania, and Kushner treated him with deference. “When you’re watching on TV, Jared looks like a very cold-blooded assassin, and Ivanka looks like a very distant, self-referential person,” Rama said. In person, “you wouldn’t believe the humbleness.”

The yacht took the party to Sazan, a nearly uninhabited island off the Albanian coast. “We stopped for a swim—effectively that’s how we found it,” Ivanka told the “Founders” podcast. “We went on a hike barefoot all the way up to the top, and we were just captivated.”

Sazan is a rugged place—strewn with rocks and tangles of trees, populated by a large colony of rats, and studded with bunkers built by the Marxist dictator Enver Hoxha to defend against an imaginary invasion. But it offers sweeping views of a turquoise sea, and the Kushners saw an opportunity there. They had already been encouraged to invest in Albania by Richard Grenell, who formerly served as Trump’s special envoy in the region and has since worked with Affinity.

A few months later, Kushner told Rama that he wanted to build resorts on Sazan and on the peninsula of Zvërnec, which shields a wide lagoon. He envisioned a hamlet for the super-rich, with golf courses, a port for yachts, and ten thousand hotel rooms and condominium units. The projects would require an investment of some four billion dollars; for the first phase, Kushner secured funds from two Qatari billionaires.

Rama loved Kushner’s idea. He believed that the project would create thousands of jobs and make Albania, which is one of the poorest countries in Europe, a destination for the sorts of people he hobnobbed with at Davos. “It’s a fact that high-end tourism brings more income,” he said. Rama declared Kushner’s development company a “strategic investor,” an official designation that allowed the government to use public resources to support the project.

In elite circles in the West, Rama is a minor celebrity; he is a former basketball star, with a rangy frame and a long gray beard that combine to

give him the aspect of Moses in a warmup suit. He's a pro-Western leader of a Muslim-majority country and, as he likes to remind people, a devoted visual artist. When I visited his office, in Tirana, he was making an abstract drawing with crayons.

Rama's goal is to lead Albania, which was isolated from the West for nearly fifty years during the Communist era, into the European Union. He told me that Kushner's plan could help. "He wants to have a signature project that will identify him as someone who cares about all the sensible issues of the day, from the environment to preservation and art and culture," he said. "The project's ambition is to do something absolutely unique, not just for Albania but for Europe. This is my ambition, too."

A similar project of Kushner's had recently ended in failure. In Serbia, next door to Albania, he and Grenell planned to build a five-hundred-million-dollar Trump International Hotel and apartment complex. The design centered on the abandoned General Staff Building, which American warplanes had bombed in 1999, during a *NATO* operation to protect ethnic Albanians from a government-sponsored campaign of terror.



"Cemeteries are such a depressing reminder that I'm bad at doing math in my head."
Cartoon by Adam Sacks

The building had been designated a protected cultural site, and Kushner agreed to honor historians' concerns by building a memorial "dedicated to all the victims of *NATO* aggression." The government of President Aleksandar Vučić, a populist and a vocal Trump supporter, fast-tracked approvals. But protests sprang up, and eventually Serbian prosecutors charged the minister of culture with falsifying documents to secure permits.

(The minister denied this.) There was no indication that anyone on Kushner's team had broken the law, but in April he decided to bow out. "Meaningful projects should unite rather than divide," a statement from Affinity said.

If the project in Albania united people, though, it was in opposition to the Kushners. In February, 2024, Rama's party, which controlled a majority of the parliament, passed an amendment enabling the construction of luxury projects in protected areas, including Zvërnec. A few weeks later, Kushner announced his plans—and then his dream began to collide with Albania's political realities.

Although Ivanka had referred to Sazan as a "private island," the area had long been open to the public. And the development in Zvërnec was planned to be constructed in the middle of a forty-thousand-acre nature preserve. Kushner's local partners fenced off a site that had been a popular spot for beachgoers. Albanians began complaining that he had been awarded development rights without public notice or competitive bidding, and that the amendment to unlock protected land had been rushed through parliament. Rama even allowed an airport to be built inside the preserve.

Almost overnight, Rama found himself a target of widespread anger, and Kushner became a villain—a plutocrat who wanted to transform a large swath of the country into a playground for the rich. The secrecy around the project rankled; even though almost a quarter of it is owned by Albanian businessmen, their names are hidden in an offshore corporation. In June, locals tore down the fence around the beach. Then public demonstrations began. Every night, people gathered in Tirana's main square and marched to Rama's residence, a mile away, chanting as they went.

At first, the protesters focussed on stopping Kushner's development. But by the time I visited, a few weeks later, their goals seemed to have changed—to forcing Rama from office and remaking Albania's political system. "This is much bigger than Jared Kushner now," Erlis Çela, a communications professor in Tirana, told me one night, as he marched with thousands of other Albanians. "There is a tiny group of people in this country with too much money, and overnight, in the dark, they make all the country's decisions."

To many people I spoke with, Kushner's project reflected a disturbing truth about Albania: the country's wealth and power were held by a handful of oligarchs, who had grown rich through illegal activities such as money laundering for international criminal groups. The proceeds from the laundered money, they said, were evident all around Tirana, in the form of largely empty apartment buildings that Albanians refer to as "concrete banks." "Rama has created this system where the oligarchs and the politicians and the media work together, and it gives them license to do almost anything they want," Fatos Lubonja, a journalist who was jailed as a political prisoner in the Communist era, told me. "Rama needs people like Kushner to be his face, to provide him with international support."

Kushner remained silent about the demonstrations, but Rama was unbowed. He blamed the opposition to the resort on a political mood prevalent among young Albanians. "It's a whole ideology out there—the ideology of anti-capitalist Gen Z, which has nothing to do with truth and facts," he said. "I'm not worried about these protests. There is no protest that is going to stop this."

Another obstacle might, though. From Tirana, I drove down the Adriatic coast to the area that Kushner wants to develop. Near Zvërnec, I passed an Orthodox monastery called St. Mary's, a relic of the Eastern Roman Empire, and arrived at a market. There, a group of locals told me that nearly all of them owned land inside the area slated for development. Kushner, they said, had involved himself in a years-old legal dispute that he didn't understand.

A retired fruit picker named Minella Konomi walked me up a hill overlooking the Adriatic. White flamingos and red-footed falcons floated above the lagoon, framed by a long strip of dune and beach. Konomi pointed to a spot in the distance that he said marked his family's patch of land. His ancestors had grown corn and onions there since the time of the Ottomans, he told me; it had lain fallow recently, but he had documents to prove that he had regularly paid taxes on it. "We've been here a hundred years," he said.

In 2006, Konomi told me, he was informed that his land had been acquired by Artur Shehu, an Albanian businessman who had previously been

investigated for his alleged involvement in smuggling drugs and migrants. Nothing came of those investigations, but Shehu had fled the country after what police described as a shoot-out with a rival gang.

Shehu made his way to Miami Beach, where he secured political asylum by claiming that allies of the old Communist government were coming after him. But he kept doing business in Albania, ultimately assembling a large parcel of land around Zvërnec. The parcel, the locals said, included land that was rightfully theirs. “Shehu falsified the documents,” Konomi told me.

In April, a company developing Kushner’s project paid Shehu a hundred and twenty-five million dollars for land in Zvërnec. Two months later, prosecutors issued a new arrest warrant for Shehu, on suspicion of drug trafficking and money laundering. In documents filed in an Albanian court, they argued that the land involved in Kushner’s development was “suspected of having been illegally acquired through forgeries.” (Shehu denied all accusations.) If the court rules in their favor, Kushner’s project may have to be halted. For Lubonja, the fate of the resort is a test of how far his country had come. “People think that the reformed justice system in Albania is working,” he said. “In my view, this is impossible. It’s like a fleet of ships that all go in one direction. You cannot turn it around with just one small ship.”

Earlier this year, as Kushner engaged in talks with Iran, he was also discreetly raising another five billion dollars for Affinity in the Middle East. After the attacks on Tehran began, suspicions arose that the two endeavors were linked. “My sense is that he thinks he was killing two birds with one stone—he was helping the Arabs defeat the Iranians, and he wanted to be paid for it,” an American with deep ties to Middle Eastern leaders told me.

Since the war has devolved into a quagmire, Kushner and Witkoff have been relegated to a secondary role in peace talks; Vance took the lead in the latest round, this summer. A former senior U.S. official told me that the Gulf monarchies were disappointed by Kushner’s failure to prevent a war: “They were investing money in him. They thought that would bring them some influence that would protect them, and it did the opposite.” He added, “Their whole business model was stability. And now it’s gone.”

Yet Kushner has thrived. In 2025, new investments from the Middle East helped his fund grow by thirty per cent, to more than six billion dollars, meaning that it collects at least tens of millions of dollars a year in fees. Affinity estimates its annual internal rate of return at twenty-five per cent. Among its projects are two large investments in Israel: a hundred and ten million dollars in the Shlomo Group, a car-leasing firm, and about three hundred million dollars in Phoenix Financial, an insurance company. Again, Kushner used Saudi money, as part of a broader goal of opening an “investment corridor” between Saudi Arabia and Israel. M.B.S. didn’t contest the deal, although Phoenix has a checkered record on Palestinian rights; it holds shares in businesses named in a U.N. database of companies that operate in illegal settlements in the West Bank, East Jerusalem, and the occupied Golan Heights. In July, Affinity sold a quarter of its holdings in Phoenix for nearly three hundred and fifty million dollars.

By far the biggest of Kushner’s recent deals was the acquisition of Electronic Arts, a major video-game manufacturer often referred to as E.A. Last August, Kushner, who enjoys playing video games with M.B.S., connected him with Andrew Wilson, the head of the company. The two met in Neom, the futuristic city that M.B.S. is constructing on the Red Sea, and played a round of golf. “Jared brought M.B.S. the deal,” the American with ties to Middle Eastern leaders told me. Not long afterward, M.B.S. assembled a consortium, including Affinity, to acquire E.A. for fifty-five billion dollars—the largest leveraged buyout in history. The deal raised potential regulatory concerns: E.A. handles a huge amount of users’ private data. But the Committee on Foreign Investment in the United States, a federal interagency panel tasked with reviewing such deals, is largely made up of Trump officials, and the President has final authority. The deal was approved last month.

For Kushner, the risk of mixing politics and business is that political currents will turn against him: his patrons overseas will stop seeing him as a valuable ally, or his opponents in the U.S. will find ways of prosecuting his apparent violations of ethics laws. If the Democrats win a majority in either house this fall, Kushner’s dealings will likely come under greater scrutiny. One Democratic aide told me that they could call Kushner to testify before Congress, or simply induce the private company that administers his funds,

S.E.I. Investments, to hand over its records. “We’re going to push very hard for that,” the aide told me. But it’s not clear that lawmakers, or even prosecutors, will be able to do much. Trump, who has been granted sweeping legal immunity by the Supreme Court, has vowed to issue pardons for members of his team who face investigation. “If Kushner wasn’t the son-in-law of the President, he would be under investigation by the F.B.I.,” Virginia Canter, the ethics lawyer, said. “No one else could get away with this.” ♦

[Dexter Filkins](#) is a staff writer at *The New Yorker* and the author of “[The Forever War](#),” which won a National Book Critics Circle Award.

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Shouts & Murmurs

- **[My Surefire, Can't-Lose Polymarket Bets](#)**

By Shalom Auslander | Spot on my neck: Cancer? 88% Yes. 12% More tests are needed, none of which are covered by my insurance.

[Shouts & Murmurs](#)

My Surefire, Can't-Lose Polymarket Bets

By [Shalom Auslander](#)

September 14, 2026



Illustration by Luci Gutiérrez

Will these pants still fit me?

100% No.

Is it my fault?

100% Yes.

I don't mean the pants—I mean everything.

100% Yes.

It's a beautiful day, with bright-blue skies, a warm sun, and a cool breeze. So this afternoon I'm going to take a walk in the park. I will pass a young couple in love, laughing in the sunshine. Will I assume that they are laughing at me?

100% Yes.

Spot on my neck: Cancer?

88% Yes.

12% More tests are needed, none of which my insurance will cover.

I've forgotten where I parked—am I getting old?

10% Yes.

90% I am getting old, but in this case my car has been stolen.

At some point during today's session, will it seem to me that my shrink is writing a lot more on his notepad than usual?

100% Yes.

Is he?

100% Yes.

Approximately how long after I receive my scalding-hot coffee will the turbulence begin?

10% Immediately.

20% As the flight attendant is handing it over, just above my laptop.

70% It doesn't matter—the engines have all failed.

Just going back to that spot on my neck: Is a spot with defined edges cancer, or a spot with undefined edges?

100% Whichever kind of spot I have is cancer.

I read a novel recently that was legitimately awful. Even putting aside the dull structure and thin characters, it was clear that the writer had nothing new to say and couldn't even be bothered to risk saying an old thing in a new way; the entire book felt like an exercise in cynicism, as if it had been crafted with the sole intention of being just middling enough to succeed.

Will it be a best-seller?

50% National best-seller.

50% Global phenomenon.

Will it win awards?

100% Yes.

Will the awards be given on merit or just to annoy me personally?

100% Just to annoy me personally.

Why is that car following me? It's been following me for, like, fifteen minutes.

10% Because he's behind me on the 405.

90% Because he's following me home to kill me.

What was that noise?

100% Something bad.

After a casual lunch with a good friend, will I, later, overthinking the conversation, take a few of her words out of context and interpret them as a vicious attack?

100% Yes.

Will I know, before she and I get together again, that I will perceive an attack regardless of what she says?

100% Yes.

And will I perceive it anyway?

100% Yes.

Remember that thing I did, a few weeks back, that everyone said I shouldn't do, but which I did anyway, because I march to the beat of my own drum and because fortune favors the brave? Will that blow up in my face?

40% Yes.

30% It already has.

30% "Blow up" doesn't quite cover it.

Does anyone else hear that humming sound?

100% No.

Back to that spot on my neck: Treatable?

100% No. But, even if it is, my undiscovered brain tumor is not.

Comedy or tragedy?

Too close to call. ♦

[Shalom Auslander](#) is the author of “[Feh: A Memoir](#),” which received the 2026 Thurber Prize for American humor writing.

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Fiction

- **[“Lost Child”](#)**

By Joyce Carol Oates | It almost returned to Kit then—what this place was, and who was waiting for them inside.

Fiction

Lost Child

By [Joyce Carol Oates](#)

September 13, 2026



Photograph by Holly Andres for The New Yorker

He said, Come with me! Take Daddy's hand.

How all the stories begin. A large hand lowered, your small hand lifted.

She isn't sure, she admits, exactly what happened.

Or when. She knows that she was little.

Maybe four years old. Maybe three.

Just guessing. Mists of time, thinly whitewashed wall of memory . . .

No. Katherine *does* remember something about when. For today—Thursday, March 12, 2026—is an anniversary of that day.

It was, Take Daddy's hand but *hurry*. Something was going to happen—unless it had already happened.

For, with Kit's father, something was always either going to happen or had already happened, and it was either too late to stop it from happening or too early to even imagine it happening, but, in any case, Hurry, sweetie! God damn.

[Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.](#)

Not used to dressing herself. The new rosy-pink raincoat, crookedly buttoned, but maybe Daddy wouldn't notice.

Hours later, at the hospital, parking at the rear—a high-rise garage, which Kit's father hated because it slowed him down, Fucking God damn.

Kit cringed a little when Daddy spoke in a harsh voice, but she understood: Daddy was not talking to *her*.

When they were alone together—which was often now—Daddy joked that the two of them were practically living in this shithole car. Daddy was rarely silent; he was too nervous, edgy, to be silent. He seemed to be

addressing Kit, but Kit knew that he would be annoyed if she interrupted him to reply.

Crucial to Kit not to annoy her father. If she was sweetly quiet, obedient, Daddy smiled at her with the radiance of Daddy love, and Kit basked in his love like a cat stretched out in the sun.

Kit's fear was that Daddy's smile would disappear. Like a light switched off.

You would have to have known him to understand, Katherine says.

Cursing as he made his way up through the parking garage, turning the wheel sharply, row after row of vehicles, nowhere to park, though the sign at the entrance had said "Open."

True that Daddy was in a hurry, but true, also, that, when Daddy at last found a parking space, on the top level of the garage, he did not drive into it head first but took time to maneuver the vehicle around so that he could back it in. Daddy felt compelled always to back into a parking space; here, an alarmingly narrow gap between two large vehicles which required many excruciating minutes, Daddy grimacing as he peered into the car's side mirrors, easing back a few inches, then forward again. His breathing came fast. His forehead glistened with moisture.

Podcast: The Writer's Voice

[Listen to Joyce Carol Oates read "Lost Child."](#)

Rainwater in puddles on the garage floor. Slow-drifting fog, mist.

The smell of her father's breath, like fumes.

In the back seat of the car, a potted plant, its blooms wrapped in crinkly cellophane, amid random newspapers, napkins, coffee cups. Also, a small suitcase so stuffed that one of the compartments was only partly zipped.

C'mon, silly. Nothing to be afraid of.

Kit smiled uncertainly. For Daddy was smiling. *Nothing to be afraid of?* It had not occurred to Kit that there might be something to be afraid of.

Two elevators in the parking garage. Both were slow to ascend to the top level. Daddy took the concrete steps down, gripping Kit's hand.

Kit was out of breath descending the stairs.

But here was relief: in the cold, wet air, she could not smell Daddy's strong breath. And Daddy stood tall above her and would protect her, for he *was* the daddy, as he told Kit often.

He remarked, as they approached the revolving doors of the tall building, on how "cavernous" this place was, which, he said, laughing, could sound to the careless ear like "carnivorous."

Kit had no idea what her father meant, these jokes of his. Though, now that they were together so much, she heard them often.

Nothing to be afraid of, smoochie! Hauling Kit into the revolving door the way you'd lift a startled little dog, for, Daddy knew, Kit was afraid of revolving doors that moved too fast for her short legs.

See? Nothing to be afraid of.

Inside the hospital, a high ceiling, bright lights, and echoing voices. That sharp smell, a chemical smell, that made Kit's nostrils pinch and caused a sick sensation in her stomach, for, she remembered, she'd been here before, in this hospital place.

It almost returned to Kit then—what this place was, and who was waiting for them inside. But then the memory faded the way a dream does when you open your eyes too soon.

Sir? Excuse me. . . .

Long-legged Daddy walking fast but not fast enough, for he was stopped by a security guard and asked to show I.D. He extracted his driver's license

from his wallet, saying, in a loud, sarcastic voice, Every fucking time pretending you don't know who the fuck I am!

Embarrassing to Kit, Daddy's loud voice. Strangers glancing at him, curious, startled.

Usually, Kit's father was affably smiling. People liked him on sight or wanted to like him, women especially. A man who, if he smiled, winked. Even sarcasm turned sweet in his mouth.

Kit's father scrawled his name, or an insolent semblance of his name, into a book. The security guard issued him a time-stamped badge. Waved Kit's father through the checkpoint stiff-faced, unsmiling.

But a smile for *her*, sweet little girl tugged along by Daddy.

More walking. More jostling. Behind Kit's eyes, tiredness swam like a soft explosion of warm water.

Almost Kit's bedtime, except there was no bedtime now, exactly.

For the day had been long. Kit could not remember the beginning of this long day.

Driving to the bank. It was impressive to Kit, to drive with Daddy to the bank.

Kit's father expressed the wish for cash. *Good old-fashioned cash*. In polite-Daddy voice, expressed the wish to close out the account.

But there was a problem—a bank officer had to be summoned.

Your wife's signature is required to close out the account.

Kit steeled herself, knowing that, since the bank officer was a woman, there would be a disagreement, because Kit's father did not like to be “bossed around” by a woman.

Kit's father's voice rising, indignant. He sent Kit away to sit in a chair by the wall.



“Want to hear how my vacation went now or wait and hear me rehash the same story to a dozen different people?”

Cartoon by Daniel Kanhai

Eventually, a second bank officer was summoned. This was a man, an older man with a waffle face and a thatch of white hair atop a burly body, but he *was* a man, so Kit was not so worried.

In the hard-cushioned chair, Kit could not keep her eyes open, and being asleep and being awake became confused.

Roughly, Daddy woke Kit, tugged her to her feet, asking if she needed to use the rest room now. Better now than later.

What was the right answer? If Kit said no, she would be scolded for changing her mind later, for when Kit needed a bathroom it was often sudden, a near-emergency.

But, if Kit said yes, maybe that was a wrong answer, too, for Daddy was rattling his car keys. She could see that he was in a hurry.

Daddy's eyes squinched when he smiled. Winking, assuring Kit that they were in the homestretch now.

The words “*ho-o-ome streh-h-h-tch*” were drawn out like an elastic band.

No idea what any of this meant, but Kit laughed to please Daddy.

Lunch they'd eaten late, in the car. Out of crinkly white paper bags. Daddy drinking from a can of something harsh-smelling, then from a bottle of something sweet-smelling inside another paper bag. Kit was very hungry, but then not so hungry. Coarse hamburger meat she had to chew and chew. Icy-cold French fries smeared with ketchup, falling between the front seats, where even Kit's small hand could not retrieve them.

Hey! Wake up! Kit's father sounded more amused than annoyed.

Kit's eyes flew open. There'd been Kit's mother smiling at Kit, trying to explain, but her words were muffled. Trying to explain why she'd gone away, how it was not her choice but just something that had happened.

Kit did *not* like elevators.

Daddy always positioned himself right in front of the elevator door. With Kit in front of him, his hands heavy on her shoulders.

But, when the elevator door opened, people pushed out. Kit's father seemed never to be prepared for people pushing out, as if it were a personal annoyance to him.

Nudging Kit. Get in! Push in!

Always too many people. Adult legs, handbags pressing against Kit. Close, stale air that Kit tried not to breathe.

And, if you were the first into the elevator, that meant you were pushed toward the back as people stepped in, and always there were more people pushing in than there was room for, and so a man's voice would intervene sharply, *No more room! Take the next elevator, please.*

The elevator door shut. Lights began to flicker on a panel above the door, indicating the floors—1, 2, 3. . . . Kit tried not to panic. As the elevator was rising, she knew, the cable pulling it up could snap at any time; suddenly, the elevator could be falling.

Once, Kit had seen an empty elevator shaft. Just greasy cables, like giant snakes.

The sight had terrified her, but Daddy had laughed. Indeed, Kit was being silly.

The elevator jerked to a stop, the door opened, and people exited, but this was not their floor. Another stop, the doors opened and people exited, but this was still not their floor. At last, on the eighth floor, Kit's father nudged her to exit, and so she did, pushing past legs, stepping out of the elevator with two other people, both men, and standing to the side, waiting for her father to join her, but where was Daddy? The elevator door was closing, and Daddy was still inside!

Kit stood staring, incredulous. Her mouth was slack with wonder at how the elevator door had just *closed*.

It had been one of Kit's worries, for as long as she could remember, that in a strange place like this she would become separated from her mother: at the grocery store, with many aisles and people pushing shopping carts, or in Macy's at the mall, or on an escalator that was moving, where, if you stepped onto one of the stairs, you could not step back down but had to go up.

It had not happened yet to Kit that she had been separated from her mother, but, still, her mother seemed to have been separated from *her*.

And now it was Daddy that Kit worried about being separated from. *Daddy is just hiding, to make me laugh*, she thought.

Daddy did like to make Kit laugh, and Daddy did like to tease. But Daddy could not now see Kit or laugh at her for being silly.

It was not possible that Daddy had stepped out of the elevator just behind her, because Kit would have seen him if he had. Kit would be seeing him now, and she did not see him.

Too frightened, too stunned to call, *Daddy? Daddy?* Her voice was such a sad, weak voice, no one would hear.

What to do? Where to go? She was just standing there by the elevator. Her heart beating as fast as a sparrow's heart. Waiting for the elevator door to open—for Kit was sure that it would open, and Daddy would step out laughing at her.

Unless he was annoyed with her. Perhaps Kit had done something wrong unknowingly. Ketchup on the car seat, French fries fallen beneath the seat. A mitten lost. Another mitten lost.

He didn't like her crying, that was for sure. He would probably tell her, Don't be a silly baby, just stay where you are. I am on the way.

Trying not to cry. Trying not to shiver so hard. Waiting right in front of the elevator door so Daddy could not miss her. How long it was, how many terrible minutes before the elevator returned, going down. (Kit could see the numbers above the door, an arrow going down from 11 to 10 to 9.) And the door opened, but it must have been a mistake, as no one stepped out. The elevator was full of people, but Daddy was not among them. Daddy did not emerge from the elevator as Kit peered inside frantically. No one noticed her, no one cared in the slightest about her, brooding and inward with their own thoughts, as Daddy sometimes was, and, to her horror, the elevator door closed again.

But *where* was Daddy?

All this had to be a mistake: Daddy knew that Kit was on the eighth floor.

Daddy knew and had to be looking for her, so it was important to stay right where she was. If she did not, Daddy would not be able to find her.

Kit was so scared that her teeth were chattering. Her mouth had gone dry—she could not swallow. Could not stop shivering. Breathing in gasps like hiccups, couldn't draw enough breath, so it felt as if she were drowning because she was *so, so cold*.

Abruptly, Katherine's voice breaks off. She is very pale, seems to be having difficulty breathing even now. She lifts a water glass to her mouth, but a fit of coughing overcomes her. Water spills down her hand and onto the enamel tabletop.

Katherine? Are you all right?

I am anxious for my friend, who may be hyperventilating. But, when I reach for her hand, Katherine jerks away and, with a weak smile, signals that she is all right and I shouldn't make a fuss.

Katherine's eyes are shadowed; her usually smooth forehead is creased. Her hand holding the water glass is trembling. She is embarrassed and apologetic—vexed with herself for having lost control in this public place. It is so unlike Katherine Carpenter, who is normally poised, restrained. Not one to talk at length—and rarely about herself—but today she has been telling me her chilling story in a halting voice, as if she were groping in the dark. Though it is obviously a personal story, she tells it as if the child, Kit, were a stranger, a figure to be pitied.

Katherine rises unsteadily from the table. Excuses herself to go to the rest room. So sorry! I'll be right back.

Left alone at our table, I am feeling awkward, self-conscious. Usually at the Purple Onion, a moderately priced café, we are a group, never fewer than four friends; always at one of the café's round tables, which we book in advance.

The restaurant is nearly deserted, as it is early, only a few minutes past noon. The story that Katherine has been telling is painful to hear. I'm dreading what comes next.

Shortly after eight this morning, Katherine called to ask if we could meet for lunch. It was late notice, but there was such urgency in her voice that I hardly recognized it.

Our lunches at the Purple Onion are often lively, festive. The laughter of women together, without men. Divorcées, widows. When the ex-husband

dies, the divorcée becomes an honorary widow. At another lunch, we'd welcomed Katherine to this status, amid much laughter.

Today feels odd, just Katherine and me. As if the world has shrunk.

We live in a small town—officially, a village—a university community. We can recognize when one of us is, but also isn't, *herself*.

The first wrong thing: Katherine ordered a drink as soon as we were seated. Katherine Carpenter, who never drinks. She did this with a giddy, embarrassed laugh to acknowledge and deflect my curiosity, explaining that today was “sort of a special day, an anniversary.”

A frothy pink drink, she ordered. With a festive name, like Ginger-Lemon Spritz.

Anniversary? I asked.

But she didn't care to explain at that moment. She'd taken up the menu, frowning. A menu she likely knows by heart, as I do.

Katherine Carpenter is an attractive woman in her mid-fifties, who carries herself so lightly that she might be mistaken for a much younger woman. She retired from her job as a full-time curator at the university art museum, but when the museum was renovated, expanded to twice its former size, she was rehired as a consultant, a position that suits her.

Katherine's features are delicate, her eyebrows thinly arched like birds' wings in an ancient Chinese scroll. She usually wears neutral colors, inconspicuous clothing of (probably) good quality. Her hair is brushed, practically, behind her ears, a fair, fading silver brown. Today, her eyes appear slightly bloodshot, as if she'd slept poorly last night. Her smile is twitchy, eager.

Flattering that Katherine Carpenter is eager to see *me*.

But she is clearly desperate not to be alone today. Perhaps she first tried other friends who did not pick up.

I understand that I must help her. I must not shield myself from her. Though it is not my way to share emotions with others. I am not an emotional person, and it is unfair to me to expect more of me than I have to give.

But now I'm wondering if I should follow Katherine to the rest room, see if she is all right.

Maybe she has changed her mind? Maybe she regrets speaking so openly to me, baring her heart?

Maybe Katherine has fled the Purple Onion and will send a text message, apologizing. *Please forgive me. I will explain soon. . . .*

(Which would be a relief to me, I have to admit.)

Not that I am *afraid* of feeling. For a very long time, I have avoided feeling, as I have avoided close contact with others. But it is not fear—just simple caution, not wanting old wounds to be rudely reopened after serviceable scabs, now scars, have grown over them.

The friendly waiter, Hugo, has delivered our lunches: heavy stoneware plates heaped with salad greens, multigrain rolls in a little woven basket. I am not sure if I have no appetite or if I am ravenous with hunger.

Katherine's frothy pink Ginger-Lemon Spritz is inviting. I'm almost tempted to sip from it.

When Katherine returns and sits across from me at the table, she looks more composed. Though her skin is still ashen, her eyes threaded with thin, broken capillaries.

She says, embarrassed, Sorry! Couldn't stop coughing. And touches the back of my hand lightly, in apology. Her fingertips are icy cold.

I feel a sudden urge to grasp Katherine's fingers. To reassure her: *You are safe now.*

Katherine tells me that she would understand completely if I would prefer not to hear any more of her "sordid, sad tale."

I assure her that it isn't sordid.

But, yes, it *is*, she says, and laughs.

Of course I want to know what happened, I tell Katherine. How could I not want to know?

That poor terrified girl waiting by the elevator for her daddy—what became of her?

She isn't sure, she admits, exactly what happened.

For it isn't what happens that you remember but what you're told to remember.

Waiting for Daddy, but where is Daddy?

Never would Kit think, *Why did Daddy do this to me?* A child does not think in such ways, ascribing blame to an adult; over the weeks, months, years to follow, Kit would think, *What did I do that made Daddy abandon me?*

Not what you see with your eyes but what you are told you have seen.

Kit waited by the eighth-floor elevator for almost an hour, or so she was told later, though to the child paralyzed with fear this was an incalculable amount of time.

Petrified little girl, with a sickly pale face in need of washing. Snarled hair that Daddy had given up brushing, crookedly buttoned raincoat with ketchup stains. It would be noted that on this wet, cold March day, Kit was wearing flip-flops on her very grimy feet.

Kit's eyes were leaking moisture, her nose, too. She wasn't supposed to wipe her nose on her coat sleeve, but she didn't have a Kleenex. Just staring at the elevator door. So hard she stared, so badly wishing that Daddy would come back. Several times she was certain that she saw him in the midst of other passengers, and that he saw her, lifted his hand, waved, blew a kiss. Even as the elevator door shut again, bearing Daddy away.

Jostled by strangers. Exiting the elevator without seeing her, for they were looking over her head—Kit was so *small*.

But it was then, as she was waiting for Daddy by the elevator, that Kit's brain taught itself a trick of survival: yes, Kit was that silly-sad pathetic child, but she was also observing that child from just enough distance that she could feel her anguish the way one might hear a muffled cry in another room.

Excuse me, little girl? Are you waiting for someone? You've been here quite a while. . . . Hello?

A kindly, concerned woman in a nurse's uniform was bending down to Kit, who shrank away.

Not looking at the stranger's face. Trying not to cry. Trying not to gasp for breath, to sob in the way that so annoyed Daddy and made Mommy wince.

We just want to help you. We are not going to hurt you. If you could tell us . . .

But, no, Kit could not. Was not supposed to trust strangers. Nor did she know her last name—her father's name—he was just Daddy.

And soon a security guard joined the nurse. It appeared that the child was too young or too frightened or too confused to tell them her name. Or maybe this child was mentally slow? She could barely speak; nor did she seem to comprehend what she was being asked. Maybe she didn't speak English?

Hello? Hello? Do you speak English?

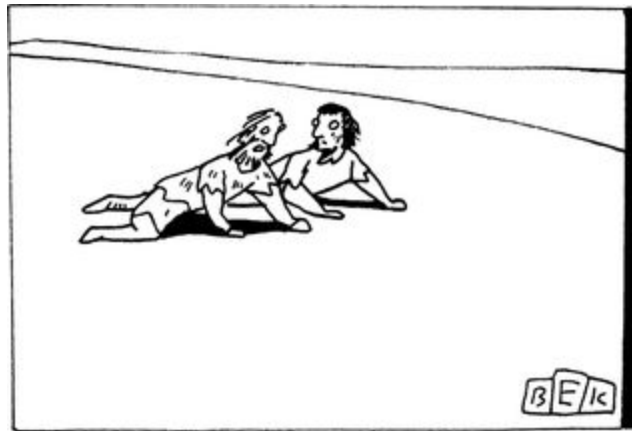
Didn't want to be lifted and carried in the woman's arms, no, she did *not*.

Walked hand in hand between the nurse woman and the security officer, who took her to the nurses' station on the eighth floor, asking if Kit was familiar to anyone there? No? Led along the corridor past patients' rooms, peering inside: *Excuse us, do you know this little girl?*

Kit wanted to hide her face in shame. Daddy would be so angry if he found out!

. . . waiting out by the elevators, all alone, so we think she must have wandered off, and her mother or father is here somewhere. No? Are you sure?

Security was checking downstairs. Visitors to the hospital had to sign in with I.D. The missing parent's name would be in the book.



*"I miss nineteen-eighties excess."
Cartoon by Bruce Eric Kaplan*

An alert was sounded through the hospital. *Attention, please! A little girl has been found on the eighth floor. Anyone who knows her, please report to Security, first floor. Attention, please!*

Repeatedly, the alert was sounded. No one came.

A female police officer insisted on taking Kit outside to a police cruiser to drive slowly through the parking garage, past rows of vehicles, asking Kit if any of the cars looked familiar. The garage was still partly swathed in a thin mist, so that seeing was not easy, and Kit was barely responsive, very tired, worn out from crying, grinding her teeth in resistance. She did not like this woman's loud, sharp voice, a remark the woman had made about Kit's face needing washing, the flip-flops on her bare feet. Clearly, this was a case of child neglect, possibly child abuse, a case for child-protective services, she had said. Kit would be taken into custody even if they found her parents. . . .

Suddenly, then, Kit did remember that her father had parked on the highest floor of the garage, but when the officer drove to that floor there were only a few cars remaining, and none looked familiar.

You're sure? You don't see his car? Hey? Are your eyes even open?

Kit never saw Daddy again. Not ever.

Nor Mommy, either. The woman she remembered, vaguely, as Mommy.

More than fifty years have passed. Katherine still isn't sure what happened, how they worked out who she was.

Shuts her eyes. Amnesia like drifting mist, fog.

What she does remember: that night, she was taken by police officers to a children's facility, and, the following afternoon, picked up by an aunt, an older half sister of Kit's mother whom Kit scarcely knew, did not recognize, who lived in another city, twenty miles away.

Just like that, it happened. *Whisked away.*

Daddy would have joked, Whisked away as quick as a whisker! Not to be confused with "whiskey."

(Certain that she'd heard her father make that joke. As well as: Between whiskey and nothing, I will take whiskey. But why was it funny?)

From that rainy, misty March night when she was taken away to live with an aunt, an anxious woman, who would never explain to Kit what had happened to her parents, except that her mother was no longer living and her father was "gone from their lives."

Growing up, Kit knew not to ask questions. Eventually, she forgot what questions she might have reasonably asked.

All the relatives Kit knew were her mother's relatives. Who never spoke of her mother, either, except to say that she had been a beautiful woman, she had loved Kit very much, she had died far too young. But Kit did learn that

her mother had been in the hospital that day, when her father disappeared; her father must have taken Kit there with the intention of having her visit her mother.

The flowers in the back seat were for Mommy, yes?

But that hadn't happened. . . .

Instead, he'd abandoned Kit on the eighth floor. He'd gone up to the eleventh floor, where her mother was, alone.

From what Kit's relatives did not tell her, Kit inferred that her mother had died in the hospital that day.

Obsessively, Kit turned over the details she knew, the way one might the beads of a rosary: a death in the hospital, a missing father, an abandoned little girl waiting by an elevator. All this had happened, yet it had happened outside Kit's comprehension.

One thing she knows: she is not the story. There is a story. But she is not the story.

Surrounded by silence, like cotton batting, Kit grew up as an awkward stepdaughter-niece to her aunt, who had no children of her own, had never married, a highly educated woman who'd made her way in a male-dominated field, corporate tax law.

Kit, who became Kathy in high school and college, and, in graduate school and beyond, Katherine.

But still, she says, she is Kit.

Still waiting by the elevator.

Of course, she looked for answers. Not systematically but haphazardly, secretly. Telling no one, no lover, no husband, no close friend.

Each year, in March, as the anniversary approaches, a sensation of mounting dread. Each year, mounting anxiety, as if every nerve in her body

were being pulled tighter, tighter—nearing the breaking point. Panicked neurons firing.

Lying awake for hours and, when at last she falls asleep, such strange dreams! In which she is not exactly a child but *child-size*, with adults looming above her.

Sometimes she is in the parking garage climbing the concrete steps, short of breath. Tugged by a disembodied hand. Thin swathes of mist surrounding her. Bare feet in flip-flops, so cold.

Sometimes she is in her father's car, ravenously hungry, but her fingers are too stiff to hold on to a French fry, which falls between the seats; in the driver's seat, behind the wheel, a hulking person with a face that resembles rough-textured canvas, with just indentations for eyes, mouth, nose—not quite a human face. . . . *Daddy? Daddy!*

Sometimes she is inside the hospital, waiting by the elevator, staring and staring, unable to look away, for if she dares to look away it might be in that fleeting instant that the door will open, and Daddy will appear, and, if Kit does not do something to make Daddy see her, the door will close again, and the elevator will bear him away.

The sensation of urgency is so strong that Katherine feels a sharp tingling along her spine, in the pit of her belly, a sudden need to urinate, which wakes her, and a sense of sexual desire, a tension that leaves her gasping for breath, soaked in sweat.

Don't go away! Don't leave me! Daddy!

All of her relatives Katherine has approached at one time or another, begging them to tell her what they know about what happened that day at the hospital; the younger relatives, Katherine's age, are more open with her but are uncertain of the facts.

He'd gone to take her home with him—your father.

Your mother had had surgery. Probably some kind of cancer surgery.

She wasn't doing well, I think.

*He'd gone to take her home, or maybe he'd gone to smother her in her bed.
Unhook machines. Because she was unconscious.*

*Because he was cruel, crazy. Because he'd hurt her—that was why she was
hospitalized.*

Because he did kill her. She died that day.

He'd gone to kill her. That was his plan.

By the time they discovered her body, he had got away.

They found flowers. Never found him.

Clay pot, broken on the floor.

Of course he forgot you. He'd come for her. Not you.

Katherine's voice breaks. She can't continue. It is too raw, too painful—the child waiting by the elevator all these years, until finally it became impossible for her to wait alone, and this morning, made impulsive by sheer need, she called me.

Like Katherine, I am exhausted. I rise from my chair as Katherine stumbles to her feet, as if to flee the restaurant to spare me further embarrassment, but I have hold of her, I am holding her, the sparrow bones so light, the reddened eyes, my arms are holding Katherine upright and steady, and to those strangers who have been watching us covertly I say, What are you staring at? This is none of your business. I am comforting my friend. ♦
[Joyce Carol Oates](#) won the 2024 Raymond Chandler Award. Her books include the story collection "[The Frenzy](#)."

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Is Zionism's Moral Crisis About Roads Not Taken—or Original Sin?

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By [Isaac Chotiner](#)

September 13, 2026



A ship named for the founder of political Zionism brings Jewish immigrants to the Port of Haifa, in 1948. According to Moser, Zionism and Nazism were ideologically congenial, but his argument relies on distortions and elementary factual errors. Photograph by Robert Capa / ICP / Magnum

The greatest cognitive dissonance in the debate over Gaza concerned the fate of the hostages taken by Hamas on October 7, 2023. Many Jewish Americans fervently believed that the conflict had to continue until every last hostage was freed. As Israel systematically destroyed Gaza without achieving Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's stated goal of eliminating

Hamas, the hostages' gruesome ordeal became one of the last rhetorical weapons available to the war's American proponents.

The debate in Israel was different. Broadly speaking, those who wanted to continue the war also considered the fate of the hostages less important than collectively punishing Palestinians. Polls showed that a majority of Israelis—though mostly undisturbed by a war in which children were starved to death—understood that Netanyahu was prolonging the conflict to preserve his far-right coalition and that hostages were most likely to be freed through a ceasefire. So, while American Jews posted pictures in their neighborhoods of hostages, one of Netanyahu's closest media allies, the anchor [Yinon Magal](#), regularly mocked their families' grief, portraying them as weak-kneed appeasers willing to pause the war to get their loved ones back.

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The idea that many American Jews were naïve or uninformed about a society to which they felt strongly connected was among the topics Benjamin Moser, the Pulitzer Prize-winning biographer of Susan Sontag, explored last year in [a long essay for *Equator*](#). Moser was born in 1976 and raised in a relatively secular Jewish home in Houston. For the Jews he grew up with, he wrote, “Israel was like a hospital or a university or a park, and I think that most Jewish-Americans looked at Israel with the same kind of benevolence with which they might view a dog shelter or a food bank: which is to say that they were happy it existed, willing to help, grateful for a brief tour, but not overly interested in its inner workings.” (I remember my grandmother’s shocked dismay when I sent her something I had written about the attack that Israel, alongside Britain and France, launched against Egypt in 1956. She believed the oft-repeated claim that Israel had fought only defensive wars and never investigated whether it was true.)

This naïveté helped explain why, as late as October, 2025, when a rickety ceasefire began and the last living hostages returned, polls showed that about half of American Jews supported a conflict some of Israel's own human-rights organizations had labelled a genocide. Meanwhile, many American Jews who had once defended free expression welcomed crackdowns on pro-Palestinian speech. The conflict, Moser wrote, "stripped the pretence of liberalism, of tolerance, to which the American Jewish leadership had, for generations, paid such pious lip service."

His essay was angry, especially at liberal Zionists. He was troubled by the exceptionalist ideas that even secular American Jews had developed about their community after the Second World War. "We really did think, in some way that we would never have dared to articulate, that Jews were better," he wrote. In his telling, this superiority eventually allowed American Jews to accommodate the United States' "imperial power structure." And, if "the marriage of American exceptionalism and liberal Zionism led to genocide," reform was inadequate; Zionism itself had to be abandoned.

Moser's new book, "[Anti-Zionism: A Jewish History](#)" (Doubleday), reminds Jewish Americans that another tradition is available, one that opposes Israel's existence rather than merely seeks to curb its worst impulses. Anti-Zionists now generally hold that Israelis and Palestinians should coexist in one binational state. Though many people find this radical, it shouldn't be controversial to say that everyone living under Israeli control between the Jordan River and the Mediterranean Sea deserves equal rights. But Moser does not detail what a future resolution might entail; he argues instead that anti-Zionism offers a way out of the moral abyss to which Zionism has led.

A rich intellectual history could be written about Jewish anti-Zionist thought, tracing its competing ideas about nationalism and diaspora. Moser has something else in mind: a series of inspirational portraits framed by autobiography. "Anti-Zionism" opens with brief reflections on his own upbringing and on Theodor Herzl, the Austro-Hungarian journalist and playwright who founded modern political Zionism, publishing a seminal manifesto in 1896. Moser's book then devotes a chapter each to twelve Jewish anti-Zionists. His gallery ranges from early-twentieth-century critics

of Zionism, such as the rabbi Aaron Samuel Tamares, to contemporary activists, like the South African politician Ronnie Kasrils and the photographer Nan Goldin.

How similar were those who opposed the notion of Israel when its creation seemed a remote possibility to those who opposed and continue to oppose its functioning as a Jewish state from 1948 onward? What connects Tamares, born in the Pale of Settlement in 1869, and Goldin, who campaigns against a nuclear-armed state backed by the world's most powerful country? The book's implicit answer is that both recognized the danger of fusing religion with nationalism, and of seeking Jewish sovereignty over a land already inhabited by non-Jews.



"Umm, I'll stick to cold brew."
Cartoon by Avi Steinberg

An entirely sympathetic figure in Moser's gallery is Edwin Montagu, one of the first Jews to serve in the British Cabinet and perhaps the British Empire's most liberal Secretary of State for India. Montagu came from a prominent Jewish family and, like many British Jews of the era, saw no need for a Jewish homeland in Palestine or anywhere else. On this question, he disagreed strongly with Arthur Balfour, a former British Prime Minister who, as Foreign Secretary, was responsible for the Balfour Declaration of 1917, which promised British support for a "national home" for Jews in Palestine. (It also stated that "nothing shall be done which may prejudice the civil and religious rights of existing non-Jewish communities in Palestine.")

The section on Montagu and the Balfour Declaration makes one of Moser's central arguments especially clear—namely, that prewar European nationalism and Zionism held a deep affinity because both envisioned Jews leaving the Continent. Balfour, whose government passed the Aliens Act, in 1905, to stem Jewish immigration from Eastern Europe, seems to have had a streak of antisemitism himself. Montagu, by contrast, launched elegant broadsides against the government and the Zionist movement in general. These showed his concern for the Muslim and Christian peoples of Palestine, as well as his fear of what would happen to the Jewish people if they formed a state. (They would “hereafter be treated as foreigners in every country but Palestine.”)

“Montagu's insistence on his Englishness,” Moser writes, was “something beyond patriotism or nationalism—beyond the refusal of a racialization that Hitler shared with Herzl, and that could only be repellent to any self-respecting person.” The pairing of Hitler and Herzl is, by design, startling, but Moser's position is that both treated Jews as a people apart, even though Herzl sought a homeland for those whom Hitler would seek to destroy.

Some later Zionists had more direct affinities with the European right. Revisionist Zionism, which emerged after Herzl's death, in 1904, was fiercely anti-socialist, and some of its adherents admired aspects of fascism. Moser emphasizes episodes in which Zionists and right-wing European nationalists found it useful to deal with each other. That history has a contemporary echo in the close alliance between the current Israeli government (Netanyahu's Likud Party is the modern successor to the Revisionists) and right-wing European leaders such as Hungary's Viktor Orbán, at least until [Orbán's defeat earlier this year](#). Netanyahu and Orbán shared a hostility to liberal élites, refugees, and Muslims generally, which evidently explained why the antisemitic overtones of Orbán's anti-Soros campaigns never seemed to bother the Israeli government very much.

One much discussed example of such dealings came after the Nazis gained power, in 1933. Some Zionists were convinced that the resulting persecution might encourage Jews to move to Palestine, then under British rule. That year, the Nazi government and Zionist leaders in Germany and Palestine negotiated the Haavara Agreement, which eventually enabled at

least fifty thousand German Jews to immigrate to Palestine and to transfer a portion of their assets. The arrangement served both parties' immediate purposes, as the Israeli historian Tom Segev observed. The Nazis removed Jews from the country and sabotaged a boycott of Germany launched mostly by American Jewish groups; the Zionist movement drew settlers who might otherwise have gone elsewhere. "Only slowly did it become clear that they owed their very lives to the agreement, as well," Segev noted.

How did Zionism become a movement that could accommodate such compromises? How did it come to attract so many adherents? For a people whose safety had repeatedly proved provisional, Zionism held out the promise of refuge—a promise that acquired new force after the Nazis murdered two-thirds of Europe's Jews. Moser acknowledges this history, but it rarely enters into his account of the movement. Indeed, as his character studies accumulate, Zionism itself remains oddly indistinct. He provides no sustained critique of its animating ideas, a peculiar omission in a book celebrating those who have challenged them, often at a real cost. In his section on Herzl, Moser offers a string of dismissals, calling him a "bad writer," someone with "the mind of the petty attorney," "thoughtless, as in without thought," and "childish," but fails to ask what made his vision persuasive. Even Herzl's treatment of the Dreyfus Affair—he covered the trial and later emphasized Dreyfus's Jewishness to argue for Zionism—is presented solely as Herzl's attempt to seize "power and glory." Moser is under no obligation to find Herzl sympathetic, but it's striking that he shows so little curiosity about Herzl's arguments, or about the competing, even contradictory forms that Zionism took.

"In a brilliant sleight of hand, these early Zionists found an enemy in their own parents," Moser writes in his section on Tamares. "Their idea of Zionism was modern, not because it was Jewish but because it was European. Judaism was backward; rank-and-file Zionists, the Sensitive Rabbi found, were 'enamored of "Europeanism" in general and the title "Doctor" in particular.' " The passage might have opened onto Zionism's complicated relationship with Europeanism, the way it borrowed from European nationalism while seeking to escape European antisemitism. Instead, Moser appears to view the younger Zionists' contempt for their

religious and conservative elders as discrediting, an odd line for a twenty-first-century progressive to take.

Moser eventually turns his gaze to Hannah Arendt, who [reported for this magazine](#) on the 1961 trial of Adolf Eichmann, and whose harsh criticism of the Israeli state's handling of the case earns Moser's admiration.

Although recent scholarship has suggested that Eichmann was a passionate antisemite rather than the unthinking drone of Arendt's account, as captured in her phrase "the banality of evil," Moser takes little interest in such debates. What catches his attention is Eichmann's brief visit to Palestine, in 1937, part of a mission to assess it as a place to send German Jews. This gives Moser a way into his more explosive thesis: that Zionism and Nazism shared "an ideological sympathy that bled into collaboration."

Moser presents this thesis as a buried truth, absent from the "fairy tale" history he learned growing up and from mainstream accounts. But he has merely inverted the triumphalist exceptionalism of his childhood. In his essay in *Equator*, he said he had been raised to believe that Jews were uniquely virtuous, in part because of the "responsibility" imposed on survivors by the Holocaust; in his book's counter-history, Zionist Jews become so uniquely sinful that they rescued the Nazi regime from collapse. To sustain that inversion, the book increasingly relies on distortions and elementary factual errors.

Earlier episodes depict Zionist leaders dealing with European antisemites when their immediate interests converged. The historian Richard Evans called the Haavara Agreement "a marriage of convenience." Moser sees something more. He tells us that, in "Mein Kampf," Hitler wrote "of 'a great movement called Zionism,' " and that, when he took over, Zionists "rushed to become privileged interlocutors with the regime." (The German word translated here as "great," *große*, refers to the movement's scale, not its virtues.) In sentences Moser ignores, though, Hitler portrays Zionism as another Jewish deception: "To outward appearances it seemed as if only one group of Jews championed this movement, while the great majority disapproved of it, or even repudiated it. But an investigation of the situation showed that those outward appearances were purposely misleading. . . . When the Zionists try to make the rest of the world believe that the new

national consciousness of the Jews will be satisfied by the establishment of a Jewish State in Palestine, the Jews thereby adopt another means to dupe the simple-minded Gentile.” In other words, Jews were only pretending to be arguing about Zionism; in fact, they planned to use Palestine as a headquarters to rule the world. (The notion that Nazis supported Zionism is a long-standing antisemitic trope.)

Several pages later, in trying to argue that Zionists were sympathetic to Nazi ideas, Moser quotes from what he describes as “the introduction” to the Nazis’ antisemitic Nuremberg Laws: “The ardent Zionists of all people have objected least to the basic ideas of the Nuremberg Laws, because they know that these laws are the only correct solution for the Jewish people.” Here, he sees a “recognition,” on the part of the Nazis, “that many Zionists endorsed their principles.” But the Nuremberg Laws did not include an introduction. The words Moser reproduces appeared in a Nazi journal two months after the laws were announced. A book he cites by the historian Francis Nicosia tells us that the author of the journal piece argued the position for propaganda purposes.

Moser has an unfortunate tendency to misrepresent the authorities he enlists. That’s on display in his discussion of the Haavara Agreement. He quotes the historian Hava Eshkoli-Wagman as writing that the agreement’s biggest proponents “did not see the saving of lives as an independent goal at that time, rather they sought to extract German Jewish property for the benefit of the Yishuv”—the Jews in Palestine before 1948. But she didn’t write that sentence; she was quoting it as a “widely held criticism” that she goes on to complicate. (To “extract German Jewish property” meant extracting Jewish assets from Nazi Germany, not extorting them from German Jews.) Elsewhere in the same discussion, Eshkoli-Wagman described Haavara as, in part, an attempt to prevent the forced sales of Jewish property, and wrote that this stance, which gave precedence to building a homeland in Palestine over preserving Jewish civil rights in the diaspora, “cannot be attributed to selfish motives.” Moser, with no patience for complexity, supplies his own gloss: “It was, in other words, a shakedown.” Eshkoli-Wagman said nothing of the kind. “The allegations of Zionist-Nazi cooperation in the 1930s,” she concluded, “fail to meet the criteria of responsible historical research and analysis.”

In the same section of the book, Moser tells us that, “in 1938, the Zionists therefore blocked a plan to bring twenty thousand Jewish children to the United States,” without citing a source for the claim. The apparent reference is to the Wagner-Rogers Bill, introduced in Congress in 1939, which would have admitted twenty thousand refugee children from Nazi-controlled Germany. As it happens, Rabbi Stephen Wise, perhaps the most prominent Zionist leader in the United States, testified in its favor; the bill died in committee after a North Carolina restrictionist sabotaged it. Some of Moser’s errors, including misdescriptions of well-known events, seem merely slipshod: amid the Suez machinations, Israel never “seized the canal.”

More often, even Moser’s mundane mistakes suggest a pattern—an eagerness to endorse whatever claims he thinks will strengthen his case. And so he wants to argue that the Jewish-led boycott of Nazi Germany, which began in 1933, was close to bringing down the Third Reich until the boycott was sabotaged by Zionists. It’s an arresting suggestion. Did Zionists really rescue the Third Reich? According to Moser, German exports fell by fifty-one per cent in the first half of 1933 alone, leading the regime to the “verge of collapse.” Here, he’s quoting statistics that he credits to Tony Greenstein, who, yes, has also used the phrase “verge of collapse.” (Greenstein, a British polemicist and Jewish anti-Zionist, was recently expelled from the Green Party; he suggested that the expulsion was at the behest of the Israeli Embassy.) But Greenstein’s own source is a book by Edwin Black, and it turns out that Greenstein confused a shift in Germany’s trade surplus with a shift in export volume. The actual decline in exports was far *lower* than it had been in the previous two years, before the Nazis took power and thus before the boycott. Moser, drawn to the implication that Zionism saved Nazism, makes claims that no serious historian would support.

It’s when Moser touches on the Nazis’ victims that his approach to the facts truly emerges as slovenly to the point of reckless. “There was abundant proof of the way the Zionist press laundered the stories of atrocities emerging from Europe,” Moser writes. “ ‘Jewish culture flourishing in the Warsaw Ghetto with 24 bookstores and libraries,’ Ben-Gurion’s newspaper, *Davar*, reported on October 16, 1942.” Moser is correct that an article

published in *Davar* on that date included these words. But it was the type of story—one that you might hope to read about Gaza today—that aimed to show the resilience of people living under hellish circumstances. “The name ‘prison’ is too soft to suggest what this is,” the author wrote in the same piece. “The Warsaw Ghetto is more like an animal enclosure that is right by the slaughterhouse in which you hold the cows until they are ready to be killed. But they don’t torture the cows the way they torture Jews in the ghetto.” The article ends as follows: “Their spirit is still with them in the face of the destruction that the enemy is perpetrating. This shows that there is still a will to live. The enemy cannot hurt their soul.” This, according to Moser, was “laundering” Nazi atrocities.

And so it goes. “In the newspaper *Jüdische Rundschau*, the Zionists had endorsed the yellow star that publicly stamped Jews with a badge of medieval pariahdom—eight years before the yellow star became compulsory,” Moser writes. A 1933 article in the newspaper did address the yellow star. The piece was written by Robert Weltsch, the paper’s editor. In response to a Nazi boycott of Jewish businesses and the painting of yellow stars and anti-Jewish slogans on the storefronts themselves, Weltsch wrote, “A powerful symbol is to be found in the fact that the boycott leadership gave orders that a sign ‘with a yellow badge on a black background’ was to be pasted on the boycotted shops. This regulation is intended as a brand, a sign of contempt. We will take it up and make of it a badge of honor.” To characterize this as an “endorsement” of Nazi antisemitism is grotesque. (Weltsch—whom Moser codes as “the Zionists”—was an ardent proponent of a binational state in Palestine.)



“What if I want to live my one wild and precious life and also stay on top of e-mail?”
Cartoon by Kendra Allenby

As the book progresses, Moser increasingly uses the phrase “the Zionists” without bothering to specify which Zionists he means, or even what country they are in. That’s a problem because his story jumps from Germany to the United Kingdom to the United States to Palestine, places where Zionists faced different political circumstances and often pursued conflicting ends. The phrase is not inherently offensive; Zionism is a political idea, and those who identify themselves with it should be prepared for criticism. But Moser presents himself as someone trying to delineate complex historical phenomena for his readers. By turning Zionism into an ideological essence detached from its historical context, he fails to do so.

Moser’s biggest failure, though, may be his inability to escape the very solipsism that he denounced in his *Equator* essay, titled “We Have Talked Enough About Ourselves,” and that he again identifies as a distinctively Jewish predilection in his book. “More than anything,” he writes, he hopes that the next generation of activists “will shed the solipsism that has ever been a fault of the Jews.” After recounting that he grew up thinking that Zionism was a “unanimity,” he asks, “How would my life have been changed if I had known that it was not?” The question, though it might be better addressed to a therapist than to a reader, is somehow fitting in a book that ends by quoting the author’s own text messages. Moser tells us, in his introduction, that he felt “duped” by what he’d learned as a child and set out to discover the truth. The charitable explanation for his distortions is that, in the course of vacuuming up material for the book, he was duped a second time.

Thirty years ago, in *The New Republic*, the historian Omer Bartov reviewed Daniel Jonah Goldhagen’s [“Hitler’s Willing Executioners,”](#) a book that may have spawned more academic debate about the Holocaust than anything since Arendt’s dispatches from the Eichmann trial. Goldhagen argued that antisemitism had been deeply embedded among ordinary Germans even before Hitler’s rise, allowing the Nazis to quickly mobilize a citizenry primed to act out its “eliminationist” fantasies about the Jews. Bartov—who was born in Israel, served in the Israel Defense Forces during the Yom Kippur War, in 1973, and later wrote a series of important studies of the

Holocaust—methodically dismantled Goldhagen’s thesis. “The most troubling aspect of Goldhagen’s book is its contention that ‘ordinary’ Germans belonged to a wholly extraordinary people, a people unlike any other, which had been that way for the better part of a century,” he wrote. “Like all essentialist views it does not require evidence; it is inimical to strictly historical analysis.” He continued: “And what are the implications of such a notion that there exists a nation of ingrained murderers? How useful is this assumption for explaining an historical phenomenon?”

Three decades later, Bartov again shows why we should resist an account of mass violence as the expression of an immutable national character. This time, the nation is his own. In his important new book, “[Israel: What Went Wrong?](#)” (Farrar, Straus & Giroux), Bartov expands on his argument, which he laid out in the *Times* last year, that Israel’s war was genocidal; he also seems intent on combatting what might be called the Goldhagen Thesis as applied to Israel. Gaza’s ruin, the apartheid in the West Bank, and the ascendancy of Israel’s far right are, in his account, the products of political choices rather than of predestination. Where Moser wants to replace a largely comforting story with an entirely damning one, Bartov refuses exculpation while remaining attentive to contingency.

“The focus on Zionism as state ideology,” Bartov writes, meant that, “in the competition between being Jewish and being democratic, the state tilted increasingly toward the former, first in the sense of being a state strictly for Jews, and then in becoming an ever more Jewish state.” Yet “this was a long process and never an inevitable one,” he cautions. “There were many forks in the road where the country could have chosen to go one way and not the other.” One revealing fork concerned Israel’s borders. Bartov explains why the country’s declaration of independence left them undefined, a result of cynical political manipulation compounded by bureaucratic confusion.

But Bartov doesn’t lose sight of Zionism’s principal failure: from Herzl’s time onward, the movement’s dominant currents never seriously reckoned with the Arabs already living in Palestine. He sees a continuity between what he calls the “colonial views” of pre-state Zionism—epitomized in the infamous phrase “a land without a people for a people without a land”—and the “settler colonialism” Israel has practiced since 1948. “Having undone

two millennia of exile, Israel never managed to normalize Jewish existence, as Zionism so wished,” he writes. “Having sought to become a Jewish majority state at any price, it paid the price of creating a vast Palestinian refugee problem that it still refuses to address.” While rejecting the idea that Israel’s path was predetermined, Bartov wants us to see that some of the thinking behind the slaughter in Gaza was present from the start of the Zionist project.

Like Moser, Bartov is invested in the American debate over Israel, for political as well as personal reasons. He, too, was dismayed by the Biden Administration’s backing of Netanyahu’s government, and by much of the American Jewish community’s response to the war, and he urges American Jews to adopt a definition of antisemitism narrow enough to leave room for vigorous criticism of Israel. His preferred political settlement is a confederation of Israel and Palestine, which would allow freedom of movement between sovereign states. Yet he sees little prospect that the current Israeli government, or any government that Israelis are likely to elect soon, will change its course toward the Palestinians. Whatever hope he retains lies in the possibility of pressure from the rest of the world, including the United States.

Bartov’s appeal to American power suggests that, for American Jews, the moral weight should fall on the adjective “American.” Moser remains preoccupied with the noun, filtering Jewish history through his own family history. Early in his book, he refers to his co-religionists who were “horrified that Jews could be associated with such an evil.” Later, in his chapter on Tamares, Moser writes, “The Jews’ status as ‘the chosen people’ had benefits, but it also had responsibilities.” That chosenness, Tamares warned, gave the Jewish people a “special capacity to befoul the ethical atmosphere more than any other nation.” Even if this is the best kind of chauvinism, it is chauvinism all the same.

Palestinian suffering deserves to be understood on its own terms, without being subsumed into a narrative of Jewish psychodrama. Many American Jews, especially younger ones, simply do not want their government aiding and arming a country that behaves like an outlaw nation—the one we live in is enough, thank you—and recognize that many non-Jewish Americans

share their revulsion. As Bartov makes clear, Gaza's destruction followed from political choices, including choices made in Washington. Instead of asking what this destruction means for American Jews, we should ask how America helped make it possible. ♦

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The Wealthiest—and Stealthiest—Class in America

America’s everywhere millionaires built fortunes from hot dogs, car dealerships, medical practices, and convenience stores. Then they learned how to protect them.

By [John Lanchester](#)

September 14, 2026



We’re obsessed with billionaires, but the owners of Main Street businesses are, collectively, an order of magnitude richer than the Forbes 400. Illustration by Joanne Joo

Billionaires have never been more central to the cultural and political conversation, more impressed with themselves, or more consumed with a sense of their own victimhood. From “Billions” and “Succession” to the latest social-media spasms of Musk or Ackman or Arnault, billionaires offer a grim and garish spectacle from which it’s hard to look away, and, let’s admit it, we often don’t. That’s understandable: there are more of them, and they’re richer than ever. In 2025, to get onto the *Forbes* list of the top four

hundred American billionaires, you needed a cool \$3.8 billion. The average wealth of that group was \$16.5 billion, and their collective net worth was \$6.6 trillion. There were another five hundred American billionaires who didn't even make the list.

This is an unprecedented concentration of wealth and power among the super-rich. When we talk about wealth, we mainly talk about billionaires. But what if that's not the most important truth about wealth in America? What if there were another group that, without drawing much attention, had grown collectively thirteen times richer than the *Forbes* 400? And that was even more effective at using its financial-political clout? And what if a typical member of that class looked less like Logan Roy and more like this:

He tells them, when they buy a Toyota, they're turning their dollars into yen. And they believe him. A hundred twelve units new and used moved in the first five months of 1979, with eight Corollas, five Coronas including a Luxury Edition Wagon, and that Celica that Charlie said looked like a Pimpmobile unloaded in these first three weeks of June already, at an average gross mark-up of eight hundred dollars per sale. Rabbit is rich.

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It was percipient of John Updike to latch on to the car dealership as the foundation of Harry (Rabbit) Angstrom's Everyman prosperity in his tetralogy of novels. As Owen Zidar and Eric Zwick show in their brilliant new study, "The Everywhere Millionaire: Who Is Really Rich in America and How They Got There" (Holt), the car dealer—Rabbit, or Buddy Garrity in "Friday Night Lights," or Daniel LaRusso, the grownup Karate Kid, in "Cobra Kai"—is a true archetype of American wealth. Car dealer, beer-

distribution magnate, partner in a medical practice or a law firm: these ordinary, ubiquitous business owners represent a collective prosperity at least as consequential as the ascendancy of the billionaire, only much less conspicuous. “In a sense,” Zidar and Zwick argue, “Main Street Millionaires are hiding in plain sight. The supermarket where you shop, the restaurant where you order a burger, and the convenience store where you buy gas, newspapers, and coffee may all be parts of huge chains that have made their founders very rich.”

Zidar and Zwick got onto this story through their work for the Treasury at the Office of Tax Analysis, which studies the impact of tax legislation, actual and prospective. The two young economists, from Berkeley and Harvard, respectively, were assigned the task of finding out how much tax business owners pay. That might sound straightforward—might, indeed, sound like the kind of thing the government should already know—but the tax code is complicated, and the I.R.S.’s various databases are thoroughly siloed and anonymized. To answer the question, they and another colleague set about finding who owned businesses, connecting those business records with individual taxpayers. It was a complicated process involving years of work, and they more than earned the endearingly nerdy, self-appointed nickname the Tax Ninjas. They discovered what comes close to being a new class in America, the “everywhere millionaire” of their title. There are a lot of them: nearly five million households with a net worth of at least five million dollars; more than two million decamillionaires, worth at least ten million; and around sixty-five thousand centimillionaires, worth a hundred million and up. The sheer mass of these numbers means that, in Zidar and Zwick’s words, in contemporary America, for all the fuss around billionaires, “these are the real rich.”

For an explanation of how they got that way, we need a brief detour into the tax code. The modern federal income tax, authorized by a constitutional amendment in 1913, began with a top rate of seven per cent and was dramatically expanded to help finance the First World War. Its top rate later rose from twenty-five per cent, in 1925, to ninety-four per cent, during the Second World War. Corporation tax, introduced in 1909, followed a similar trajectory, peaking at fifty-three per cent in 1968. By the time Ronald

Reagan became President, in 1981, the top rates of income and corporation tax stood at seventy and forty-six per cent, respectively.

Republicans in Congress wanted to cut taxes, and Democrats wanted to simplify the tax code. The outcome was the bipartisan Tax Reform Act of 1986, which did both. In the process, the bill introduced a novelty in American history by leaving the top rate of corporation tax, thirty-four per cent, higher than the top rate of federal income tax, twenty-eight per cent. At the same time, the bill boosted the allure of a special-enterprise category: the “pass-through,” in which a business passes its net income through to the tax returns of individual owners, who pay the lower individual rate of tax, rather than the higher corporate rate, while avoiding dividend taxes. One bookkeeping expert quoted by Zidar and Zwick calls owning a small business “the best tax deal in America.”

That is who the everywhere millionaires are: owners of pass-through businesses. These businesses are everywhere, and they do pretty much everything. Our image of wealth skews glamorous and coastal. These businesses and their owners don't. Some of the firms are well known, part of the familiar roadside furniture of American life—Buc-ee's, Bass Pro Shops. There are many, many more, and the catalogue of what they do and where they do it is a Whitmanian portrait of capitalism: the “world's largest mozzarella maker,” Texas's largest supplier of seamless gutters, “the biggest in the world in the high-end skiwear market,” gas-and-convenience-megastore tycoons, a “massive family-owned supplier of door handles,” “a company that just stored documents for medical and financial firms,” makers of car parts, bakers of hamburger buns, distributors of toilet paper, a tanning-bed mogul who pivoted to waxing when she realized that tanning was going out of fashion.

As for what the people who own these businesses are like, Zidar and Zwick give both a statistical summary and individual portraits. Statistically, the mean pass-through decamillionaire is a white, college-educated, sixty-two-year-old man—older than one might expect, because these businesses take a while to build. (He's also unusually likely to be married: the average for the general population is around fifty per cent, but among this cohort it is ninety.) We all know people who are laid-back, curious about lots of

different things, and have a good work-life balance. These small-business owners are not like that. They tend toward monomania. Their days are, in Zidar and Zwick's words, "full, busy, and mundane." They usually own only one business, and they dedicate themselves to it unrelentingly, with few outside interests or hobbies, a high tolerance for risk, and little appetite for work-life balance. (Rabbit Angstrom wasn't like that, but Rabbit Angstrom didn't stay rich.)

The portraits in "The Everywhere Millionaire" are vivid. In 1976, Nancy Mueller's young children were enrolled in school in California, and she was on her way to play tennis when she stopped and asked herself where she wanted to be in a decade: to be better at tennis, or to be doing something else? "I wanted to have something to show for the next ten years," she recalled. "I wanted to make it count." She went into business making frozen miniature quiches, "leasing space from a dilapidated empanada factory that was vacant while the owner served time in jail." Mueller adapted a washing machine to take water out of spinach and had her production equipment improved by an aerospace engineer who had left the industry in protest of the Vietnam War; soon, she was making a hundred thousand mini quiches a day. What she wasn't making yet was profit—"you're shipping dollar bills with every case of quiche," her accountant father told her. Her big break came in 1983, when Price Club placed a large order, followed by other warehouse stores. By the late nineteen-nineties, she had an eighty-six-thousand-square-foot production facility and was making fifty million dollars in sales, seemingly undeterred by the tragic loss of her husband to suicide in 1994. At one point, she said, the business earned an eighteen-percent pre-tax profit margin. Worried that the warehouse stores would suddenly drop her products one day, as they are known to do, she sold the business to a leveraged-buyout firm in 1999 and retired, in Zidar and Zwick's words, to "sail off into the sunset," aboard her superyacht, the *Andiamo*.

A different energy attaches to the story of another pass-through business owner, Dick Portillo. He grew up poor, in a rough Chicago housing project, and joined the Marines in 1957, seven days after graduating from high school. He liked fighting. On his first date with his future wife, "he took her to a lake but told her that he had to participate in a rumble there." In 1963,

with a family to support, exhausted and injured from manual labor, he decided, “I had to figure something out. I had to create a future for us.” Portillo thought he had spotted something: Chicago was famous for hot dogs, but its suburbs were short of places to buy them. He opened his first hot-dog stand in a discount-store parking lot in a homemade six-by-twelve trailer.

Many adventures later, Portillo sold his business to private equity, his chain of thirty-eight restaurants and two commissaries valued at a cool billion. (He came to regret it. Portillo was bored by retirement.) The valuation reflected an astonishing fact: where a successful McDonald’s could have a turnover of three million dollars a year, a Portillo’s could turn over nine million. We get a glimpse of how Portillo’s got so successful in the story of how he fended off competition from a rival, Ditka Dogs, set up by the beloved local figure Mike Ditka, the head coach of the Chicago Bears. According to Portillo, Ditka’s team had poached one of his managers. A few days before the restaurant was due to open, Portillo invited the manager to see him. “I told him that he did what every man, every leader of the house, every bread-winner would do.” Portillo began taking money out of his pockets and putting it on the table in front of him. “There was about \$12,000 on the table now. I told him it was all his if he did one more thing.” Ditka’s new restaurant was opening on Saturday. The “one more thing”—in addition to coming back to Portillo’s for higher pay and convincing the other employees who had been hired away to do the same—was to quit on Friday. “Portillo attended the grand opening and sat with a cup of coffee to watch the mess unfold.” The reason you’ve never been to a branch of Ditka Dogs is that the company no longer exists. The name of Portillo’s yacht? Top Dog.

The common thread in “The Everywhere Millionaire” is not dazzling innovation. Anyone might have thought to make a fortune from quiche, or hot dogs, or human-resource management, or office supplies, or convenience stores, or gas stations. The secret ingredient is no secret: it’s the sheer remorselessness, ingenuity, and resilience of the business owners.

If that were all there was to the everywhere-millionaire story, we could celebrate it as an example of how non-crony capitalism is supposed to

work, a meritocratic free-for-all. Unfortunately, there is a shadow side. As Zidar and Zwick argue, their protagonists, for all their virtues, are also “central characters in the saga of rising inequality.” Between 1980 and 2024, the share of national income going to American workers is estimated to have declined from sixty-five per cent to fifty-six per cent, meaning that “nine cents of every dollar that a firm creates that used to go to workers now goes to firm owners.” There have been increases in productivity, remarkable ones. The authors, surveying “top-owned firms,” report a recent rise in labor productivity from thirty-four thousand dollars a year to fifty-two thousand dollars a year. If the annual proceeds had been shared equally, that eighteen-thousand-dollar increase would have meant nine thousand dollars each. Instead, fifteen thousand dollars has gone to owners and three thousand dollars to workers. The so-called Gilded Age and the years following saw huge income disparities; in the early twentieth century, the highest-earning one per cent of households earned eighteen per cent of all income, and the bottom ninety per cent earned sixty per cent. The equivalent numbers in 2022 are worse: twenty per cent and around fifty per cent.

Social mobility has also declined. Poor children born in 1940 had about a ninety per cent chance of earning more than their parents. The chance for those children born in 1980 was closer to seventy per cent. According to a 2014 analysis, the chance of moving from the bottom fifth to the top fifth of earners was 7.5 per cent. Turn this around, and it means that if you were born in that bottom fifth, you could be 92.5 per cent sure that you wouldn’t get to the top fifth. “The chance of making it to the top as a poor kid in the twenty-first century is about half of what it was at the beginning of the twentieth,” Zidar and Zwick write. That means that the richest and most powerful country in the world has seen a dramatic and dispiriting decline in opportunity for the less well off.

The link between inequality and the everywhere millionaire runs through politics. Entrepreneurship is important for upward economic mobility: nine per cent of those who made the transition from the bottom fifth to the top fifth are entrepreneurs; only 1.3 per cent attended elite universities. But that rise is harder than it used to be. The pass-through owners are very active in politics, both at the federal level—where decamillionaires hold twelve per

cent of congressional seats, despite representing less than one per cent of the U.S. population—and at the state level, which, Zidar and Zwick point out, is another huge focus of lobbying money. A consistent theme in their political activity has been to pull up the drawbridge and make it harder for new entrepreneurs to get rich in the same ways.

The free-market economy of the U.S. has, when you look closely, a remarkable number of restrictive practices, many of them concentrated in industries where the Main Street Millionaires got rich. Beer distribution—the highly lucrative and highly protected intermediary industry between brewers and bars—is one. Car dealerships are another. In both cases, legal protections designed to defend the little guy against bullies—the brewers, the car manufacturers—ended up creating a new category of bully. The same logic extends to the labor market. Around eighteen per cent of American workers, one survey found, are bound by non-compete agreements. It is hard to see why a janitor should need one, unless you run a company that supplies janitorial services. As Rabbit's son explains to him, the secret to wealth in America is that “you just get yourself in the right position and it *comes*.”

Realtors have also done a sensational job of defending their throne. “While 90 percent of homebuyers now find properties online, nearly 90 percent of them still use agents to buy their homes,” Zidar and Zwick write. Agents typically collect a five to six per cent commission rate per sale. That comes to about a hundred billion dollars a year. Uncoincidentally, the National Association of Realtors “spent more on federal lobbying than any other U.S. company or organization during the 2024 electoral cycle.”

Doctors are heavily represented among Main Street Millionaires and have the political clout to show for it. Doctors' lobbying organizations, fearing a glut of clinicians, fought for limits on the number being trained, and the 1997 Balanced Budget Act capped the residency positions for which most teaching hospitals could receive Medicare funding at roughly their 1996 levels. “By 2017, the number of doctors per thousand people in the United States was 2.6, nearly 30 percent lower than the average of 3.5 in other advanced economies,” Zidar and Zwick write.

Organized medicine also fought efforts to restrain what Medicare paid physicians. A formula introduced in 1997, the Sustainable Growth Rate, was meant to keep Medicare spending on doctors from outrunning the economy. It produced a 4.8-per-cent cut in physician payment rates in 2002 and called for at least another round of cuts thereafter. Congress repeatedly postponed those cuts in what became known as the annual “doc fix,” until a bipartisan law signed by President Obama in 2015 abolished the formula.

Perhaps the biggest single accomplishment of concerted Main Street Millionaire lobbying came with President Trump’s Tax Cuts and Jobs Act of 2017, which lowered the corporate tax rate considerably below the top individual rate. Led by Senator Ron Johnson, who co-founded and held shares in a plastics company—“I just have in my heart a real affinity for these owner-operated pass-throughs”—the effort produced a new rule allowing eligible pass-through owners to deduct up to twenty per cent of their qualified business income. The cost to the federal government during the next ten years was estimated at four hundred and fifteen billion dollars. The victory proved durable. In 2025, Trump’s One Big Beautiful Bill Act made permanent and enhanced the pass-through deduction even as it phased out federal tax credits for clean vehicles, a blow to Elon Musk. It’s difficult to argue with Zidar and Zwick’s conclusion that “the obsession with Big Banks, Big Oil, and Big Tech . . . diverts attention from how much local market power Main Street Millionaires and their so-called small businesses have amassed, as well as the social costs of policies that protect their power.”

Zidar and Zwick have some suggestions for how to change this. You might expect them to emphasize access to capital and to higher education, especially for the minority groups they show to be underrepresented among Main Street Millionaires. Instead, they stress connections, networks, and early exposure to entrepreneurs. With starting a business, as with so much else, seeing someone do it makes you likelier to do it yourself.

On inequality more generally, their prescriptions are similar to everyone else’s—reform health insurance, raise the minimum wage, share more profits with workers. That such proposals, far from outlandish, seem so unlikely to be enacted is itself a measure of how far the center of policy

debate has shifted. In the short term, the best we can probably do about this concentration of wealth and power is see it and name it, and that's what Zidar and Zwick have done. I suspect we will be hearing much more about their work and its implications. Rabbit would be displeased. "I don't *think* about politics," he once said. "That's one of my Goddam precious American rights, not to think about politics." ♦

[John Lanchester](#) has written for *The New Yorker* since 1995. He is a contributing editor at the *London Review of Books*, and is the author of the novel "[Look What You Made Me Do](#)," among other books.

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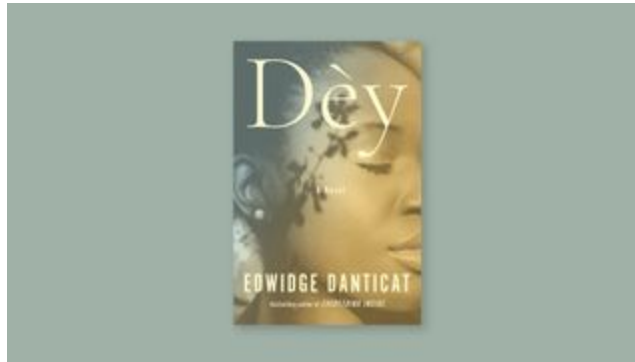
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Briefly Noted

“Dèy,” “Etna,” “Are They Dead Yet?,” and “Unbelonging.”

September 14, 2026



Dèy, by Edwidge Danticat (Knopf). Set among Haitian Americans in Miami, this novel centers on Magnolia, a young mother who is at a mall when a mass shooter opens fire. She escapes and, because she does not want to be defined by the tragedy, decides not to tell anyone about it. In the weeks that follow, Magnolia plans her daughter’s birthday, negotiates her relationship with her daughter’s father, and coördinates medical care for her aging parents, who are living in Haiti amid growing violence. This fascinatingly banal aftermath forces the reader to confront the normalcy of such horror in a world where approximately seven per cent of American adults have been at the scene of a mass shooting. Danticat asks, Is gun violence newsworthy anymore? Or is it everyday life?



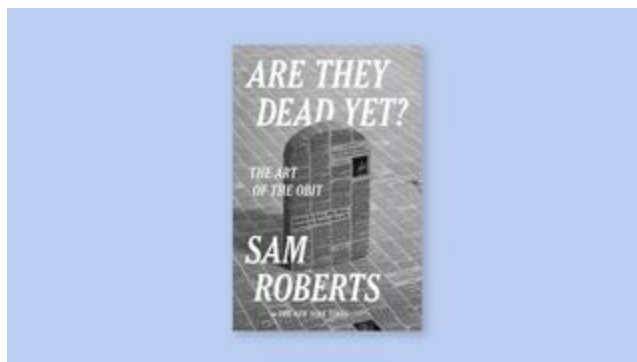
Etna, by *Paul Yoon* (Scribner). This novel's narrator is a dog who lives on a farm in a nameless country that is descending into war. One day, a woman arrives who can speak with him telepathically; she names him Etna and takes him to be trained by American soldiers as a combat dog. After years of conflict, Etna is a grizzled veteran who knows how to search for explosives and how to kill. But, when the war ends, the world as he knew it has been destroyed. He abandons his handlers and wanders the wasted land, searching for any home that might be left. Yoon's choice to plant his sparsely written novel in a canine perspective reveals the devastation that human aggression can inflict on all creatures.

What We're Reading



Illustration by Henri Campeã

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Are They Dead Yet?, by *Sam Roberts* (Bloomsbury). “Writing obituaries is not a job for the faint of heart, nor the heartless,” Roberts announces early in this pithy and engaging survey of what he calls “the dead beat.” Roberts, who has written more than sixteen hundred obituaries, retraces the origins of the form (in ancient Rome) and the emergence of the modern newspaper obituary (in the eighteenth century). As he describes the process by which

writers and editors decide who among the “more than 150,000 or so people who die each day around the world qualify to be immortalized in the *Times*,” he demonstrates how and why obituaries “demand a degree of empathy not required of, say, political reporting or restaurant reviews.”



Unbelonging, by Catherine Jagoe (Wisconsin). This sensitively observed essay collection, by a translator of Spanish literature, considers the elusive nature of home. “Defining home, identifying a homeland, feeling at home. I just can’t seem to manage it,” Jagoe writes. In trying, however, she ranges elegantly across experiences, from the ecstasy of swimming to the “deep, dark wintering” of depression. The act of patiently noticing the physical world runs through the book. In Madrid, she reëncounters the “upland light, landscape, and air” of Nigeria, where she lived as a small child; and though southern Wisconsin, where she lives today, lacks the “transparent, haunting fragrance” of wild bluebells in the woods of England, her country of birth, she discovers a place for herself there nonetheless, through close engagement with the landscape.

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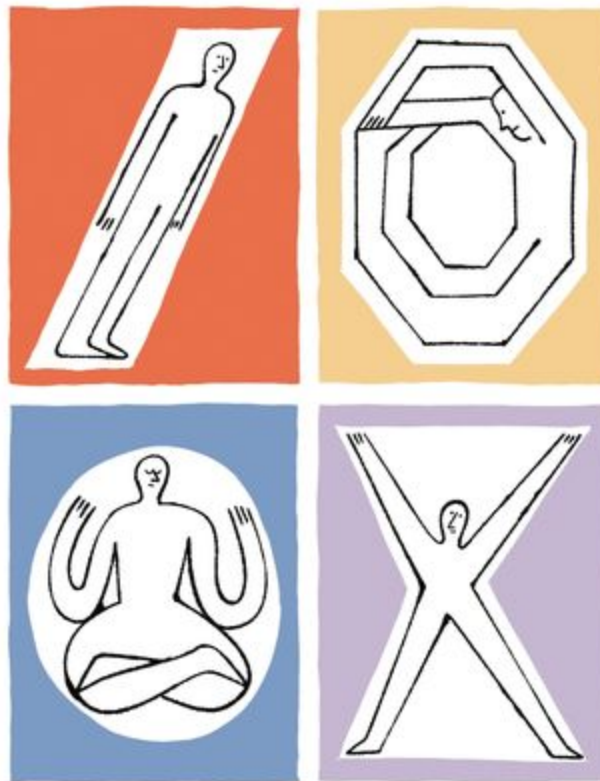
[Books](#)

Is Will Power Overrated?

In “Situated,” Angela Duckworth challenges the conventional wisdom that says we shouldn’t run away from our problems.

By [Meghan O’Gieblyn](#)

September 14, 2026



In a new book, Angela Duckworth, the author of “Grit,” argues that simply trying hard is rarely enough. Illustration by Lourenço Providência

What the weak-willed lack in discipline, they make up for in ingenuity. Although the story of Odysseus binding himself to the mast to resist the Sirens’ song may belong to the mythical imagination, plenty of desperate souls have gone to heroic lengths to obstruct their wayward desires. Plutarch claims that Demosthenes shaved half his head so that he’d be too ashamed to leave his study in search of distraction. Twenty-four centuries

later, Jonathan Franzen destroyed his laptop's Ethernet port so he wouldn't be tempted to go online. "*PROTECT ME FROM WHAT I WANT*," the artist Jenny Holzer once blazoned over Times Square, articulating a self-alienation recognizable to anyone who has downloaded a focus app or taken a dose of Antabuse before meeting friends at a bar. Casinos offer voluntary self-exclusion programs for compulsive gamblers; birth plans allow devotees of natural labor to deny their future selves an epidural. The activist Zelda Gamson kicked a nicotine addiction by swearing that if she smoked another cigarette she'd donate five thousand dollars to the Ku Klux Klan.

These self-binding tactics, sometimes known as "Ulysses pacts" or "commitment devices," attempt to solve what ancient Greek philosophers called *akrasia*, the baffling human tendency to act contrary to our higher aspirations. If the resolutions you make in a "cool" state cannot survive the "hot" state of desire, there are any number of hacks—physical barriers, peer pressure—that can keep you from succumbing, or help you avoid the battle entirely. So contends Angela Duckworth in her new book, "[Situated](#)," which promises the secret to conquering temptation "without willpower." Duckworth, a psychologist at the University of Pennsylvania who studies self-control, believes we put far too much stock in brute effort; success and personal growth largely depend on the "situation" we inhabit—our community, our associates, the spaces in which we work and live. While the book offers many tips about how to trick yourself into sticking with your goals, it ultimately advocates a far more extensive form of self-binding, arguing that it's possible to strategically engineer one's entire life so as to make success more likely, without struggle. "Of all the ways you can change your behavior," she writes, "willpower is the absolute worst."

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This conclusion will likely confound anyone familiar with Duckworth's previous work. For the past two decades, her name has been synonymous with "grit," a concept she began writing about in 2007, then popularized in her 2016 best-seller, "[Grit: The Power of Passion and Perseverance](#)." "Grit" is essentially will power sustained over time; Duckworth researched high achievers and found that it was a better indicator of success than I.Q. and was a skill that could be learned. The term caught fire among school reformers and earned her a MacArthur "genius" grant. Duckworth also faced backlash from critics who argued that her message was, at best, a series of hollow exhortations to simply try harder and, at worst, an insidious form of victim-blaming that ignored structural inequality. (As one lecturer at the Harvard Graduate School of Education put it, in 2015, "Grittiness is often situational.")

High-profile authors are obviously under pressure to offer novel frameworks, but rarely do these second acts feel like an about-face. Duckworth insists that "Situated" is not a reversal but an expansion of her earlier research; as an account of individual success, grit is "necessary but not sufficient," and must be complemented by the larger picture. That explanation turns out to be tenuous, but, in its attempt to address the problem of conflicting desires, "Situated" reveals some of the paradoxes inherent in the prevailing beliefs about will power and self-control.

While "grit" may be the most enduring buzzword of its era, Duckworth was one of many popular psychologists in the aughts and twenty-tens who argued that it was possible to white-knuckle your way to success. Roy Baumeister's "ego-depletion theory" posited that will power was a muscle you could strengthen; Carol Dweck's "growth mindset" maintained that personal success came down to positive self-talk, a conclusion in tune with the relentless work ethic of the gig economy, sometimes called the "grindset." These theories and other will-power research ran into replication difficulties a decade ago. The grit literature failed to replicate in a 2017 meta-analysis, which found that the effects of grit were exaggerated and that the concept was nearly identical to "conscientiousness," one of the Big Five personality traits that psychologists have studied for decades and that are widely thought to be fixed. Duckworth acknowledged that this critique

was valid and said she aspires “to be a scientist who remains open to criticism.”

In the years since grit’s heyday, much of American culture has succumbed to a state of emotional and spiritual defeat. The A.I. tools that promised to lighten workloads have intensified many jobs while eliminating others; the chaos of two Donald Trump Administrations and a global pandemic have engendered various neologisms for exhaustion (“coasting culture,” “quiet quitting”). At a moment when “doing nothing” has become a form of resistance, the skepticism about muscling through marks a discernible vibe shift—or perhaps a generational passing of the baton, the Gen X “Just Do It” ceding to the millennial “I can’t even.”

In recent years, a flurry of popular psychology books—including James Clear’s “[Atomic Habits](#)” and Benjamin Hardy’s “[Willpower Doesn’t Work](#)”—have dismissed will power as ineffective and looked instead at how environmental cues influence decision-making. Duckworth, meanwhile, has been co-authoring papers with titles like “Beyond Willpower,” and proposing complementary strategies drawn from choice architecture and nudge theory, friendly rebrands of social engineering. She now co-directs the Behavior Change for Good Initiative (B.C.F.G.) at the Wharton School, which partners with major corporations to study, for example, whether e-mail reminders can get bank customers to save more. Cass Sunstein, an originator of nudge theory and a colleague of Duckworth’s at B.C.F.G., has argued that people are, by default, “somewhat mindless, passive decision-makers,” and that corporations and governments should design environments that prod them, sometimes unconsciously, toward better choices.

In “Situated,” Duckworth claims that individuals can harness these techniques to achieve personal goals—that it’s possible to “nudge thyself.” “Want to read more books? Keep books on your nightstand,” she writes. “Watch less TV? Cancel a streaming subscription.” In short, if you’re the kind of person who would fail the marshmallow test, don’t keep marshmallows in the house. Since “Grit,” Duckworth writes, “my curiosity has taken me from what goes on inside the minds of high achievers to everything and everyone around them.” The foundation of this new focus is

the three-box model, a “revolutionary” framework on which she collaborated with the Stanford psychologist James Gross: the first box is the “situation,” the objective circumstances you find yourself in; the second box represents “thoughts,” or how you mentally appraise your situation; the third box is your “response,” the emotions and actions that flow from the previous two boxes.

Imagine you’re at Thanksgiving dinner and your brother-in-law starts spouting opinions you find objectionable. It’s almost impossible, Duckworth argues, to will yourself not to feel anger—that is, to change your emotional response (Box Three). It might be more effective to change your thinking (Box Two) by mentally reframing the situation. “Instead of thinking, My brother-in-law is an idiot,” Duckworth writes, “you might consider, I don’t have the same view. What does he see that I don’t?” But the best strategy is an earlier intervention: engineer a situation (Box One) that circumvents this battle entirely. Choose a seat far from your brother-in-law or excuse yourself to help with the dishes. The problem with will power, Duckworth writes, is that it attacks the problem “at the last possible moment.” The goal is to create a system that automatically elicits the desired response “without any (Box Two) thinking at all.”

Duckworth’s advice to avoid temptation is sound enough. Few of us have the steely resolve of Dwight Eisenhower, who kept his pockets stuffed with cigarettes long after he’d quit, because handing them out to others gave him “a feeling of accomplishment and superiority.” But self-binding tactics are hardly foolproof. Thomas Schelling, the economist who pioneered commitment devices, wrote about the “tortured reasoning” that led him to create work-arounds to his own rules when trying to quit smoking: having promised himself tobacco only after the “evening meal,” he quickly found loopholes—international flights, a token midafternoon sandwich. Once, in the throes of a news addiction, I deactivated my phone’s browser only to discover that I could access the *Times* home page by locating the paper’s headquarters on Google Maps.

What about more drastic changes to your environment? The most surefire way to spur growth, Duckworth asserts, is to change where you work and live. She looks to high achievers such as Taylor Swift and the Olympic

swimmer Léon Marchand who, as teen-agers, moved to different cities (Nashville, Tempe) so they could pursue their dreams among like-minded strivers. She cites studies suggesting that people who move to more walkable towns take more than a thousand additional steps per day. She and her husband made a move of this sort, from the suburbs of Philadelphia to a pedestrian-friendly neighborhood in the city. “We’ll move if priorities change again, and if, in a different place, getting what we want most out of life is easier,” she writes.

For all its attempts to disavow the cult of effort, “Situated” will likely rankle the same critics who accused “Grit” of advocating a crude bootstrap logic. “Very often, the greatest obstacle to getting situated has nothing to do with money or privilege or power,” Duckworth writes. “Rather, it’s assuming it can’t be done.” A major impediment to goal fulfillment, she contends, is “status quo bias,” our preference for things to stay the same. She cites David Foster Wallace’s 2005 commencement speech at Kenyon College, [“This Is Water,”](#) which opens with a parable in which a young fish is asked “How’s the water?” and replies, “What the hell is water?” The story, she argues, illustrates how difficult it is to practice “situational awareness,” the art of seeing how our environment, and other people, inflect our behavior. Duckworth peppers her book with aphorisms about the importance of collaboration and community: “the real hero’s journey is from ‘I’ to ‘we.’ ” Or: “If you want to go fast, go alone. If you want to go far, go together.” She also suggests that personal growth requires constantly uprooting oneself and challenges the common wisdom that you cannot run away from your problems. Duckworth considers this objection, but her response is tautological: “Wherever you go, there you are—so choose where you go wisely.”

This tautology arguably lies at the very heart of Duckworth’s book. If motivation is conditioned by environment, then all you have to do is change your situation to get what you want out of life. But the decision to change one’s environment is presumably itself subject to some previous desire. “A man can do what he will, but not will what he will,” Arthur Schopenhauer wrote. We can pursue our desires, in other words, but our desires themselves are shaped by our environment and our personal history—a problem that extends backward ad infinitum. Duckworth sees this

recursiveness as a virtuous circle that can be harnessed to one's advantage: change your situation, and you change your thoughts and desires—which changes your actions, leading to better situations, better thoughts and desires, and so on. This framework, which she calls a “flywheel,” is presented with utter authority and an accompanying diagram, and no acknowledgment that it can also work in reverse.

It's hard to spend much time with “Situated” without sensing a sleight of hand. Although the book insists on the futility of will power, it offers a vision of human agency that is virtually omnipotent, capable of defying all obstacles—class, geography, milieu—and drafting peers into the supporting cast of one's own heroic narrative. Duckworth calls it “situational agency.” In a 2024 interview, riffing on the famous line from William Henley's poem “Invictus” (“I am the master of my fate, / I am the captain of my soul”), she offered a slight amendment to the poem's message: “The seas that you decide to sail are part of your agency, too.”

Duckworth has said that her interest in situational agency stems from the story of her mother's life, which she tells in the book's epilogue. As a young woman coming of age in Taiwan, her mother was a talented painter, but she gave up art after immigrating to the United States and entering into an unhappy marriage with Duckworth's father—who was “a bit of a tyrant,” per Duckworth. Her mother assumed that it was her duty to make her husband happy; rather than change her situation, she believed that “the only thing you can control is what's inside your mind.” It wasn't until the age of eighty-seven that she finally got a room of her own, in a senior-living community, where she has returned to painting. The story is meant to illustrate the psychic cost of trying to change yourself, rather than your circumstances, though it ends on a hopeful note: “It's never too late to reimagine, and then reshape, your situation.”

It's not the only story of an unhappy marriage in “Situated.” In the book's most personal chapter, Duckworth writes about a crisis she and her husband, Jason, experienced almost two decades ago. Both were working demanding jobs while raising two daughters. On the brink of burnout, Duckworth announced that she was done with the marriage. Jason vowed to try harder, but she insisted they had both tried as hard as they could. Instead

of separating, however, they asked for help from their parents and closest friends. They started going to therapy and adjusted their life style to include more sleep and exercise. Today, Jason refers to their marriage as his proudest accomplishment. Rather than willing themselves to try harder, they changed their relationship “from the outside in.”

It’s a powerful and engrossing story. Duckworth has said that she doesn’t see herself as a writer, but throughout her two books she draws on her personal life with the practiced vulnerability of a memoirist. Still, the story stands in stark relief to the book’s celebration of high achievers who uproot themselves. The reader is left to wonder: If your marriage is holding you back, shouldn’t you leave the situation? I suppose that a marriage vow counts as a commitment device, one of the few that are designed to last one’s entire life. The person who promises to love their spouse “for better or for worse” is not unlike Odysseus lashing himself to the mast, insuring that his future self complies with the commitment, despite the siren call of future desires.

Duckworth does not discuss the two marriage stories in tandem, but, taken together, they underscore the conceptual fuzziness of the “situation,” which Duckworth defines as “quite literally everyone and everything around you. All of it.” All of it? But then how do you know whether the problem is your marriage, as with Duckworth’s mother, or the conditions that inflect it, as with Duckworth? When is a relationship salvageable, and when is it time to jump ship?

For all its bluster about the futility of will power, what “Situated” is actually wary of is thinking. “Your thoughts matter, of course,” Duckworth reassures us, but, throughout the book, the mind is a middleman who can be cut out of the picture. She quotes William James on “the effortless custody of automatism” and invokes the usefulness of “neural autopilot.” When you use your situation to change behavior, she writes, “your brain eventually stops deliberating and starts automating.”

It’s true that those of us prone to compulsive behaviors can benefit from ignoring our thoughts in the crucible of temptation, a warning distilled in many twelve-step clichés. (“My best thinking got me here.”) That solution lands differently, however, when it comes to the ordinary friction that

characterizes our relations with others. As I read “Situated,” my mind kept drifting back to the Thanksgiving-dinner scenario of the brother-in-law with cringey politics. Although Duckworth ultimately recommends the Box One solution, she admits that she initially found mental reappraisal (Box Two) compelling: “You could think about all the qualities you like about your brother-in-law. Or recall the favors he’s done for you in the past.”

This is, as it happens, precisely the kind of mental reorientation that Wallace recommends in “This Is Water,” which describes a situational awareness that differs significantly from Duckworth’s. His point is that the only way to avoid spiritual death amid the inevitable petty trials of adult life is to deliberately fight “the automatic, unconscious belief that I am the center of the world” and endeavor to see the whole picture. If you’re cut off in traffic, you can conclude that the person who’s inconvenienced you is just an asshole. Or you can consider the possible reasons for his behavior. He might be a father rushing his injured son to the hospital, in which case “it is actually I who am in HIS way.”

In social psychology, this failure to consider the situations of others is called the fundamental attribution error. Of course, the notion that self-interest clouds our perception of reality was not invented by modern psychology; it has a long lineage in philosophy and religion. “Since time immemorial, philosophers, coaches, and parents have advised looking within, not without, in order to succeed,” Duckworth notes. But she is suspicious and, at times, dismissive of this wisdom, which she sums up with familiar dictums, such as “Mind over matter.”

But mantras like “Mind over matter” connote a rigid approach that is quite different from the reflective, imaginative thinking that belongs to Box Two. In fact, it’s arguable that attention to one’s thoughts, and to their limitations, offers a more reliable alternative to brute effort when it comes to personal change. The novelist and philosopher Iris Murdoch argued that the slow, daily work of cultivating good attachments and trying to see reality clearly is more effective than will power. “At crucial moments of choice, most of the business of choosing is already over,” she writes, a conclusion that is echoed by Duckworth’s observation that will power attacks the problem “at the last possible moment.” For Murdoch, though, the solution was not to

avoid difficult situations but to attune the mind to one's higher values, combatting the predictable patterns of the "fat, relentless ego" that frequently obstruct self-transcendence.

"One is often compelled almost automatically by what one can see," Murdoch writes in her 1970 essay "[The Sovereignty of Good](#)." The work of a moral life, then, is to expand the field of vision. Murdoch considers a mother who finds her daughter-in-law uncouth but realizes one day that her judgment might be unfair. Perhaps her daughter-in-law is not vulgar but, rather, simple and spontaneous? It's a small correction, one that happens entirely in the mind. But such choices about what to think about, what to attend to, cumulatively build the kind of character capable of acting in accordance with itself: "We act rightly 'when the time comes' not out of strength of will but out of the quality of our usual attachments."

Murdoch was writing in the long shadow of behaviorism, at a time when science and philosophy had so thoroughly abandoned the inner life that she felt compelled to defend the seemingly obvious point that self-questioning constitutes a moral action—that the mother-in-law who labors to change her thoughts "has been doing something." Duckworth would likely argue that situational awareness requires thinking, too: assessing one's environment, taking stock of the external factors that prevent you from fulfilling your desires. What it does not ask you to do, however, is to question whether your desires are fair or just—or are even your own.

The problem of *akrasia* exists because humans, unlike other animals (or, at present, machines), have second-order volitions—the preference to have different preferences. This doubleness arises from "the capacity for reflective self-evaluation," as the philosopher Harry Frankfurt puts it. For Frankfurt, as for Murdoch, the work of being human involves interrogating the motives and assumptions that guide our actions, asking whether our desires are truly desirable. To refuse this work is to be a "wanton," he argues, someone who is less a person than an animal—or, one might add, like an algorithm following a script. It is to fall prey to an older form of bondage, one that the Stoics called *stultitia* ("fickleness and boredom and a continual shifting of purpose," as Seneca put it) and that Buddhists refer to

as *samsara*, an endless cycle of craving and restlessness that is never satisfied.

Self-interrogation, of course, is often unpleasant and is not a prescription that is likely to sell many books. But the alternative—the freedom to perpetually abandon difficult circumstances—is, in the long run, the more wearying path. One could argue, in fact, that the current popularity of self-binding is a response to the anxiety and exhaustion many of us feel amid the relentless invitations to reimagine our lives. We have more opportunities than ever to eject ourselves from trying situations. Peers can be unfriended; politicians can be unfollowed. Marriages are easily dissolved, and jobs are no longer meant to last your entire life. The ropes that tie us to the mast are made of straw. Although Duckworth presents situational agency as a revolutionary form of self-mastery, it may be another instance of status-quo bias, cleverly disguised. It is simply the water in which we swim. ♦

[Meghan O’Gieblyn](#) is the author of the memoir “[Will and Attention](#),” among other books.

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Poems

- **[“Driveway”](#)**

By Stephanie Horvath | “In the gut, / In the mouth, / In the irreducible / ‘Bile’ humor.”

- **[“Late September”](#)**

By Jodie Hollander | “Now the air / is darker; my garden plots are empty.”

[Poems](#)

Driveway

By [Stephanie Horvath](#)

September 13, 2026

In the gut,
In the mouth,
In the irreducible
 "Bile" humor,
In the middle
 Of the melancholic rainbow,
The green best friend,
The meat seen, in the
Throw-up, pink,
In the irreducible mouth,
In the phrase "didn't like,"
In the outstretched palm
Beside the bull's head,
In the disposable razor's
 Singular softness,
In the overstayed shower,
In the overstayed sober, weak
With few walks and perpetually
 Fogged windows,
In the salty food,
In the heartburn disguising
 The heartache in the
Eventual mouth,
 In the evidential upchuck
 Of the beautiful best friend,
In the last hour,
In the medicine one shan't

Have taken,
In the pigeon ooze,
In the cradle of straw
The crow curves upon,
In the ride to town,
In the unlevel graveyard ground,
In the fire
In the dream
About the people
Lighting themselves
On fire,
On lightning, and lack
Of memory,
In the right way,
The soft light,
The voltage, the numeral,
The hand traced to look
Like a turkey,
In the poor posture,
And the sad mood to prove it,
In the best friend,
In the driveway,
Where caterpillars
Flee tires,
Where the earth shakes
To warn them,
In the ride back from town,
In the medical marijuana,
In the grass-fed butter,
Bring the soul back bring the
Soul back bring the soul
Back bring the soul back, she said.

This is drawn from “[Field of Vision](#).”

[Stephanie Horvath](#) is the author of the poetry collection “[Field of Vision](#).”

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[Poems](#)

Late September

By [Jodie Hollander](#)

September 13, 2026

Now the wind chimes are chiming earlier,
chiming colder in the neighborhood;
the sun is smaller and the birds are fewer,
much fewer in the backyard. Now the air
is darker; my garden plots are empty.
Now I sleep with the windows closed,
and wake to silence. Then what is there?
Only thoughts: soon the pines will be
dropping needles; soon snow will be
visible on the peaks, then more snow
will silence the town—just the sound
of the wind moving through bare trees,
the sadness of a January sky. Perhaps
there are thoughts pushing toward
summer (always there are thoughts), but
where else to go when the wind chimes
begin chiming earlier, chiming colder,
when the sun suddenly grows smaller,
if not for thinking of the smell of the soil
after a June rain, picturing the tomatoes
vivid in the sunlight, or imagining opening
the screen door and stepping out into
the garden, only to find oneself lost
in a crowd of bright orange marigolds?

[Jodie Hollander](#) is the author of the poetry collections “[Nocturne](#)” and “[My Dark Horses](#).”

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By Wyna Liu | A moderately challenging puzzle.

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The Crossword: Tuesday, September 8, 2026

A moderately challenging puzzle.

By [Wyna Liu](#)

September 8, 2026

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[Wyna Liu](#), a puzzle editor at the New York Times and the writer of its game Connections, began contributing to The New Yorker in 2020.

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